

The Indian EXPRESS

NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 18 PAGES

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

₹7.00 (₹8 RAIPUR, ₹15 SRINAGAR) • www.indianexpress.com

DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

Life of Middle Class Made Easier



Annual income up to **₹12.75 lakh** tax-free

Affordable air travel for **1.6+ crore** passengers under the **UDAN Scheme**

Metro connectivity expanded from **5 cities** to **26 cities**

12 *Vishwas ke, Vikas ke, Jan-Kalyan ke*



Government of Bharat

CBC 44101/13/0003/2627

Happening today

● **NOIDA INTERNATIONAL** Airport (code DXN) begins its commercial flight operations. The first arrival will be an IndiGo flight from Lucknow.

TRACK THIS AND MORE ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

IDEA EXCHANGE

KIREN RIJU

UNION MINISTER OF PARLIAMENTARY AFFAIRS AND MINORITY AFFAIRS

PAGE 16

TMC rebel MPs meet Birla, say have merged with a regional party

Manoj C G & Asad Rehman
New Delhi, June 14

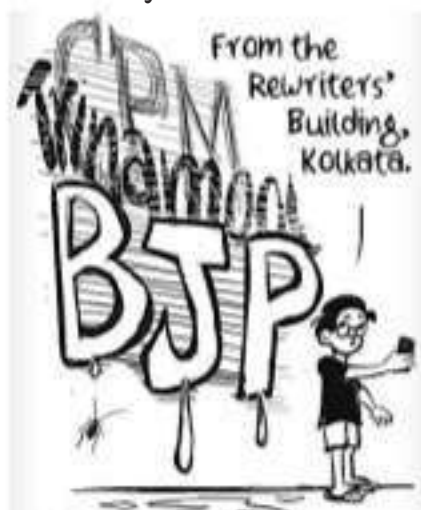
CLAIMING THE support of 20 of the Trinamool Congress's (TMC) 28 Lok Sabha members, the party's rebel MPs on Sunday announced their merger with an outfit called the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI) and met Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla seeking a separate seating arrangement in the House.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

RELATED REPORTS, **PAGE 6**

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY

From the *Rewriters' Building, Kolkata.*

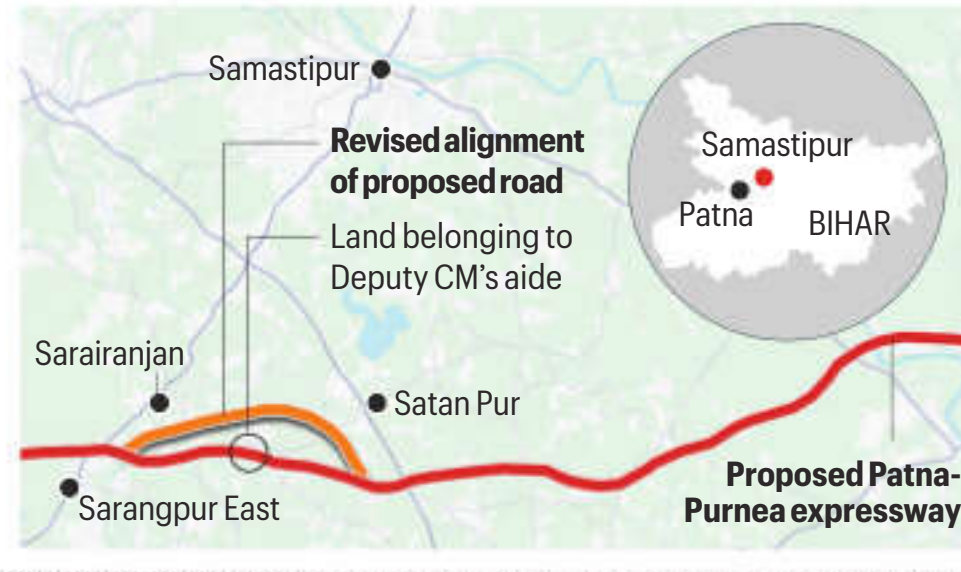


Bihar: Residents say expressway plan altered to spare Dy CM aide's land

Santosh Singh
Patna, June 14

A ROW is simmering in the Sarairanjan block of Bihar's Samastipur district over the route alignment of the central government's ambitious Patna-Purnea Greenfield Expressway, with local residents writing to the Union Minister for Road Transport and Highways

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



UPI AT NICE, PARIS AIRPORTS: MISRI

Trade to AI: India, France set new targets

Modi-Macron meeting: Plan to double trade in 5 yrs, adopt 'Innovation Roadmap 2030'

Shubhajt Roy
New Delhi, June 14

A MECHANISM to double annual bilateral trade from the existing \$16 billion in five years; an India-France Innovation Roadmap 2030; a joint working group focussed on AI (artificial intelligence) governance; an economic security dialogue; increased cooperation on defence and space — these were among the key outcomes of the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



PM Narendra Modi with French President Emmanuel Macron in Nice, France, Sunday. X/@ELYSEE

In NCERT Art textbook, 'Dancing Girl' covered up

Ritika Chopra
Mumbai, June 14

AN IMAGE of one of the most recognisable artefacts of the Indus Valley Civilisation, the iconic "Dancing Girl" of Mohenjo-daro, appears in a new avatar in an NCERT textbook —



The photo with masked torso in the new arts education textbook for Class 9; (right) the photo in the new Class 6 Social Science textbook

Israel hits Beirut, Trump says deal close, 'all sides should stand down'

Parisa Hafezi & Phil Stewart
Dubai, Washington, June 14

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump criticised an Israeli strike on Lebanon that could complicate attempts to finalise a framework

deal between the United States and Iran on Sunday on ending their war, but said an agreement was nonetheless close.

Iranian negotiator Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf said Israel's

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

സംസ്ഥാന സർക്കാർ ഇനിര ഗ്യാരണ്ടി പ്രകാരമുള്ള പ്രിയദർശിനി സ്ത്രീ സൗജന്യ യാത്രാ പദ്ധതി

സ്ത്രീ ശാക്തീകരണ പുതുയുഗയാത്രയ്ക്ക് കെഎസ്ആർടിസിയിലൂടെ ശുഭാരംഭം

സംസ്ഥാനതല ഉദ്ഘാടനം **ശ്രീ.വി.ഡി.സതീശൻ** (ബഹു.കേരള മുഖ്യമന്ത്രി)

പ്രിയദർശിനി സൗജന്യ യാത്ര

ജൂൺ 15 തീയതി രാവിലെ 08.30 ന് തിരുവനന്തപുരം സെൻട്രൽ ബസ് സ്റ്റേഷനിൽ



4 jump onto tracks from MP Intercity Express after fire rumour, run over by another train

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, June 14

A RUMOUR of a fire aboard the Khajuraho-Udaipur Intercity Express train triggered panic among passengers in Madhya Pradesh's Morena district on Sunday, leading to a tragic chain of events that culminated in at least four people, including children, being killed after being struck by another train.

The incident occurred near Hetampur railway station in the Jhansi division of North Central Railway at around 4.15 pm, when passengers travelling in the Intercity Express reportedly began shouting that a fire had broken out inside the train.

According to railway officials and eyewitness accounts, no fire was subsequently found on the train. However, the alarm chain was pulled in one of the general coaches, bringing the train to a halt between Hetampur and Dholpur stations.

Anirudh Kumar, DRM, Jhansi Railway Division, said preliminary inquiries had found no evidence of a fire aboard the train. According to officials, the curved alignment of the track may have limited the visibility of the approaching Pataalkot Express for passengers who had descended onto the railway line. Railway authorities said the locomotive pilot attempted emergency braking but was unable to stop the train in time.

"The Khajuraho-Udaipur Intercity train had stopped after chain-pulling, and some passengers, including women and

children, got down. At the same time, the Pataalkot Express was approaching from Agra on the adjacent curved track. Due to the curve, those on the track may not have seen the train. Despite the driver's attempt to apply emergency brakes, the train, moving at high speed, ran over them. So far, reports confirm the deaths of three women and one child," Kumar said.

Following the rumour of a fire in Intercity Express, panic spread through the coaches, and passengers rushed to disembark. Several people jumped from the train and moved onto an adjacent railway track.

Moments later, the Firozpur-Seoni Pataalkot Express approached on those tracks at speed. Before many of those standing on the tracks could react, the train struck them, resulting in multiple fatalities and injuries. Initial reports from local authorities put the death toll at four — three women and a child.

Eyewitnesses said the panic began after confusion among passengers charging mobile phones in one of the coaches. Someone allegedly shouted that a fire had broken out. Within minutes, passengers began moving towards the exits, and some reportedly attempted to jump off even before the train had come to a halt.

"The train was stopped after emergency braking but was unable to stop the train in time.

"The Khajuraho-Udaipur Intercity train had stopped after chain-pulling, and some passengers, including women and

Bodies of six Naga men identified, handover may take time: Manipur minister

Express News Service
Imphal, June 14

MANIPUR HOME Minister Govindas Konthoujam on Sunday said that the identification process of the six Naga men whose bodies were recovered on June 10 has been completed.

The Home Minister told reporters in Imphal, "The bodies have not been handed over so far because the apex Naga body (United Naga Council) has placed certain demands before the Manipur government, which are being examined. It may take some time before the bodies are handed over."

Responding to questions regarding the demand by Naga organisations for the abrogation of the Suspension of Operations (SoO) agreement with Kukli mili-

tant groups, Govindas said the matter does not fall solely within the state government's jurisdiction and that the Government of India is also involved. "So, we are discussing the matter," he said.

The six Naga men, including two pastors, and their family members were kidnapped on May 13 after the killing of three church leaders from the Thadou tribe in an ambush the same day in Kangpokpi district. Twelve people, including women and children, were later released.

At least 44 people were reportedly taken hostage by Kukli and Naga groups. While several of them were released earlier, 14 members of the Kukli community were released last Tuesday.

A day later, forces recovered the bodies of the six missing Naga men.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

India, France

● KEY OUTCOMES

- Adoption of India-France Innovation Roadmap 2030
- Creation of a Joint India-France AI Working Group focused on AI governance
- MoU on establishment of a National Centre of Excellence for Skilling in Aeronautics and Allied Sectors at NSTI, Kanpur
- Expanded possibilities for using India's UPI in France
- Incubation of an additional 10 Indian start-ups at Station F, Paris
- Establishment of a Centre of Digital Sciences between Department of Science and Technology (DST) and Institut National de Recherche en Sciences et Technologies du Numérique (INRIA)
- Establishment of an ICCR India Chair on 'AI, Innovation and Cul-

ture' at Universite Paris-Saclay

- Letter of Intent between Indian Council of Medical Research and Health Data Hub of France
- Setting up a high-level mechanism for realising the goal of doubling bilateral trade in the next five years, building on the existing Economic and Financial Dialogue
- Institution of an Economic Security Dialogue
- Declaration of Intent on cooperation on railway and high-speed railway development in India
- General Security Agreement on the exchange and protection of classified information
- Letter of Intent between ISRO and CNES on cooperation in microgravity research and human space exploration

bilateral meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and French President Emmanuel Macron in Nice, France, on Sunday.

Addressing Macron in a post on X, Modi said: "Nice to have met you in Nice. A productive first leg indeed. The India-France partnership will keep scaling new heights. See you in Evian and Paris."

This was their first meeting since the elevation of India-France ties to a 'special global strategic partnership' earlier this

year.

"The two leaders held extensive discussions covering diverse aspects of bilateral relations," the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said in a statement.

They shared ideas to strengthen and diversify bilateral ties in the fields of economic growth, technology and innovation, talent mobility and people-to-people and cultural exchanges, it said.

In this context, they noted the "steady growth in bilateral trade and agreed to set up a high-level

Trump

attack on the southern suburbs of Beirut, which Israel said targeted Iranian-backed Hezbollah militants, showed the US lacked the will or ability to fulfil its commitments.

Tehran warned of a "strong response", with its top joint military command saying the "finger (is) on the trigger" ready to fire at the "enemy's heart".

In a post on his Truth Social platform, Trump said: "This morning's attack on Beirut should not have happened, particularly on a special day when we are so close to a Peace Deal with Iran."

"We are very close to a Deal that will bring peace to the region, including to Lebanon, and all sides should stand down... Let's not blow it," he wrote.

Israel has said it is not party to the planned US-Iran deal and PM Benjamin Netanyahu has

NCERT

NCERT over what they said was the nude depiction.

The retouched photograph now features in the opening chapter, "History of Arts", of Madhurima — the new arts education textbook for Class 9. In the image, the figurine's torso has been shaded over from the shoulders down, obscuring anatomical details visible in photographs of the original and giving the impression that she is clothed.

The depiction is significant because the "Dancing Girl" has appeared in NCERT textbooks for at least 25 years, including during the NDA government when Murli Manohar Joshi was

in charge of Education as Minister of the then Human Resource Development ministry. A review by this newspaper of earlier editions shows that while the figurine has long featured in school textbooks, its torso had never previously been covered.

The retouched image appears in a textbook that is part of NCERT's first-ever arts education series, introduced from Classes 1 to 10 under the National Education Policy (NEP) and the National Curriculum Framework (NCF) to integrate arts into mainstream education. Textbooks from Classes 1 to 9 have been released so far.

The approximately four-inch-high "Dancing Girl", discovered at Mohenjo-daro, depicts a young girl with her hair tied in a bun, adorned with

Expressway route

(MoRTH), Nitin Gadkari, alleging an "arbitrary and politically motivated" alteration to the expressway's original track along a five-kilometre stretch.

Though the petitioners have not named anyone in their letter sent to Gadkari, dated June 1, more than two dozen home and shop owners claim that the JD(U) MLA from Sarairanjan and current Bihar Deputy Chief Minister, Vijay Kumar Choudhary, influenced the move to benefit a close associate who is also a distant relative. Around 10.5 bighas of land belonging to the person, Vinit Ishwar alias Bobby Ishwar, and his family fell under the original alignment, records show.

The route, if modified, could result in the demolition of over 150 homes and dozens of shops, as well as a section of the 65-year-old Kedar Sant Ramashray College, where over 6,000 students study.

When contacted, Choudhary told *The Indian Express*, "I have not used any political influence. All people from Sarairanjan belong to me. It is entirely up to the NHAI (National Highways Authority of India) to say if they have changed the alignment. It is not my domain."

The Indian Express also spoke to Bobby Ishwar, who said, "Those who have been making allegations of Vijay babu protecting the 10.5 bighas of land in the original alignment must know that six bighas of my land is affected in the current proposed alignment. If influence was used, I could have also saved these six bighas."

NHAI officials and Bihar CM

Samrat Choudhary promised to look into the issue. "Even though it is a central government project, it is the state government that decides the route. We will look into the matter and address concerns of the people," the CM said. "We are asking NHAI and Bihar's Road Construction Department to look into the alleged change in alignment."

NHAI's Bihar Regional Officer N L Yeotkar said that "as per regulations, alignment, once notified, cannot be changed". "I am forwarding the matter to the Chhappra project director. If there is any change in the original alignment, it is a serious matter," he said.

NHAI project director in Chhappra, Raju Kumar, said, "Once the alignment is fixed, it cannot be changed."

Union Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai, who is the MP from Ujjaypur, told *The Indian Express*, "I am aware of the changed alignment issue. I have already met the Union Minister of State, MoRTH, regarding this. I am also taking it up with Union Minister Gadkari to ensure that there is an order from his department for the NHAI to revert to the original alignment to avoid habitable areas."

Residents who stand to lose their homes and shops if the NHAI proceeds with the altered alignment between the 48- and 53-kilometre mark of the proposed expressway said that Choudhary had, in May last year, assured them that their habitation would not be disrupted. In a Facebook post from

mechanism to double it within five years," the MEA said.

"They called for early implementation of the India-EU Free Trade Agreement, which offers a unique opportunity to expand bilateral trade and investment. The leaders also discussed ways to enhance cooperation in the SME, aviation and railway sectors," it said.

The MEA said the two leaders "expressed satisfaction at the excellent growth and depth of bilateral defence collaboration across all domains and agreed to further intensify it with focus on co-design, co-development and co-production of defence platforms and advanced technologies."

"Both leaders noted the rich legacy of cooperation in the space sector and discussed furthering collaboration in human spaceflight and spacesituational awareness. They also discussed ways to expand private sector collaboration in space," the statement said.

Recognising the key role of innovation and technology in the bilateral relationship, the statement said "both sides adopted an 'Innovation Roadmap 2030' to give the partnership a long-term direction".

Both leaders, it said, appreciated the continued expansion of UPI in France, as well as the signing of 19 agreements among institutions linked to the innovation ecosystems of both countries. Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri said that airports in Nice and Paris would now have UPI.

clashed with Trump over US demands that Israel curb military action in Lebanon to allow Washington to reach a deal.

"If you lack the will and ability to fulfil your commitments, speaking of continuing the path is not possible," Qalibaf wrote on X, castigating the US. Trump and mediator Pakistan said on Saturday they expected the deal would be signed on Sunday, the US President's 80th birthday.

An official involved in the talks said on Sunday that medi-

angles, a bracelet and a necklace. Her confident posture and the sophistication of her craftsmanship have made her one of the defining symbols of the Harappan civilisation.

Archaeologists have long viewed the figurine as evidence of the civilisation's advanced metallurgical knowledge. The original is housed in the National Museum in New Delhi.

In an interview with *The Indian Express* published on May 27, historian Michel Danino, who headed the textbook development committee for NCERT's new Class 6 Social Science books, had disclosed that the NCERT objected to placing the "Dancing Girl" on the opening page of a chapter on Indus Valley Civilisation because the figurine was nude and could become

May 8, 2025, Choudhary wrote, "I met people, likely to be affected with Patna-Purnea Expressway project, and heard their grievances. People expressed their concerns with the officials concerned. We will deal with all issues with sensitivity and resolve them amicably."

Choudhary, who was a state minister at the time, had also said that the Deputy Collector Land Reforms would propose a third alternative route to the NHAI. However, that proposal was never submitted, and residents say they only recently learned that the NHAI was proceeding with the altered route when land surveyors began approaching them over the last two months.

The project is currently in its pre-land acquisition stage.

Asked about the May 2025 meeting, Choudhary said, "Some aggrieved people had come to meet me last year. I had directed them to the officials concerned to address their grievances."

Asked how an MLA could make such a promise, Raju Kumar, the NHAI project director in Chhappra, said, "It (the May 2025 meeting) could be for service roads and other concerns. I can say one thing, we stick to the original alignment."

The project, its impact

The proposed six-lane greenfield corridor, spanning 244.93 kilometres with an estimated blueprint cost of Rs 18,000 crore, is designed to reshape north-south connectivity in Bihar. According to NHAI guidelines, greenfield expressways are ideally routed away from densely populated residential zones, prioritising single-crop agricultural lands or

TMC MPs

This came moments after the TMC submitted to the Speaker a letter by its Parliamentary Party leader in the Lok Sabha, Abhishek Banerjee, urging him not to accord "any recognition, status, or facility to any purported separate group or faction of the AITC (All India Trinamool Congress)".

"We 20 MPs, who were elected from the AITC, have met the Speaker and given him a letter urging him to allow us to sit as a separate bloc. And these 20 MPs, who are more than two-thirds (of the TMC's strength in Lok Sabha), this faction, is with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India. We will work for the country and work with the NDA under the leadership of the Prime Minister," TMC MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, who is leading the MPs' revolt, told reporters after the meeting with Birla.

Among the MPs who met the Speaker along with Ghosh Dastidar are Sudip Bandyopadhyay, Satabdi Roy, Yusuf Pathan, Saayoni Ghosh, June Malia, and Jagdip Basunia. The rebel MPs went into a huddle at the official residence of Union Minister Bhupender Yadav, who was the BJP's Bengal poll in-charge, before proceeding to meet the Speaker at his residence.

The rebels' decision to merge with the NCPI appears to be an attempt to avoid attracting the provisions of the anti-defection law and buy time to make the

ators were optimistic the deal was "nearly over the line," and a Kremlin aide said Trump had told Russian President Vladimir Putin by phone on Sunday that a deal was near.

But Tehran cast doubt over the timing even before the strike on Beirut, saying on Saturday that the signing would not be on Sunday though it could happen in the coming days. A senior Iranian official told Reuters that, under the terms of the draft deal, the US would agree to release \$25

"controversial".

"Even told NCERT that if the Dancing Girl is not age-appropriate, then perhaps children of that age should not be allowed into the National Museum either because the figurine is displayed there," Danino had said. While he initially resisted the suggestion, he eventually agreed to move the image from the chapter opener to an inside page and reduce its size. The image, however, was retained in the textbook.

Asked whether the masking of the torso was linked to concerns over nudity, NCERT Director Dinesh Prasad Saklani told *The Indian Express*: "No, I don't think there is any specific reason. In Grade 6 SST (Social Science Textbook), the Dancing Girl is very much there along

open lowlands (chaurs). The proposed expressway will require a 90-metre-wide land corridor and will feature 21 major bridges, 140 minor bridges, and 9 railway overbridges as it cuts through Vaisali, Samastipur, and Madhepura to reach Purnea. It is expected to shorten the travel time between Patna and Purnea from the current eight hours to just four hours.

Local residents say the initial independent survey conducted by the NHAI adhered to these guidelines. The original path was slated to pass seamlessly through the Dhanhar Chaur (lowlands) along the southern borders of Kankalipur and Jhakhra, drawing no objections from the farming community.

However, those who wrote to Gadkari allege that under pressure from "a few politically and socially influential individuals", the project's trajectory was deliberately distorted and a curve was "engineered" into the alignment. This bend steers the massive highway straight into densely populated residential and commercial neighbourhoods, they claimed.

If this modified route is implemented, they say, over 150 homes and dozens of shops and other commercial spaces could be demolished across Sarairanjan Bazar, Kankalipur, and Jhakhra. According to NHAI documents, a section of the main building of the 65-year-old Kedar Sant Ramashray (KSR) College in Sarairanjan could be razed. The intermediate and degree college, which receives aid from the Bihar government, caters to over 6,000 students.

The project documents reviewed by *The Indian Express*



Rebel TMC MPs with Speaker Om Birla in New Delhi, Sunday

E. EXPLAINED

Behind the move

The TMC rebels appear to be trying to buy time with this merger before launching a bid for the status of "real TMC". The party has pointed out, citing the Supreme Court's Subhash Desai judgment, that protection under Paragraph 4 of the Tenth Schedule requires a valid merger involving the original political party as well.

claim to be the "real TMC".

Under Paragraph 4 of the Tenth Schedule, disqualification on the grounds of defection is not applicable in case of merger. The merger of the original political party of a member of a House is deemed to have taken place "if, and only if, not less than two-thirds of the members of the legislature party concerned have agreed to such merger".

"We have merged with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India... It is a recognised regional

party. When you leave with two-thirds of the party, you cannot demand the name of that party on the first day itself ... In July, when Parliament restarts, we will make a demand to give us Trinamool since we have two-thirds majority. Then the court will decide," said Bandyopadhyay.

However, the TMC leadership has cited a 2023 judgment of the SC's Constitution Bench on the Maharashtra political crisis which held that a political party and the legislature party are different entities and that protection under Paragraph 4 requires a valid merger involving the original political party as well. Ritabrata Banerjee, who has been recognised as the Leader of Opposition in Bengal, told *The Indian Express* Sunday that the process to take over the political party was also underway.

"Therefore, assuming without admitting in any manner that two-thirds of the legislative party has switched, there has been no merger of the political party with any party or any creation of a new party called AITC," Abhishek wrote in the letter to Birla dated June 10.

Dahiye neighbourhood of Beirut in an attack that Lebanon's civil defence said killed three people. Israel has said it will retain freedom of operations in Lebanon. Tehran has made a full ceasefire there an important component of its demands.

In Sunday's post, Trump said there "should be no more attacks by Israel anywhere in Lebanon, but there should also be no more attacks by any other party, including Hezbollah, against Israel". REUTERS

billion of frozen Iranian assets, while Tehran would agree not to produce or acquire nuclear weapons.

Qatari negotiators flew to Tehran on Sunday as part of efforts to finalise the agreement, a source with knowledge of the situation told Reuters.

The Israeli military said on Sunday Hezbollah had launched three projectiles towards communities in northern Israel. Israel then fired at what it called Hezbollah targets in the

with many other findings related to Harappan civilisation as it is one of them. For art textbooks you may also contact the related TDT (Textbook Development Team) members."

Sandhya Purecha, chairperson of the Sangeet Natak Akademi and head of the textbook development team for Arts Education, was unavailable for comment.

Commenting on the image used in the Class 9 textbook, Danino said the depiction was "wrong and unfair to the student" and that "the shading of the figure's whole trunk is an act of censorship".

"This picture of the Dancing Girl is unfair to the student. First, it is so tiny that nothing of this remarkable figurine's facial expression or ornaments can be

made out. Second, the shading of her trunk is an act of censorship; unless we wish to return to Victorian morality, such prudishness is misplaced — should students, then, be barred from entering the National Museum, where the original figurine is housed, not to speak of many semi-nude or nude statues of goddesses, apsaras, etc.? Third, this manipulation of the image amounts to creating a fake artefact which exists nowhere. That is just not done," Danino told *The Indian Express*.

Danino is no longer part of NCERT's textbook development committee for Social Science, having stepped down following the controversy over references to corruption and judicial delays in the revised Class 8 Social Science textbook.

ment. She had written, "The changed route would result in the demolition of the Jhakhra college and numerous houses and shops. Please revert to the original alignment." She had red-flagged the issue when she witnessed NHAI officials and the local CO office conducting land surveys on the route.

In the Brahmin-dominated neighbourhoods of Sarairanjan, residents such as Sushil Jha, Dinesh Jha, Umesh Jha, and Kashinath Jha face the prospect of their homes being razed if the NHAI proceeds. Sushil Jha said, "I stand to lose my house, which sits on over eight katha of land. There are at least 15 houses in our immediate vicinity facing demolition."

Parmanand Ishwar, who donated eight acres of land for the construction of the degree college at Jhakhra, said, "We cannot accept this altered alignment, and we will not let our college be destroyed. Even if most of the college building does not fall under the new alignment, its grounds and a portion of the building will be affected. Our MLA owes us an answer." College principal Bipin Jha said, "About 6,000 students are enrolled in the college. The closest degree college in Dalsinghsarai is 20 kilometres away."

Even as public discontent simmers, the administrative machinery is moving rapidly. Records indicate that Samastipur's District Registry Office has already implemented hiked Minimum Valuation Register rates for the affected sectors. Simultaneously, the MoRTH has issued a Central Gazette Notification to formally initiate land acquisition for a 64.7-kilometre stretch running directly through Samastipur district.



EXPRESS EDUCATION

PHYSICS

OPTIONAL
by Renowned
DP Vajpayee Sir

NEW BATCHES
OFFLINE/ONLINE Mode
From 15th JUNE 2026
All India Test Series in
Physics/Chemistry
from 14th June.

319 MARKS
Highest in
Physics
Optional
in CSE 2025

DIAS
DELHI INSTITUTE FOR ADMINISTRATIVE SERVICES
India's Leading Institute for Civil Services Examination

18, PUSA ROAD, KAROL BAGH, NEW DELHI - 110005
www.diasindia.com diasindia0702@gmail.com
Ph: 011-40079000, 35002599, 9350934622

ANTHRO

Classroom Batches: Jun 16, Jun 24

Batch Highlights

- 300+ Answers Prepared & Evaluated
- Test Series Included ➤ 1-to-1 Mentoring
- PYQs Analysis ➤ Full Support Till Success

Recordings Available for Online Students

IAS 2025

Harsh Nehra
AIR 74
303/500

5 OF OUR CLASSROOM STUDENTS SCORED 290+

Anthro Sampooran Test Series
40 Tests | 1-to-1 Mentorship | Model Answer Content

VAID'S ICS, DELHI
For details visit www.vaidsics.com or call 953 800 1600

Contact for Advt. Booking: M/s Friends Publicity Service
(M): 9212665841, 9212008155

ACCUSED ARRIVED IN ONE SCOOTER. SET ANOTHER ON FIRE: POLICE

Tughlakabad blaze that killed 3 'not an accident'

Alok Singh

New Delhi, June 14

TWO DAYS after a fire at a residential building in Southeast Delhi's Tughlakabad Extension claimed three lives, two scooters emerged as crucial evidence in the case. Not only was a minor girl apprehended and three others arrested, but the Delhi Police also found out that the blaze was "not an accident"

The incident occurred around 2.24 am on June 12. The fire rapidly spread from the ground to the fifth floor, trapping residents and triggering panic.

Emergency responders rushed to the scene and rescued several residents. Eight people, who had sustained injuries, were sent to hospitals.

Three of them — Pankaj (28), his sister Soni (20), and their grandmother Sushila Devi (70) — succumbed to their injuries, police said.

Investigators, while scanning CCTV footage, spotted a young girl entering the building premises, her face covered, just seconds before the blaze broke out on the ground floor.

“CCTV footage showed a girl entering and leaving the premises. Around 30 seconds later, an explosion occurred on the ground floor. A flash of flames can be seen in the footage.

Soon after, the girl can be seen leaving the area quietly," a police officer said.

Investigators later found that the masked girl had set a parked scooter on fire, triggering the blaze that engulfed the building.

"The challenge was to identify the masked girl," the officer said.

Multiple teams were tasked with collecting CCTV footage from various locations to track the girl's movements. Investigators found that she had arrived on another scooter. She was riding a pillion while a woman was riding the two-wheeler, they said.

With the help of CCTV footage, police zeroed in on their residences.

The teams subsequently recovered the scooter used in the crime from one of the accused.

The minor girl, later found to be 17-year-old, was apprehended from her residence, police said.

DCP (Southeast) Hemant Tiwari said that during questioning, the juvenile told police that the 27-year-old woman had allegedly instigated her and provided petrol and a matchbox to set the scooter ablaze that belonged to one Deepak, who lives on the fifth floor of the building where the fire later broke out. The girl said there was some "monetary dispute" the DCP said.

The arrested woman, however,

claimed that the conspiracy had been hatched at the behest of her friend and his brother, who allegedly wanted "revenge" as they had a dispute with Deepak. DCP Tiwari said,

According to the police, the woman's friend and his brother have been involved in criminal cases, including robbery and attempted murder. The woman's friend had also been declared a 'Bad Character' by the local police station.

Police also said that Deepak had allegedly borrowed Rs 50,000 from the accused woman a few months ago, but failed to repay on time. "The outstanding amount, along with interest, had risen to Rs 80,000, which the woman wanted back. However, Deepak was allegedly refusing to pay," an officer said.

Sources said investigators are examining if there were other motives, as locals have alleged the sale of drugs and other illegal contraband in the area.

Initially, police had filed a case under BNS sections 287 and 106(1) for negligent conduct and causing death by negligence. "In light of the findings, police have added serious charges under the BNS, including criminal conspiracy, culpable homicide, attempt to commit culpable homicide, mischief by fire, and lurking house-trespass by night," the officer said.

CM leads mega cleanliness drive on Yamuna banks

Devansh Mittal

New Delhi, June 14



CM Rekha Gupta at Geeta Colony Ghat on Sunday. ABHINAV SAHA

“MAINTAINING THE cleanliness of the Yamuna is not solely the responsibility of the government but the duty of every citizen,” Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Sunday as she joined a mega cleanliness drive along the riverbank, with thousands of volunteers participating across 28 locations in Delhi.

The government organised a simultaneous clean-up campaign at 28 ghats and riverfront sites as part of the Yamuna Riverbank Cleanliness Campaign 2026. Gupta

participated in the drive at Geeta Colony Ghat, where she joined volunteers and residents in removing waste from the riverbank

Describing the Yamuna as a source of faith, culture and life for crores of people, Gupta appealed to residents not to throw plastic waste, religious offerings, flowers, garlands, idols or other materials into the river. She added that a significant quantity of broken idols, garments used for deities and worship material wrapped in plastic were removed during the drive, highlighting the need for behavioural change among citizens.

According to the government, thousands of volunteers from more than 500 social, religious and community organisations participated in the campaign across nearly 22

kilometres of the riverfront. The drive, which began at 6 am, went on for four hours.

The CM said similar drives would continue in the Capital, adding that sustained public participation could help restore the river

Delhi ministers Parvesh Sahib Singh, Pankaj Singh, Ravinder Indraj, and Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta were among leaders who participated in the campaign at different ghats.

Addressing volunteers at Hathi Ghat near ITO, Water Minister Parvash said the scale of participation reflected growing public awareness about the river's condition.



Nalanda
UNIVERSITY

Established by an Act of Parliament of India and holds the status of an institution of National Importance



विदेश मंत्रालय
MINISTRY OF
EXTERNAL AFFAIRS

ADMISSIONS 2026

MA | MSc | MBA | PhD

Last Date to Apply: 30 June 2026



NEW MASTER'S PROGRAMMES

- Data Science & Artificial Intelligence
- Science & Technology Policy Studies
- Sanskrit

- Historical Studies
- Archaeology
- Buddhist Studies, Philosophy and Comparative Religions
- Hindu Studies (Sanatana Dharma)
- Sustainable Development and Management
- World Literature in English

- Ecology and Environment Studies
- International Relations and Peace Studies
- Philosophy
- Economics
- Mathematics
- Hindi

Salient features

- A Global Community of Faculty & Students from 25+ Countries
- Net-Zero Sustainable Campus
- Cafeteria Model for Interdisciplinary Education
- Immersive Residential Experience

ADMISSION HELPLINE

+91-9031027489 | 7033291552

Email: admission@nalandauniv.edu.in

SCHOLARSHIPS & RESEARCH ASSISTANCE AVAILABLE

SCAN TO APPLY

www.nalandauniv.edu.in/admissions



Fire at Kalkaji restaurant, elderly woman rescued

New Delhi: A fire that allegedly started from a tandoor at a restaurant engulfed a four-storey commercial building in South East Delhi's Kalkaji early Sunday morning, triggering a series of LPG cylinder explosions and causing panic among residents, officials said, adding that no casualties were reported.

They said an operation was launched and Sita Devi (70), who was trapped on the first floor of an adjoining residential building, was rescued.

As per the Delhi Fire Services, a distress call was received around 4.45 am regarding a fire at a building in H-Block, Krishna Market in Kalkaji. Preliminary probe suggests that the tandoor might

not have been completely extinguished
after use

During firefighting operations, four commercial LPG cylinders exploded, officials said. The building housed a warehouse in the basement, shops on the ground floor, a restaurant on the first floor, a gym on the second, and a banquet hall on the third. **ENS**



SPORT
UTILITY
VEHICLES

mahindra ^{Rise}

THE LIFE. THE SUV.



THAR R O X X

STARTS AT ₹12.39 LAKH*

BENEFITS UPTO ₹1.50 LAKH#



PANAROMIC SKYROOF™



9 SPEAKER CUSTOMIZED TUNED
HARMAN KARDON SOUND SYSTEM



TWIN 26.03 DIGITAL SCREENS



LEATHERETTE MOCHA
BROWN SEATING



POWERFUL mHAWK & mSTALLION
ENGINES

Creative Visualisation. For illustrative purposes only, actual products may vary.
 *Ex- Showroom Price of base variant (All-India)
 #The benefit mentioned is of a particular model & variant. Benefits will vary depending on the model & variant selected.



To book online visit auto.mahindra.com.

SOUTH DELHI: SHIVA AUTO: SAKET: 7669783680, SYNERGY CARS: SAFDARJUNG ENCLAVE: 8448791662, MALWA MOTORS: MAHIPALPUR: 9289773666, UNITED AUTOMOBILES: MOHAN ESTATE: 9289524154, KONCEPT AUTOMOBILES: LAJPAT NAGAR: 8448791672 • **OKHLA PHASE 1:** KONCEPT AUTOMOBILES: 8448791672 • **SOUTH WEST DELHI:** SHUBAN SAI MAHINDRA NAJAFGARH: 8178102134, MADHU VIHAR, RAJAPURI: 8178101995, MARBLE MARKET, DWARKA/SEC 20, 8178101584, • **CENTRAL DELHI:** MALWA MAHINDRA: DARYAGANJ: 9289923362, 9289809360, KAROL BAGH: 9289524166 • **WEST DELHI:** MALWA MAHINDRA: NARAINA: 92056 66547, INDRAPRASTHA AUTOMOBILES: JANAKPURI: 9821500363, INDRAPRASTHA AUTOMOBILES: PEERAGARHI: 7290055619, SRI DURGA: MOTI NAGAR: 7290055624 • **EAST DELHI:** SHIVA AUTO: DILSHAD GARDEN METRO STATION/PATPARGANJ/NIRMAN VIHAR: 8929172582, INDRAPRASTHA AUTOMOBILES: ASHOK NAGAR: 9953424546 • **NORTH DELHI:** INDRAPRASTHA AUTOMOBILES: NARELA 9289263814, SHAKTI NAGAR: 9311011260, WAZIRPUR: 7290055619 • **NORTH WEST DELHI:** INDRAPRASTHA AUTOMOBILES: PRASHANT VIHAR: 9289263813 • **FARIDABAD:** PRIME AUTOMOBILES: YMCA CHOWK/HODAL/PALWAL: 9354601752, UNITED AUTOMOBILES: NHPC CHOWK: 7428081661 • **NOIDA:** KONCEPT AUTOMOBILES: NOIDA (SEC-2): 9289937566, NOIDA (SEC-63/75): 9289937566 • **GREATER NOIDA:** KONCEPT AUTOMOBILES: GREATER NOIDA WEST/JEWAR: 9289937566 • **GURUGRAM:** DEE EMM MAHINDRA SEC-61: 8929648021, DAULTABAD: 8929648021, DEE EMM: ATUL KATARIA CHOWK/PATAUDI/SECTOR-14: 8929648040, GOLF COURSE: 8929648021, ARAV MOTORS: MANESAR: 9289220861, KONCEPT AUTOMOBILES: MG ROAD: 9289117279, SOHNA ROAD: 9289117279, RAJEEV CHOWK: 9289117279, SOHNA: 9289117279 • **GHAZIABAD:** SHIVA AUTO: LOHIA NAGAR: 7290055612, VAISHALI METRO STATION: 7290055612, LONI: 7290055612, MODINAGAR: 07669700992, HAPUR: 7290055614, BULANDSHAHR: 8010855603, • **HARYANA:** SONIPAT DRIVE PVT. LTD: SONIPAT: 7089211250/270/279, GOHANA: 7082911300, GANAUR: 7082911321, DEWAN FOURWHEELS PVT LTD: REWARI: 8607600241, 8607600251, DHARUHERA: 8607600207, NARNAUL: 8607600220, 8607600243, MOHINDERGARH: 8743812345, LOHCHAB MOTORS: ROHTAK/JHAJJAR/BAHADURGARH/MEHAM: 8059888800

epaper.indianexpress.com

New Delhi

The contamination beneath

Water contamination, shortages in some of South Delhi's most affluent neighbourhoods this summer expose the strain on ageing infrastructure and raise questions about the reliability of the Capital's water supply, reports **Sophiya Mathew**

Inside a white metal cabin beside Gate 2 of Gulmohar Park in South Delhi, residents have begun reading numbers they never expected to care about.

Chlorine: 0.63 mg/l.

pH: 7.08.

Turbidity: 0.43 NTU.

The readings appeared on June 11 on a newly installed online water analyser that continuously monitors the quality of water entering one of South Delhi's most affluent societies before it reaches homes.

Installed after a three-week contamination scare, the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) is testing the system in Gulmohar Park before deciding on a wider rollout. The analyser tracks key indicators: if the water is too acidic, if enough disinfectant remains to help keep it safe, and how clear it is.

For residents, those readings have become more than data. They have become a way to measure whether or not normalcy is returning.

Just weeks earlier, many had stopped trusting the water coming from their taps.

Across parts of South Delhi — including Gulmohar Park, Hauz Khas, Sarvodaya Enclave, and Green Park — residents say this summer exposed a troubling reality: a deteriorating water and sewer system alongside recurring seasonal shortages.

Behind incidents of foul-smelling tap water, sewage contamination, and weeks of flushing operations, residents point to an ageing underground network strained by construction activity, rising demand, overloaded sewers, and utility maps that, in some areas, no longer exist.

"This entire saga started somewhere around May 22," recalled Atul Bal, president of the Gulmohar Park RWA.

Some residents said the water smelled foul. Others described murky supply. Families reported falling sick.

WhatsApp groups filled with photographs of contaminated water and questions no one seemed able to answer: Was the contamination coming from inside the colony? From outside?

Officials spent days tracing possible sources.

Bal said one suspected point emerged near B Block, where houses under construction had temporary toilets allegedly positioned above a water pipeline. The structures were removed. Attention then shifted to Gate 2, where Delhi Jal Board teams dug up the area and found a punctured pipe.

But the problem did not disappear.

Residents said contamination continued to move through the colony's ageing internal network for nearly two weeks.

"Since contamination existed for almost two weeks across the pipeline in the colony, which is almost 60 years old now, residual contamination was still there," Bal said. The colony eventually began flushing pipelines from the tail end to push out what remained inside, Bal said.

After weeks of disruption, the answer was continuous monitoring. For residents, the analyser offers reassurance.

For Gulmohar Park residents, the three-week disruption extended beyond bad-smelling water. The daily-life toll was significant, the residents said. Several among them missed work because of illness, some spent money on treatment and tank cleaning, and others paid for private water. "Overall, the quality of life had gone down," Bal said.

Vimal Bhan, vice-president of the RWA, said his own health deteriorated during the episode. "My wife and several other neighbours also fell sick," he said. Low pressure created another problem. Bhan said household pumps began pulling harder and damaging ferrules. "When the pressure was low, my pump pulled and the ferrules got



damaged," he recalls.

Several residents eventually dug up their own service lines and replaced ferrules before realising some of the remaining issues lay within household connections. The colony also had to run a parallel water supply operation while repairs were underway, the residents said.

Bal said the RWA coordinated with DJB for tankers "It was a mammoth exercise — a colony of 700 houses, most of them asking for water," he said. At one stage, 13 tankers operated in shifts, making around 30-35 trips, carrying 10,000 litres each. But even that did not reach everyone.

Some residents bought private tanker water, especially those dependent on overhead tanks or unwilling to return to piped supply.

A few kilometres away, in Hauz Khas Village's Y Block, amid the simmering mid-June heat, the crisis remained visible in trenches and exposed service lines as workers replaced old pipes.

Standing near the dug-up stretch, Prakash Chand Gupta, a Y Block resident, described what had been coming through the taps. "Nalla ka paani aata hai, ek dam kala. (Sewage-mixed water comes in, completely black.) It has been ten days." His family had been arranging drinking water separately.

"This work has been going on for four days now," he said, expressing hope that repairs would bring relief. "Mostly by this evening... it will get fixed..."

Residents estimated that around 200 people in the area had faced water contamination issues this summer.

Nearby, Manoranjan Singh, chief of the federation of RWAs in Hauz Khas, pointed to the underground tank at his house.

"Look... you can't see the bottom. It is so dirty. Earlier it wasn't like this at all. We could clearly see the bottom."

Residents linked the crisis to ageing infrastructure, intermittent supply and low pressure. Gaurav Sharma, secretary of the RWA of Geeta Bhavan Lane in Hauz Khas, explained that empty pipelines can become vulnerable to contamination.

"When the water stops, there's no water in the pipeline," he said. If sewage accumulates nearby, he said, contaminated water can enter through weak points. "When fresh water comes from behind, it pushes all that sewage into the next few houses."

Singh argued that uneven demand and erratic supply had worsened the situation. "There is no checking nor limits imposed. By the time heavy demands of the first few residences are met, the tail-end houses get really poor supply. The erratic timings of the water supply has been another concern," he said.

In Sarvodaya Enclave, RWA head Shafai Mittal said a similar episode surfaced in the first week of May at the end of one lane, affecting around 10 houses.

Before residents realised the scale of the issue, she said, some had already got diarrhoea. "We wouldn't have ever known," Mittal said.

"One person wrote that the water is smelly. Then the entire group started speaking up."

DJB teams later dug up the pipeline and



(Anti-clockwise from above) A newly installed water analyser; maintenance work underway in Hauz Khas in New Delhi on Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

• DJB COMPLAINTS AND WATER SAMPLES TESTED OVER THE LAST YEAR

Month & Year	Collected	Satisfactory	Unsatisfactory	Main affected zones (Total count)
Jan 2025	1,130	1,111	19	Dwarka (8), Nangloi (3), Wazirabad (3), Greater Kailash (2)
Feb 2025	2,413	2,390	23	Nangloi (9), Greater Kailash (6), Bhagirathi (4), Wazirabad (1), Okhla (1)
Mar 2025	1,150	1,123	27	Nangloi (9), Wazirabad (7), Dwarka (4)
Apr 2025	464	453	11	Bhagirathi (4), Greater Kailash (4)
May 2025	1,128	1,111	17	Greater Kailash (5), Nangloi (5), Wazirabad (4), Bhagirathi (2)
June 2025	793	759	34	Bhagirathi (12), Nangloi (9), Dwarka (8), Wazirabad (2)
July 2025	826	811	15	Nangloi (8), Greater Kailash (7)
Aug 2025	700	681	19	Greater Kailash (7), Bhagirathi (6), Nangloi (5)
Sept 2025	421	394	27	Dwarka (9), Bhagirathi (8), Okhla (7)
Oct 2025	714	684	30	Wazirabad (10), Bhagirathi (9), Nangloi (6)
Nov 2025	770	748	22	Greater Kailash (9), Bhagirathi (5), Dwarka (4), Nangloi (1)
Dec 2025	857	843	14	Dwarka (5), Haiderpur (4), Greater Kailash (2), Bhagirathi (2)

found a fault. "Pipes have gotten old. They are corroding," Mittal said, adding that the affected section was replaced.

But the repairs exposed another concern.

"They kept asking us for maps," she said.

"There is no plan. Ours is like a 60-year-old colony."

Mittal said sewer pipelines had come under growing pressure over the years. "Another major problem nobody is talking about is builders," she said.

She pointed to makeshift toilets at construction sites, waste dumped into drains and polishing residue entering sewer lines. "On ground the problem is so visible. Every colony where big constructions are going on, the lane there faces sewer blockage problems. Eventually there are complaints of bad water," she alleged.

In Green Park, the immediate concern has been water shortage.

RWA head Neha Puri said two blocks had received inadequate water supply for nearly 20 days, with the disruption still continuing.

"My own family is also affected," Puri said. "I am currently abroad, but I have had to arrange drinking water for my ageing parents back home."

On June 6, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi issued an advisory for under-construction buildings in Green Park: that no damage be caused to sewer lines, water lines, prohibited labour huts and barred construction material from being stacked on roads.

The Deer Park booster station serves as a key distribution node for Green Park through supply from Haiderpur Water Treatment Plant. Officials said that this summer, falling water levels at Wazirabad reduced production at critical treatment plants by around 40%, worsening both supply shortages and water-quality concerns.



Most Severely Affected

Reason: Low per-capita supply

- Karawal Nagar
- Badli
- Kirari
- Burari

Acute Shortages & Contamination

Reason: multiple localised issues

- Hauz Khas
- Greater Kailash 2
- Janakpuri
- Civil Lines

DJB: Water network under huge pressure

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, June 14

RESPONDING TO recent water contamination complaints in several South Delhi colonies, Delhi Jal Board (DJB) officials said field teams are deployed to inspect affected areas, collect samples and carry out corrective measures. A senior official attributed most localised incidents to ageing infrastructure and operational stress during the summer months.

A senior official said rapid population growth, rising demand and uneven consumption patterns had placed increasing pressure on Delhi's water network.

This summer, reduced output at major water treatment plants (WTPs) created supply shortfalls of 40–100 MGD on many days, even as peak demand crossed 1,200 MGD. Officials said efforts were made to secure additional water from Haryana, while water levels at the Wazirabad pond — which stores Yamuna water before treatment — fell below the 674.5-foot level required for normal plant operations.

"Out of Delhi's 16,634-km water distribution network, nearly 5,500 km of pipelines are more than 30 years old and about 3,000 km are 25–30 years old. These ageing lines are prone to leakages and contamination. Huge quantities of treated water are lost before reaching consumers," Delhi Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh told reporters earlier this June.

"Replacing old pipelines, reducing leakages, modernising distribution systems and strengthening water infrastructure are essential if Delhi has to become water secure," he said, adding that the work was being prioritised. Officials said long-term measures include phased pipeline replacement, desilting and network upgrades to reduce losses and maintain stable pressure.

In early June 2026, DJB also announced a water rationalisation initiative after an internal survey found significant disparities across Delhi's 70 Assembly constituencies. Officials said the exercise would assess population density, demand, supply and infrastructure before corrective measures are implemented.

• 'CONTAMINATION EPISODES MUST BE VIEWED ALONGSIDE DELHI'S GROWING DEMAND, RISING DENSITY AND AGEING DISTRIBUTION NETWORK'

How low pressure, ageing pipes and leaks pollute Capital's water

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, June 14

DELHI'S RECURRING water contamination episodes highlight the limits of relying on emergency repairs and tanker supply. Experts say the city needs to shift from responding to breakdowns to preventing them — through real-time monitoring, updated maps of underground networks, routine water testing and planned replacement of ageing pipelines.

Without these changes, problems may remain undetected until residents begin reporting foul smells, illness or dirty water.

First, on what is wrong and why.

Why contamination happens

Contamination usually occurs under three conditions.

First, there must be a pollution source close to a drinking water line — such as a leak-

ing sewer, overflowing drain, polluted groundwater, sewage-laden stormwater, construction waste or stagnant contaminated water around the pipe.

Second, there must be a pathway for entry: a corroded pipe, damaged joint, leaking valve, weak ferrule, abandoned pipeline, cross-connection or poor repair.

Third, there is often a hydraulic trigger — low pressure, back-suction or flow reversal. Household pumps and borewells can worsen the problem. In low-pressure areas, residents often use motors to draw water from the line. If pressure inside the main drops, those pumps can pull contaminated water through weak points in the network. Similar risks have been flagged in WHO guidelines and Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs water-supply manuals.

Dr Fawzia Tarannum, a water governance and sustainability expert and assistant professor at TERI, said water and sewer



pipelines often run side by side.

"If there is a burst in the pipeline or some compromise or breach in the sewer line, and the water line is not 24x7 pressurised, contamination can enter en-route," she said.

A resident of Hauz Khas shows his water tank.

PRAVEEN KHANNA

Continuous pressure, she added, largely prevents this.

She said the contamination episodes must also be viewed alongside Delhi's growing demand, rising density and ageing distribution network. As colonies add floors and commercial activity expands, the same water and sewer lines are carrying heavier loads.

"There is a crisis of water," she said, adding that nearly 40% of supplied water is lost as non-revenue water.

"If they can plug these leaks..."

Reducing losses, she argued, would improve both availability and pressure. In better-managed systems internationally, such losses are often closer to 5–10%, while higher levels point to deeper inefficiencies.

What can be done

The solution, Tarannum said, lies in

shifting from complaint-based detection to real-time monitoring.

"IoT-based sensors are available. If there is any drop in pressure... the officials could know," she said.

She said water distribution should be integrated with Supervisory Control and

Data Acquisition (SCADA) systems, which are already used in sectors such as energy transmission.

"If the entire network is connected to a SCADA system, sitting in an office, remotely you can monitor what is happening on the ground,"

she said.

Such systems, she added, must be supported by accurate digital maps of water pipelines, sewer lines and vulnerable points. If ageing pipelines are replaced without parallel investment in monitoring and mapping, she said, the city risks carrying old weaknesses into new infrastructure.



NCR draft Plan 2041 up for approval, conservation zones yet to be mapped

Jay Mazoomdaar
New Delhi, June 14

DESPITE MULTIPLE directions from the National Green Tribunal (NGT) since 2018, the National Capital Region Planning Board (NCRPB) has yet to map, ground-truth and demarcate Natural Conservation Zones (NCZs) in the draft Regional Plan 2041, scheduled to be considered for approval at the Board's next meeting on June 16.

The NCRPB has overlooked repeated reminders from the Environment Ministry and the Delhi government to include comparative data on land-use changes between the regional plans (RPs) of 2021 and 2041.

Ground-truthing is the process of verifying whether land use and land cover indicated by satellite imagery accurately reflect actual conditions on the ground. In a series of orders between 2018 and 2022, aimed at protecting NCZs and preventing shrinkage, the NGT sought comparative mapping at a scale of 1:50,000 to verify changes between 1999 and 2019 — and for a finer assessment of present land use at 1:10,000 scale or closer using satellite imagery from 2021-22 or later. The separate exercises were required because higher-resolution imagery from 1999 — the base year for RP-2021 — was not available with the National Remote Sensing Centre (NRSC). “The classification scheme of the mapping should be selected in a manner that Natural Conservation Areas are explicitly mapped. Due emphasis should be placed on ground truthing,” the Tribunal ordered in September 2020.

Six years on, the revised draft RP-2041 relied on ISRO's Bhuvan geoportal for “the existing broad land use analysis” based on satellite imagery from 2015-16. There are still no details on NCZs in terms of area, coordinates or encroachments, nor any mention of commissioning mapping work using more recent, finer-resolution imagery.

In April 2022, the NGT reiterated that violations, including “shrinkage of the Aravallis” and other NCZs, noticed on lower-

E. EXPLAINED

Policy impact

The decade-long pendency of field verification and demarcation of Natural Conservation Zones affects planning and policy-making. The absence of clearly marked boundaries also makes it difficult to identify violations of land use and enforce accountability.

resolution images were not to be ignored. “Once violations have been identified, then with the use of high-resolution maps... violators can be identified and action initiated as per law,” the order said.

Yet, the revised draft RP-2041, which is up for approval this week, offers only broad guidelines and a low-resolution “tentative map” of NCZ areas, saying the “extent of natural features under NCZ will be identified, ascertained and delineated by the NCR participating States in accordance with above definition using ground truthing and revenue records, etc”.

This echoes the NCRPB's September 2019 position that Regional Plan “may have schematic maps presenting the broad policies....and detailing of the maps at the scale of 1:10,000 and below along with ground

Land use in NCR: 1986-2016

	1986	1999	2012	2016
Category				(in sq km)
Built-up	988	2,635	3,724	4,569
Agriculture	26,506	24,050	26,450	45,030
Forests	775	1,215	1,127	1,801
Water bodies	32	242	231	873
Wastelands#	1,859	2,005	2,346	2,511
Others**	82	95	266	360
Total NCR	30,242	30,242	34,144	55,144

GULLIED, SALINE, WATERLOGGED, BARREN, ROCKY AND RIVER SAND AREAS

** STONE QUARRY, BRICK KILN ETC;

SOURCE: NCRPB

truthing and detailed planning may be left to the states”.

In 2012, the NCRPB asked the four NCR states — Delhi, Haryana, UP and Rajasthan — to explain the loss of an estimated 1,014 sq km of NCZ areas. Seven years later, the NGT observed in November 2019: “The plea of the concerned States is that ground truthing has yet to be done. Such exercise cannot be unending.”

When contacted, NCRPB member secretary Gulzar Narayan said: “We had meetings with the Environment Ministry. I am not aware of anything pending as of now.” He did not respond to a query on whether the NCRPB could identify NCZ violations if boundaries were delineated by states without a central mapping exercise by an expert agency, such as the NRSC.

In July 2022, the Delhi gov-

ernment pointed out to the NCRPB that a “clear comparison of change of land use in the last two decades has not been provided” in the draft RP-2041. “In comparison, the earlier Regional Plan 2021 had provided a clear change in land use map from the 1980s to 1999 using satellite analysis,” it wrote, adding that the omission also violated NGT orders. The same month, the Environment Ministry reminded the NCRPB of various NGT orders requiring mapping for different time periods to ensure conservation of NCZs. “The request made by this Ministry in previous communications to NCRPB for compliance with the said orders may also be kept in

view,” the ministry wrote.

In response to both, the NCRPB noted “the matter has been discussed at senior levels of the Government of India and further action is proposed accordingly in the draft final revised Regional Plan 2041”.

However, the draft final revised RP-2041 still lacks comparable data to identify land-use changes between 1999 and 2019. “Since RP-2021 was released, the NCR area has increased by more than 60% from 34,144 sq km to 55,144 sq km. So unless specific area-for-area data is provided, it is not possible to assess land-use changes from state-level data,” said a former Environment Ministry official.

Records show the NRSC had submitted a proposal in September 2020 to complete the mapping work in 12 months for “an estimated cost of Rs 1.86 crore”. The NCRPB refused to provide budgetary support in December 2020. In April 2021, the NGT reiterated its order.

A senior Environment Ministry official said: “We conveyed our views but didn’t think it appropriate to push beyond a point. After all, NCRPB is a statutory body under the Urban Affairs Ministry, and ultimately it’s between them and the NRSC.”

A senior NRSC official declined to comment.

‘Jan sunwai’ at all police stations every Saturday

New Delhi: To create a dedicated platform for people to raise grievances, complaints and public safety concerns directly before officers, Delhi Police has directed all police stations across the Capital to organise a weekly “Thana Divas-Jan Sunwai” every Saturday from 10 am to 2 pm.

The move follows directions issued by Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu to strengthen public outreach, improve accessibility of police services and ensure prompt redressal of complaints, officials said.

As per a circular issued by Commissioner of Police Satish Golcha, every complainant attending the Jan Sunwai must be heard, even if their complaint has already been registered on the police’s Integrated Complaint Management System (ICMS).

BEFORE THE NATIONAL COMPANY LAW TRIBUNAL, CHENNAI BENCH
COMPANY SCHEME PETITION Nos. CP(CAA)/39(CHE)/2026,
CP(CAA)/42(CHE)/2026 and CP(CAA)/38(CHE)/2026
CONNECTED WITH
COMPANY SCHEME APPLICATION Nos. CA(CAA)/13(CHE)/2026,
CA(CAA)/14(CHE)/2026 and CA(CAA)/12(CHE)/2026

In the matter of the Companies Act, 2013;
And
In the matter of Petitions under Sections 230 to 232 of the Companies Act, 2013 and other applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 read with the Companies (Compromises, Arrangements and Amalgamation) Rules, 2016;
And
In the matter of a Composite Scheme of Arrangement between Veranda Learning Solutions Limited, Veranda XL Learning Solutions Private Limited, J.K. Shah Commerce Education Limited and their respective shareholders and creditors ("Composite Scheme").

Veranda Learning Solutions Limited,
Veranda XL Learning Solutions Private Limited and
J.K. Shah Commerce Education Limited,
all having their registered office at G.R. Complex,
First Floor, No. 807-808, Anna Salai,
Nandanam, Chennai – 600 035.

...Petitioners

NOTICE OF HEARING OF COMPANY SCHEME PETITIONS

NOTICE is hereby given that the above Company Scheme Petitions under Sections 230 to 232 and other applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 seeking sanction of the Composite Scheme were presented by the Petitioner Companies on April 29, 2026 and were admitted by the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, Chennai Bench ("Tribunal") vide Order dated June 03, 2026. The Hon'ble Tribunal has fixed **Tuesday, July 07, 2026**, as the date of hearing of the said Company Scheme Petitions.

Any person desirous of supporting or opposing the said Company Scheme Petitions should send to the undersigned a notice of such intention, signed by such person or such person's Advocate, stating the name and address of such person, so as to reach the undersigned at the address mentioned below not later than seven (7) days before the date fixed for hearing of the said Company Scheme Petitions. Any person seeking to oppose the said Company Scheme Petitions shall also furnish, along with such notice, the grounds of opposition or a copy of the affidavit intended to be relied upon.

A copy of the Company Scheme Petitions may be obtained from the undersigned upon payment of the prescribed charges by emailing the Petitioner Companies at secretarial@verandallearning.com

Sd/-
Mr. Pawan Jhabakh
Advocate for the Petitioners
No. 115, Luz Church Road,
Mylapore, Chennai – 600 004

Date : June 15, 2026
Place : Chennai



A Navratna Company

NATIONAL FERTILIZERS LIMITED
(A GOVERNMENT OF INDIA UNDERTAKING)
CIN: L74899DL1974GOI007417
Registered Office: Scope Complex, Core -III,
7, Institutional Area, Lodhi Road, New Delhi 110003.
Website: www.nationalfertilizers.com, Email ID: investor@nfl.co.in
Telephone: 011 – 24360066, 24361252

Notice to Shareholders

Special Window for Transfer and Dematerialisation of Physical Securities

This is to inform all concerned shareholders that, pursuant to SEBI Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/1/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, a special window for transfer and dematerialisation of physical securities which were sold/purchased prior to April 01, 2019, has been opened for a period of one year from February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027.

This initiative is also applicable to transfer requests that were originally submitted prior to April 01, 2019, but were either rejected, returned, or not attended due to deficiencies in documentation or other procedural issues.

Please note that all transfer requests will be processed strictly in dematerialized form and shall be under lock-in for a period of one year from the date of registration of transfer. Such securities shall not be transferred/lien-marked/pledged during the said lock-in period. Concerned shareholders are advised to take note of this opportunity and lodge/re-lodge their transfer requests along with the requisite documents to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, MAS Services Limited, at T-34, II Floor, Okhla Industrial Area, Phase-II, New Delhi – 110020. Tel.: 011-26387281-83; Email ID: investor@masserv.com

Place: New Delhi
Date: 15.06.2026

For National Fertilizers Limited,
Sd/-
(Ashok Jha)
Company Secretary



Indian Academy of Highway Engineers
(Ministry of Road Transport & Highways, Govt. of India)
A-5, Institutional Area, Sector-62, Noida (UP)-201301

Indian Academy of Highway Engineers (IAHE), Noida is the premier National Training Institute for Training of Highway Professionals and Registered Society under the administrative control of the Ministry of Road Transport & Highways, Government of India. IAHE invites applications for filling up the of posts of **(i) Core Faculty (Highways); (ii) Core Faculty (Bridge); (iii) Core Faculty (Pavement); (iv) Core Faculty (Safety)** one each in the grade of Joint Director in IAHE on Contract basis.

The last date of receipt of applications: 15.07.2026
Corrigendum or Addendum or cancellation to this advertisement, if any, shall be published only on the website of IAHE.

Further details regarding Application Form, Qualifications, Experience, Pay Scale/Remuneration and Age Limit etc. please visit IAHE website: <https://iahe.morth.gov.in>

Director, IAHE



SHILLONG MEDICAL COLLEGE
Government of Meghalaya
Pasteur Hills, Lawmali Road, Shillong, Meghalaya- 793001
email: shgmcollege@gmail.com, website: shillongmedicalcollege.co.in

NOTICE INVITING RFP FOR PROCUREMENT AND INSTITUTIONAL ACCESS OF DIGITAL MEDICAL E-BOOK COLLECTION FOR SHILLONG MEDICAL COLLEGE.

Dated Shillong the 12th June 2026

SMCMS-05/2026/e-Books/07: The Shillong Medical College Management Society, vide NIT Reference No. SMCMS-05/2026/e-Books/05: dated 12th June 2026, invites Request for Proposal (RFP) from eligible and qualified bidders for procurement and institutional access of Digital Medical E-Book Collection for Shillong Medical College, Shillong, located at Pasteur Hills, Lawmali, Shillong. Interested bidders may obtain the detailed RFP document from the official website: <https://meghealth.gov.in/>

MIPR No.: 798
Dated: 12.6.2026

Sd/-
Member Secretary
Shillong Medical College Management Society



CONTAINER CORPORATION OF INDIA LTD.
CONCOR ANNEXE, NSIC New MDPI Building, 2nd Floor,
Okhla Indl. Estate (Opp. NSIC Okhla Metro Station), New Delhi-110020.

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

CONCOR INVITES E-TENDER IN SINGLE PACKET SYSTEM OF TENDERING FOR THE FOLLOWING WORK:-

Tender No. CON/EP/Area-L/P/WAY/R-I/E-102409/2026-28
Name of Work: Removal of the existing 60 track and Annual preventive Maintenance of CONCOR Siding at different terminals of Area -I (i.e. TNG, Wazirpur, Japur, Khatawas, Ludhiana, Dhapur, Phalau, Khemli, Barhi, Dadi, Kanpur, Agra, Kota and Malanpur)

Estimated Cost ₹ 7,24,57,451.57
Completion Period 24 Months from the 15th day after date of issue of Letter of Acceptance
Earnest Money Deposit ₹ 5,12,290/- (through e-payment).
Cost of Tender Document NIL
Tender Processing Fee (Non-refundable) 3000/- (Plus GST as applicable through e-payment)
Date of Sale of Tender (online) 15/06/2026 (11:00 hrs) to 06/07/2026 (upto 17:00 hrs.)
Date & Time of Submission of Tender (online) 07/07/2026 (upto 17:00 hrs.)
Date & Time of Opening of Tender (online) 09/07/2026 at 11:30 hrs.

For financial eligibility criteria, experience with respect to similar nature of work, etc, please refer to detailed tender notice available on website www.concordia.com, but the complete tender document can be downloaded from website www.tenderwizd.com/CCIL only. Further, Corrigendum / Addendum to this tender, if any, will be published on website www.concordia.com, www.tenderwizd.com/CCIL and Central Procurement Portal (CPP) only. Newspaper press advertisement shall not be issued for the same.

Group General Manager (Tech-Area-I)
Phone No.- 011-41322300



ऑयल एंड नेचुरल गैस कॉर्पोरेशन लिमिटेड
Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd.

Regd. Office: Plot No. 5A-5B, Nelson Mandela Marg, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi-110070
CIN: L74899DL1993GOI054155
Website: www.ongcindia.com | Email: secretariat@ongc.co.in

EXPRESSIONS OF INTEREST (EOI)

ONGC invites Expressions of Interest (EOI) for Identification and Assessment of Independent Vendors for Supply of Spares and Maintenance Support Services for Caterpillar Engines.

The Purpose of this EOI is to identify technically competent vendors with proven capabilities in supply of spares of Caterpillar engine and supporting related maintenance requirements. Detailed information regarding the EOI is available on the ONGC Tender Portal, <https://tenders.ongc.co.in/>. The last date for submission of EOI responses is 05.07.2026. Interested vendors may submit their responses in electronic format to TS_SUPPORT@ONGC.CO.IN.

Any corrigendum, addendum, amendment, clarification or extension related to this EOI shall be hosted only on the ONGC Tender Portal. No separate press notification shall be issued in this regard. Interested parties are advised to visit the portal regularly for updates."

PUBLIC NOTICE

Whereas SS Group Private Limited Regd. office at SS House, Plot No.77, Sector 44, Gurugram-122003 has applied to Chief Town Planner, Haryana-cum-Chairman, Building Plan Approval Committee for approval of revised Building Plans of Mixed Land Use Colony under TOD policy being developed over an area measuring 10.4066 acres (License No. 265 of 2023 dated 19.12.2023 and 35 of 2026 dated 20.02.2026) in sector-90, Gurugram.

In compliance with the conditions of in-principle approval granted by the office of Chief Town Planner, Haryana vide Memo No. ZP-1940/SD(RD)/2026/20067 dated 8.6.2026, objections are hereby invited from each existing allottee of License No. 265 of 2023 and 35 of 2026, if any, regarding the amendment in the building plans. Copies of earlier approved building plans and the revised building plans being approved in-principle are available for perusal on our website www.ssgroup-india.com/notice-ads as well as in the office of the Senior Town Planner, Gurugram. The said plans can also be perused at the registered office of the Company as well as the site office of the Project.

If any existing allottee has any objection on amendment in Building Plans, he/she may file objection in the office of Senior Town Planner, HUDA Complex, Sector 14, Gurgaon within 30 days of the issuance of this notice, failing which it shall be assumed that there are no objections to the amendment in Building Plans.

Date: 15.06.2026

Sd/-
Name: Bijimol Mni
Designation: Sr. Business Manager
SS Group Private Limited



प्रधान आयुक्त कार्यालय, केंद्रीय माल एवं सेवा कर, दिल्ली उत्तर
OFFICE OF THE PR. COMMISSIONER,
CGST DELHI NORTH
सी०आर० बिल्डिंग, आई०पी०इस्टेट, नई दिल्ली-110002
C. R. BUILDING, I. P. ESTATE, NEW DELHI-110002

HOLDING OF PENSION ADALAT

The Central GST, Delhi North Commissionerate is holding a Pension Adalat pertaining to CGST Delhi North/Delhi East/Delhi Audit-I/Delhi Appeal-I including all subordinate offices of the said Commissionerates for taking on-spot decision for prompt resolution of pensioner's grievances at C.R. Building, I.P. Estate, New Delhi-110009 ON 14.07.2026 from 12:00 PM onwards. All the pensioners, whose pension cases are pending settlement/decision, may file application before the Adalat for settlement of their cases. Prescribed application form for submission before the Adalat is already available at www.gstdelhihzone.gov.in.

Sd/-
Additional Commissioner (P & E)
Central GST Delhi North

EXPRESS Careers



DES' Shri Navalmal Firodia Law College, Pune.
Gate No. 3, Fergusson College Campus, Pune - 411004.
Tel: (020) 67656400/06 | E-mail: deslaw@despune.org

WALK -IN INTERVIEWS

(Un- Aided and Approved by Bar Council of India and permanently affiliated to Savitribai Phule Pune University, Pune.)

Applications are invited for the Walk In Interview for an appointment of Assistant Professor in various disciplines mentioned below for the academic year 2026-27 on Ad-hoc basis. The interviews will be conducted on 20.06.2026 at 11.00 am at DES's Shri. Navalmal Firodia Law College Pune. The details of the post and subjects are as follows.

Sr. No.	Post	Subject	No. of Posts	Category
1.	Assistant Professor	English (For B.A. LL.B., B.B.A.LLB. 5 Years Law Integrated Course)	1 (Ad-hoc)	MA (English) & NET/SET/ Ph D. as per UGC Norms
2.	Assistant Professor	Business Management (For B.B.A.LLB. 5 Years Law Integrated Course)	1 (Ad-hoc)	MBA (as per UGC Norms)
3.	Assistant Professor	Law (UG) (For B.A.LLB, B.B.A.LLB. and LL.B. Courses)	12 (Ad-hoc)	SC-02, ST-01, VJ-A-01, NT-B-01, OBC-2, SEBC-01, EWS-01, Open-03
4.	Assistant Professor	Law (PG) (For LL.M. P.G. Course)	2 (Ad-hoc)	LLM & NET/ SET/Ph D. as per UGC Norms

Note:- PWD/ दिव्यांग (राट-अ) candidate will be given preference

Secretary
Deccan Education Society, Pune



YOGA FOR HEALTHY AGEING

12th International Day of Yoga 2026

You are cordially invited to join the Main Event on **21st June**, from **5AM** Onwards

Join the Main Event live at a venue near you or participate virtually from your home!

Adopt Yoga to

- Boost Immunity, Reduce Stress**
- Enhance Balance & Mobility**
- Preventive Care, Lifelong Gains**

Main Event: Kolkata, West Bengal

Celebrating Wellness Across Generations

moayush | ministryofayush | ministryofayushofficial



Gentle Reminder

GIVEN THAT CRPF DG G P Singh is rather prompt in engaging on social media, some CRPF personnel have started reaching out to him on X. Earlier this week, a CRPF constable of the CoBra battalion, hailing from Kanpur, posted on social media a complaint he had lodged with a local police station, and requested Singh to follow up. Singh acknowledged the post but advised the jawan to send such requests for help through official channels. It is learnt that personnel have been told that the CRPF has a fully functional internal mechanism to deal with issues of jawans and officers and they must utilise it rather than going on social media.

Late Arrivals

WHILE THE Education Ministry continues to grapple with major paper leaks and technical glitches in the On-Screen Marking system, Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's office is believed to be dealing with a different internal problem: late arrival by staff members. According to sources, several staff members regularly come to work well after office hours begin, irking senior officials. In response, some seniors have reportedly shared photographs of empty desks and chairs in office WhatsApp groups as a way of highlighting the issue.

Zero Tolerance

DAYS AFTER a CBI operation that saw multiple Delhi Police personnel, including an inspector, getting arrested in a Rs 3 crore bribery case, Commissioner of Police Satish Golchha has directed the vigilance branch to activate its field officers and step up action against officers involved in dubious or unethical conduct. The move, an official said, is meant to send a clear message across the force: corruption won't be tolerated and accountability will be visible and swift.

CJP protest in Jaipur gets police nod, participants capped at 800

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, June 14

AFTER INITIALLY rejecting the group's request, Jaipur police on Sunday granted permission to the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) to hold a protest in Jaipur on Monday. The approval, however, has come with quite some riders, including an unusual cap on the number of protesters: 800. Other conditions include no DJs, no rally, no disruption of traffic. "The programme should be completely maryadit (decorous) and should totally keep in mind Indian culture. It should be seemit (limited) and sanyamit (restrained) so that traffic and public movement is not disrupted and unnecessary lawazma (crowding) is avoided," read one of the nearly two dozen directions. The permission has been granted for a protest between 3 pm and 7 pm. The organisers will also have to follow the Noise Pollution (Regulation and Control) Rules, 2000. In case of a violation, they will be penalised. Additionally, approval will be revoked if complaints are received from students or members of the public, police said. Apart from CJP president Abhijeet Dipke, activist Sonam Wangchuk is also expected to be present.

MODI AND MACRON INAUGURATE 'BHARAT INNOVATES' EVENT IN NICE

India a tech provider, offering global solutions: PM in France

Says priority is 'human-centric innovation'

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 14

UNDERLINING THAT the "world is undergoing a period of unprecedented upheaval", Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said that India and France have made "concerted efforts" to find solutions to global challenges, and "India is emerging not merely as a consumer of solutions, but as a contributor to them".

Modi made the comments at the inauguration of the 'Bharat Innovates' event in Nice, France, in the presence of French President Emmanuel Macron.

"For the world, this decade is defined by both disruption and development. Amidst conflicts and the escalating impact of climate change, the world is undergoing a period of unprecedented upheaval. Yet, the challenges facing humanity today are matched by equally significant opportunities," he said.

Until a decade ago, Modi



PM Narendra Modi with French President Emmanuel Macron at the 'Bharat Innovates' event in Nice on Sunday. ANI

said, the world viewed India merely as a technology adopter. "Today, India is emerging as a technology provider. Moreover, the innovations and solutions India offers benefit a vast segment of humanity. This is precisely the goal of 'India Innovates.' Bharat Innovates is an invitation to the world to co-create the next chapter of global innovation with India," he said.

"An India that is emerging not merely as a consumer of

solutions, but as a contributor to them. Some are working to transform rural life using AI, while others are utilising satellite technology to assist farmers. Young innovators are building the future through smart cities, advanced manufacturing, and new materials. Others are ensuring a sustainable future through green hydrogen, electric mobility, and battery technologies. Meanwhile, some start-ups are

developing cutting-edge technologies in the fields of defence and security," Modi said. "Observing your capabilities, I would say: Bharat innovates with scale and speed; Bharat innovates for a sustainable future; and Bharat innovates for the entire world."

"India has demonstrated that innovation and inclusion are not contradictory but complementary. This means that the greatness of any innovation lies not merely in its evaluation, but in its human impact," he said. "Today, the world is looking towards technologies that are reliable, inclusive, human-centric, and aimed at the global good. In such times, India's priority is technology for humanity, human-centric innovation."

Addressing Macron, Modi said: "During your recent visit to India, you stated that India and France must come together to address the challenges of this century. Today, I can proudly say that this initiative is a step in that very direction."

"Countries across the world trade with one another and form strategic partnerships; however, there are certain relationships that are driven not only by shared interests but also

by a shared vision. The relationship between India and France is precisely of this nature," he said. "This relationship embodies connection and conviction; innovation and inspiration; shared values and a shared vision. Building upon this foundation, we have launched new initiatives together over the past few years, given direction to new ideas, and made concerted efforts to find solutions to global challenges," Modi said.

In his address at the event, Macron said that France respects the Make-in-India initiative and that Paris has been part of it in diverse sectors. Describing India as a "country of innovation", he said New Delhi and Paris have a "true partnership" in critical sectors like AI and climate change. There is scope to expand bilateral cooperation in the civil nuclear energy sector, including in the area of Small Modular Reactors, he said.

Bharat Innovates, a 3-day event, brings together top innovation start-ups from India, France and the world. More than 120 Indian companies/startups and prominent business leaders, investors and CEOs from France and other countries are participating. WITH PTI

'District units, civic bodies next': Ritabrata eyes full TMC takeover

Manoj CG
New Delhi, June 14

WITH THE TMC anti-Abhishek Banerjee faction securing the support of over two-thirds of MLAs in West Bengal and Lok Sabha MPs, the rebels will slowly move towards taking over the rest of the party, Ritabrata Banerjee told *The Indian Express* on Sunday. Banerjee is spearheading the MLA revolt and, though expelled by the Mamata Banerjee-led group, has been recognised as the LoP by the Assembly Speaker.

"Once the MP-MLA things are over, the municipalities will be shifting. The municipalities, the corporations, the Zilla Parishads, even people who are presidents of different districts are already in touch with us. It is a parliamentary democracy. Numbers are important. Anyway, let's meet at the EC," Banerjee told *Express* in an interview.

"The TMC's grassroots organisation will be holding a meeting. We are working out what we will do. The primary focus was on the MLAs, then the MPs, then slowly we will be taking over the corporations, then



Ritabrata Banerjee has been spearheading MLA revolt in TMC

the municipalities, then the Zilla Parishads," he reiterated.

Asked if this faction would stake claim as the real TMC, he said, "We are TMC, what real what non-real? More than two-thirds of MPs are on board, more than two-thirds of MLAs are on board ... If necessary, we will meet at the EC."

Banerjee said he had handed over a letter to Speaker Rathindra Bose with signatures of 58 MLAs. Three more MLAs had given separate letters to the Speaker and three more would submit letters on Monday, taking the number in this group up to 64. The number eventually will touch 67-68, he said. The TMC has 80 MLAs in total.

This group of TMC rebel

MLAs would function as the Opposition against the BJP in Bengal while the rebel MPs would align with the NDA in the Lok Sabha, Banerjee said.

"The MPs are in Delhi. Once they return, our leadership in the Assembly will try to sit with them... what I can say is as fear is contagious, so is courage. So I congratulate everybody. We will be opposing BJP, but any one of my MP colleagues, if they decide they will be supporting NDA, that may be a politically opposite stance, but I will still congratulate him or her. It is a fight against dictatorship and a fight for democracy," Banerjee said.

Hitting out at Mamata Banerjee's nephew Abhishek Banerjee, Banerjee said, "A grassroots-level party belonging to Mamata Banerjee has been conveniently hijacked by a corporate bureaucracy." This appears to be a reference to the influence of political consultancy I-PAC. Asked who will head the rebels overall, Banerjee said, "... I never consider myself a leader. I am a team man... it is a collective leadership..."

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM



As crisis deepens in his party, TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee arrives at the CID headquarters — the second time in four days — in the alleged signature forgery case, in Kolkata on Sunday. Party MLA Kunal Ghosh was also questioned. PTI

Focus on party that lost both seats it fought in Tripura in 2023

Asad Rehman & Debraj Deb
New Delhi, Agartala, June 14

WITH REBEL Trinamool Congress MPs on Sunday conveying to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla that they had merged with the Nationalist Citizens Party Of India (NCPI), and that they want to sit in the House as a separate bloc, the spotlight moved to a lesser-known party that made its electoral debut in the 2023 Assembly polls in Tripura, losing deposit in both the seats it contested.

Led by founder Shiuli Kundu, the NCPI has been ac-

tive in Assam and Tripura in recent years. According to the Election Commission of India website, the NCPI is among "registered (unrecognised)" parties, with a symbol of "pen nib with seven rays".

Although it was not immediately clear if the NCPI contested in the recent elections in Assam, a party leader, who did not wish to be named, said it "fielded" four candidates in the 2023 Tripura elections, including two who fought the election on party tickets.

While Jahangir Ali (54) and Barjeda Tripura (65) fought on

NCPI tickets from Kailashahar constituency in Unakoti district and Chawmanu constituency in Dhalai district, respectively, identities of the other two candidates are yet to be confirmed. It is likely that the two were party-backed Independent candidates, sources said.

As far as the result goes, the party managed a combined 822 votes in the two seats where it fielded own candidates — 536 in ST-reserved Chawmanu and 286 in Kailashahar.

Incidentally, the Trinamool Congress came third in Kail-

ashahar, albeit with 696 votes, marginally above NOTA (537 votes). In Chawmanu, it secured fourth position with 566 votes, again just above NOTA (500).

With the rebel TMC MPs conveying their intention to move to the NCPI, it brings back memories of a similar situation that had unfolded in Arunachal Pradesh in 2016 when the Congress lost its government in the state. Its entire legislature party, barring former CM Nabam Tuki, joined the People's Party of Arunachal (PPA), which had become part

of the BJP-led North East Democratic Alliance (NEDA).

On December 31, 2016, Pema Khandu and 32 other legislators of the PPA switched loyalties to the BJP, giving the saffron party its first full-fledged government in the Northeast.

After the move, in the 60-member House, the BJP strength reached 45. The PPA count went down to 10 while the Congress was left with only three members. In the next elections in 2019, Khandu emerged victorious for BJP, winning 41 of 60 seats.

Three Kerala V-Cs draw ire of CM, Opp leader for attending Bhagwat's event

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, June 14

THE PRESENCE of Vice Chancellors of three universities in Kerala at an event addressed by RSS Sarsangchalak Mohan Bhagwat has triggered a political controversy in the state, with both the Chief Minister and the Leader of Opposition condemning their attendance.

Bhagwat addressed a lecture series in Thiruvananthapuram Saturday on "100 years of the Sangh's journey".

The event was attended by Kerala University V-C Dr Mohan Kunnummal, MG University V-C Dr D Mavoothu and Malayalam University V-C Dr C R Prasad, among other invited dignitaries and RSS leaders.

Kerala CM V D Satheesan said in a Facebook post that the attendance of the three V-Cs at Bhagwat's event was a matter of serious concern. "It is a serious lapse on the part of the V-Cs, and is not in tune with the state's educational tradition and the dignity of the post of the V-Cs. Kerala society holds the office of the VC in high regard," the Chief Minister said.

"Any action that encourages

communalism, whoever may be responsible for it, will not be accepted. Nor will it be tolerated. The three Vice Chancellors should apologise to Kerala," Satheesan added.

State Higher Education Minister Roji M John said at a time when "efforts are on to weaken the secular nature of universities, V-Cs should not have adopted such an approach".

"They should show the decency to admit before the public that they were wrong in attending the event," John said.

Opposition Leader Pinarayi Vijayan termed the incident an example of how the RSS is "attempting to tighten its grip on the higher education sector". "Why are the UDF and the state leadership hesitant to oppose BJP and Sangh Parivar," Vijayan asked. His statement came before the CM posted his criticism.

The Congress has been facing the allegation it has "surrendered to the Sangh Parivar agenda". The swearing-in ceremony had triggered a row over the full rendition of Vande Mataram, but the CM defended the government, saying the event was organised by the Lok Bhavan.

Himanta key factor, his ability to deliver unmatched: Sushmita on her exit from TMC

SUSHMITA DEV, once the TMC's face in Assam, has quit the party and resigned from the Rajya Sabha amid the meltdown in the Mamata Banerjee-led party. The daughter of Congress leader and former Union Minister, late Santosh Mohan Dev, she was with the Congress until 2021, when she switched to TMC. She spoke to **Atri Mitra**.

Why this decision? What disturbed you?

Reasons are many. Some, I would not like to reveal. My politics is in Assam and I feel AITC is handling a major crisis in Bengal, which is the focus. Prospects in Assam may not be there at all in the future. As a full-time politician I don't fear defeat... but to be able to work in Assam for people, this was the best decision. Internal turmoil in AITC just because of defeat is a grim picture. Exodus is unprecedented. Why has no one been able to contain it? Big question!

What were the circumstances which led to this?

I met Assam CM (Himanta Biswa Sarma) whom I have known since my early days in politics. I have seen his struggle and his rise. His vision and ability to deliver for the people of Assam is unmatched. I sought his advice and guidance straight after resigning. I have complete faith in whatever he decides for me. He has been a critical factor in (me) arriving at my decision.

Why are MLAs, MPs distancing themselves from the party?

I can only speculate but the public reactions on the ground towards TMC and the Bengal mandate may be a factor. Everyone wants a good future.



SUSHMITA DEV
FORMER TMC MP

There is a fine line between opportunity and opportunism.

Why so many resignations now?

That's the point, it can't be just the results or the defeat. I get the feeling that (they feel) distancing themselves will help shed negative public perception.

What are the reasons for the party's downfall?

Defeat has many reasons, can't be one. Can't blame only one person. My common sense tells me anti-incumbency is always a factor that influences change and this has been underplayed by AITC. Many grassroots leaders have let down Mamata ji in their misdemeanours. She couldn't control it somehow.

Any plans of aligning with the BJP?

The BJP high command will decide. The Assam results tell me the writing is on the wall. Congress had a crushing defeat... Coming from a region like Barak Valley, we have a lot of catching up to do and the last 10 years have shown me a quantum change in development and growth of the region. Internal politics of Congress in Assam always slowed down Barak Valley.

India, China in talks over joint UNESCO nomination for Xuanzang's work

Divya A
New Delhi, June 14

TO SPEED UP the process of safeguarding heritage, the BRICS countries are deliberating on filing joint nominations for various UNESCO lists. In this line, India and China are in advanced stages of discussions over a joint nomination for "The Great Tang Records on the Western Regions", a narrative of Chinese Buddhist monk and scholar Xuanzang's travels through medieval India in the 7th century.

The proposal, led by China and to be supported by India, is presently under consideration with the Ministry of External Af-

fairs, as per sources. China had earlier reached out through diplomatic channels to convey an interest in pursuing a joint nomination for an inscription in UNESCO's Intangible Cultural Heritage List.

The accounts of Xuanzang, also known as Hiuen Tsang, who spent 19 years travelling through India, remain a source for the study of early medieval India. He studied at the Nalanda University and captured the political, social and religious practices of the time in his accounts.

India also aims at securing a place for Panchatantra on the UNESCO list along with Iran as

E. EXPLAINED
Why joint nominations
The idea is to skip the queue since each country is allowed only two dossiers during the two-year cycle of UNESCO heritage lists, and most BRICS nations have a lot of heritage that needs safeguarding. As per officials, there is no limit on nations filing joint nominations, with the dossier led by one country, backed by others.

the fables have been a staple of Persian literature and folklore for over 1,500 years; as also for the philosophy of Satyagraha along with South Africa, official sources told *The Indian Express*.

This has come out of deliberations at the recent BRICS Culture Working Group meet under India's chair, which was attended by delegations from Brazil, China, South Africa, the UAE, Indonesia and Iran, with representatives from Russia, Ethiopia, and Egypt joining in hybrid mode.

The second meeting of the BRICS Culture Working Group was held in Varanasi earlier this month. At the inaugural session,

Union Culture Secretary, Vivek Aggarwal, highlighted BRICS countries are home to some of the world's oldest civilisations while also representing vibrant and evolving contemporary cultural landscapes. The recommendations from the Second Culture Working Group meet will be sent to BRICS Cultural Track ministerial meet in August in Bhopal, so they could be reflected in the joint statement by BRICS Culture Ministers.

At a panel discussion on "Collaborative Approaches for Safeguarding Shared Heritage: Joint Nominations under the UNESCO World Heritage Convention, Intangible Cultural

Heritage, and the Memory of the World Programme", during the meet, delegates explored opportunities for collaborative nominations among BRICS countries.

The idea is to skip the queue by filing joint nominations since each country is allowed only two dossiers during the two-year cycle of UNESCO heritage lists with most BRICS nations having a lot of heritage that needs to be safeguarded. As per officials, there is no limit on countries filing joint nominations, with the dossier led by one country, and supported by others.

In 2017, as India had sent Sowa-Rigpa, the Tibetan system of medicine, as its official entry

for UNESCO's Intangible Cultural Heritage list, China had also sent a similar entry, claiming Sowa-Rigpa as its own.

Ramesh C Gaur, Dean, Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts, the government's nodal agency for preparing and presenting these nominations, said, "BRICS nations have a lot of common, overlapping heritage — be it the Ramayana traditions equally popular in India and Indonesia, the Buddhist scriptures common to India and China, or Panchatantra in India and Iran. If we leverage joint nominations, we can achieve a lot towards safeguarding our civilisational heritage."



Ministry of Civil Aviation
Government of India



SOARING TOWARDS VIKSIT BHARAT, CONNECTING PEOPLE WITH PROGRESS

"Over the past decade, India's aviation sector has undergone a historic transformation, evolving from an exclusive club into the world's third-largest domestic aviation market"

- Narendra Modi, Prime Minister



Under the visionary leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, the Ministry of Civil Aviation is driving growth and connecting India with its landmark achievements and advancements

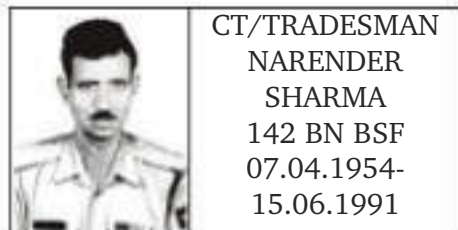


SALUTE THE SOLDIER

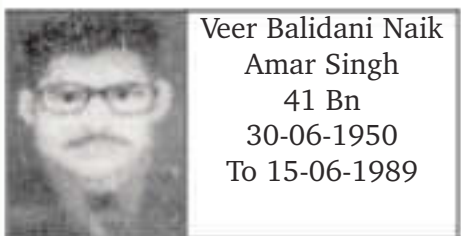
BORDER SECURITY FORCE

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans on their Balidan Divas.

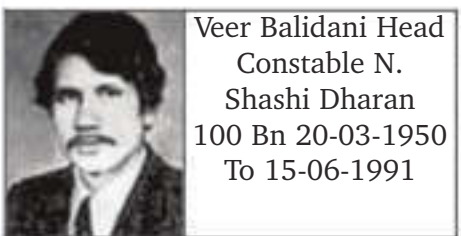
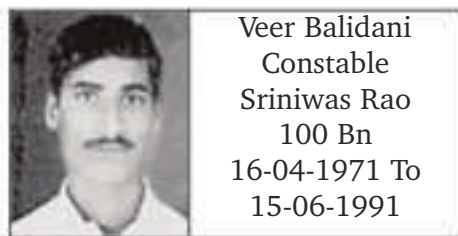
	LANCE NAIK CHINMOY BHOWMIK 11 BN BSF 02.01.1965- 15.06.1999		CONSTABLE BISHAN DAS 133 BN BSF 24.08.1965- 15.06.1991
--	--	---	--

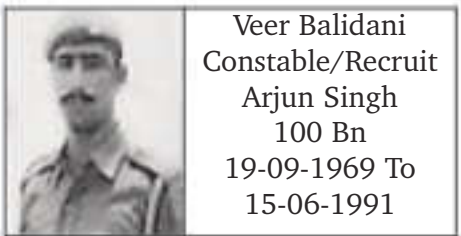
	CONSTABLE SANNI KUMAR 115 BN BSF 22.04.1972- 15.06.2002		CT/TRADESMAN NARENDER SHARMA 142 BN BSF 07.04.1954- 15.06.1991
--	---	---	---

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

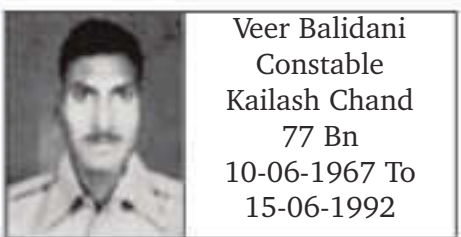
	Veer Balidani Naik Amar Singh 41 Bn 30-06-1950 To 15-06-1989		Veer Balidani Constable Laxmi Kant Barman 41 Bn 11-03-1966 To 15-06-1989
--	--	---	---

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Naik Amar Singh and Constable Laxmi Kant Barman of 41 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating terrorists during an operation in Amritsar district, Punjab on 15 June 1989. For their outstanding gallantry and unwavering devotion to duty, both were posthumously awarded the President's Police Medal for Gallantry. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain

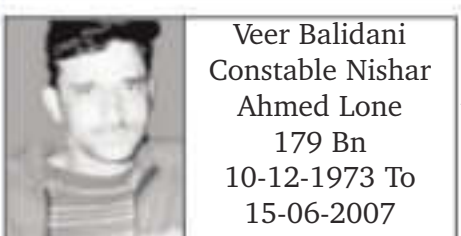
	Veer Balidani Head Constable N. Shashi Dharan 100 Bn 20-03-1950 To 15-06-1991		Veer Balidani Constable Srinivas Rao 100 Bn 16-04-1971 To 15-06-1991
--	---	---	---

	Veer Balidani Constable/Recruit Arjun Singh 100 Bn 19-09-1969 To 15-06-1991	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable N. Shashi Dharan, Constable Srinivas Rao, and Constable/Recruit Arjun Singh of 100 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating extremists	
---	--	--	--

during election duty in Warangal district, Andhra Pradesh on 15 June 1991. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain

	Veer Balidani Constable Kailash Chand 77 Bn 10-06-1967 To 15-06-1992	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Kailash Chand of 77 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating militants during a duty at Hari Singh High Street, Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir on 15 June 1992. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.	
--	---	--	--

1992. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

	Veer Balidani Constable Nishar Ahmed Lone 179 Bn 10-12-1973 To 15-06-2007	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Nishar Ahmed Lone of 179 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating militants in Sopore, Baramulla district, Jammu & Kashmir on 15 June 2007. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.	
--	--	---	--

salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

	Veer Balidani Constable Varun Kumar Tiwari 229 Bn 22- 08-1993 To 15-06- 2015	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Varun Kumar Tiwari of 229 Bn, who was grievously injured while bravely combating Maoists in Bijapur district, Chhattisgarh on 4 June 2015 and succumbed to his injuries on 15 June 2015. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain	
--	---	---	--

on 15 June 2015. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Hardeep Singh, S/o Ajit Singh Parmar, R/o V-691, Jal Vayu Vihar, Builders Area, Plot 8, Pocket 4, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201310, have changed my name to Hardeep Singh Parmar.

0071041946-1

I, Santosh Kumar Sharma S/o Chander Bhan Sharma R/o Flat No-74, Seemant Vihar Sector-14, Kaushambi, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, 201010, have changed my name to Santosh Sharma.

0071042053-1

I, Sandhya Shankar D/o Subhash Chand Gupta Ex W/o Sanjay Shankar R/o 1760/130, Shanti Nagar, Tri Nagar, Onkar Nagar, Delhi-110035, I got divorce from my Ex-husband vide Divorce Decree No. CIS No.HMA-109-2019.4., Dated 22/07/2019, have changed my name to Sandhya Gupta.

0071041980-1

I, Kaveri R/O Quarter No. D1-211, Type - 5B Satya Marg, Chanakya Puri, Po. Chanakya Puri, Dist - New Delhi, Delhi - 110021, Have Changed My Name To Kaveri Suman.

0071042054-1

I, Sneha Arora, W/O Saurabh Singh, R/O D-419, Gali No. 14A/6, Sadh Nagar, Palam Colony, South West Delhi-110045, have changed the name of my minor son (Date of Birth: 28/07/2024) from Adhvik Arora to Adhvik Singh. Henceforth, he shall be known and identified as Adhvik Singh for all future purposes.

0040860514-1

I, Deeksha Soni, D/o Subhash Soni Ex W/o Gaurav Koundil, R/o C-380 First Floor Sarita Vihar, New Delhi-110076, I got divorced from my Ex-husband vide Divorce Decree No. H.M.A. Case No.335 of 2026, Dated 24 February 2026, have changed the name of my minor daughter namely Aalia Koundil to Aalia Soni. Aged 12 years.

0071041979-1

I Umesh Singhal S/o Pratap Singhal R/o 13/68, 1st Floor, West Punjabi Bagh, New Delhi-110026 declare that my father's name be read as "Pratap Singhal" instead of Pratap (Partap) Singh

0040860558-1

I Prashant S/o Om Prakash R/o 158, Khanpur Village, Khanpur, Pushpa Bhawan, South Delhi-110062, have changed the name of my minor daughter Barbi to bhavika aged 10 years.

0071041976-1

I, NAEEMUDDIN, son of SALIM, R/o H.NO.B-59 GALI.NO.1 BHAGIRATHI VIHAR PHASE-1, GOKALPUR, NORTH EAST DELHI, DELHI-110094, have changed my name to NAEEMUDDIN, for all purposes 0040860596-1

LOST & FOUND

Lost Original Allotment Letter, DDA Handing Over Possession Letter, DDA Site Possession Letter, DDA NOC, Bank Challans, and other miscellaneous Documents of my DDA Janta Flat No.A-5/96, Sector-15, Rohini, Delhi. Finder may Contact-Karan Sabharwal at above noted address.

0040860553-1

MANEKSHAW CENTRE
PARADE ROAD, DELHI CANTT-10
NOTICE INVITING TENDER

1. ADG, Adm & Coord invites sealed tender from vendors for Outsourcing of Catering Services at Manekshaw Centre, Parade Road, Delhi Cantt-10 for a period of three years extendable as per the terms and conditions.
2. The tender documents (RFP) may be collected from Main Office, Manekshaw Centre, Parade Road, Delhi Cantt-10, between 1000hrs to 1700 hrs wef 15 June 2026 to 24 June 2026 on any working day against submission of tender documents for a fee of Rs 2,500/- in the form of bankers cheque/Demand Draft/Cash in favour of 'Manekshaw Centre Main Acct'.
3. Sealed tender documents as per RFP will be dropped in the tender box placed at the Office of Manekshaw Centre by 1100hrs on 09 July 2026.

"IMPORTANT"

Whilst care is taken prior to acceptance of advertising copy, it is not possible to verify its contents. The Indian Express (P) Limited cannot be held responsible for such contents, nor for any loss or damage incurred as a result of transactions with companies, associations or individuals advertising in its newspapers or Publications. We therefore recommend that readers make necessary inquiries before sending any monies or entering into any agreements with advertisers or otherwise acting on an advertisement in any manner whatsoever.

OFFICE OF EXECUTIVE ENGINEER CAPITAL DIVISION NO. 2.,
PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT, E-5, ARERA COLONY, BHOPAL

Phone-0755 2465467

No. 01/SAC/C-2/2026-27 Bhopal, dated: 01-06-2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Online Tenders are invited from registered contractors under centralized registration system in MP PWD for the following works. Details of the work and NIT is available on the website <http://mptenders.gov.in>.

S. No.	NIT No. & Date	Sistem Tender No.	Name of Work	Probable amount of contract	Amount of Earnest Money	Cost of Tender Document	Office in which Documents are to be submitted Physically
1	01/SAC dt 01.06.2026	2026_CPA_512123_1	Interior and exterior white washing, color washing and painting work of Mantralay Vallabh Bhawan-2, under Capital Sub Div. No.04, Bhopal (2ND Call)	Rs. 50.00 Lakhs (Fifty lakhs)	Rs.50,000/-	Rs. 5,000/-	Online submission only
2	02/SAC dt 01.06.2026	2026_CPA_512124_1	Interior and exterior white washing, color washing and painting work of Mantralay Vallabh Bhawan-3, under Capital Sub Div. No.04, Bhopal (2ND Call)	Rs. 50.00 Lakhs (Fifty lakhs)	Rs.50,000/-	Rs. 5,000/-	Online submission only
3	03/SAC dt 01.06.2026	2026_CPA_512125_1	A/R, S/R maintenance work of Mantralaya Vallabh Bhawan- 1, under Capital Sub Div. No.04, Bhopal (2ND Call)	Rs. 50.00 Lakhs (Fifty lakhs)	Rs.50,000/-	Rs. 5,000/-	Online submission only
4	04/SAC dt 01.06.2026	2026_CPA_512126_1	Water proofing, paver block and other misc. work for CPA Building (west side) Bhopal (Bittan Market) (2ND Call)	Rs. 25.00 Lakhs (Twenty Five lakhs)	Rs.50,000/-	Rs. 5,000/-	Online submission only
5	05/SAC dt 01.06.2026	2026_CPA_512128_1	Upgradation of water logging area (Jalbhara) for Master plan road from Kolar Square to Gulmohar Colony Length 210 M (2ND Call)	Rs. 27.51 Lakhs (Twenty seven lakhs fifty one thousand)	Rs.50,000/-	Rs. 5,000/-	Online submission only
6	06/SAC dt 01.06.2026	2026_CPA_512129_1	Upgradation of Water logging area (Jalbhara) for Master Plan road from Ishwar Nagar to Aura Mall Bhopal Length 150 M (2ND Call)	Rs. 20.19 Lakhs (Rs. Twenty lakhs nineteen thousand)	Rs. 40,380/-	Rs. 5,000/-	Online submission only
7	07/SAC dt 01.06.2026	2026_CPA_512395_1	Upgradation of water logging area (Jalbhara) for Master Plan road from DK Cottage to Bawadiya Kala Canal, Bhopal (2ND Call)	Rs. 27.29 Lakhs (Rs. Twenty seven lakhs twenty nine thousand)	Rs.50,000/-	Rs. 5,000/-	Online submission only

Tender form (documents) can be downloaded after online payment of the cost of the form from the above website. The last date of purchase, down load and online submission of tender form shall be 18/06/2026 upto 5.30 PM. Detailed NIT and other details are available on the website.

EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
CAPITAL DIVISION NO. 2,
PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT,
E-5, ARERA COLONY, BHOPAL
PH : 0755 2465467

G-14415/26



Police personnel keep watch at Patliputra station in Patna on Sunday. RAHUL SHARMA

Stones pelted, trains stopped: Chaos at railway stn in Patna ahead of police exam

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, June 14

TENSIONS PREVAILED in Patliputra Railway Station in Patna on Sunday after a large crowd of those travelling to appear for the Bihar Police Prohibition (Excise) Constable examination gathered at the station in the early hours of the day, leading to disruptions, stone-pelting and damage to property. Police later used force to disperse the crowd and restore normalcy.

According to officials, the unrest began when a group of exam candidates and others assembled at the station in large numbers. Authorities said some individuals repeatedly pulled the emergency chains on trains and demanded special trains. Officials also alleged that candidates who were willing to travel for the examination were being prevented from boarding trains.

Patna District Magistrate DrThiyagarajanSM said authorities received information late at night about disturbances at the station and rushed to the spot. "Late at night, we received information that some people were creating unrest at the railway station. We reached the spot and dispersed the crowd using mild force. The situation is now completely peaceful and under control, and there is no further problem," he said.

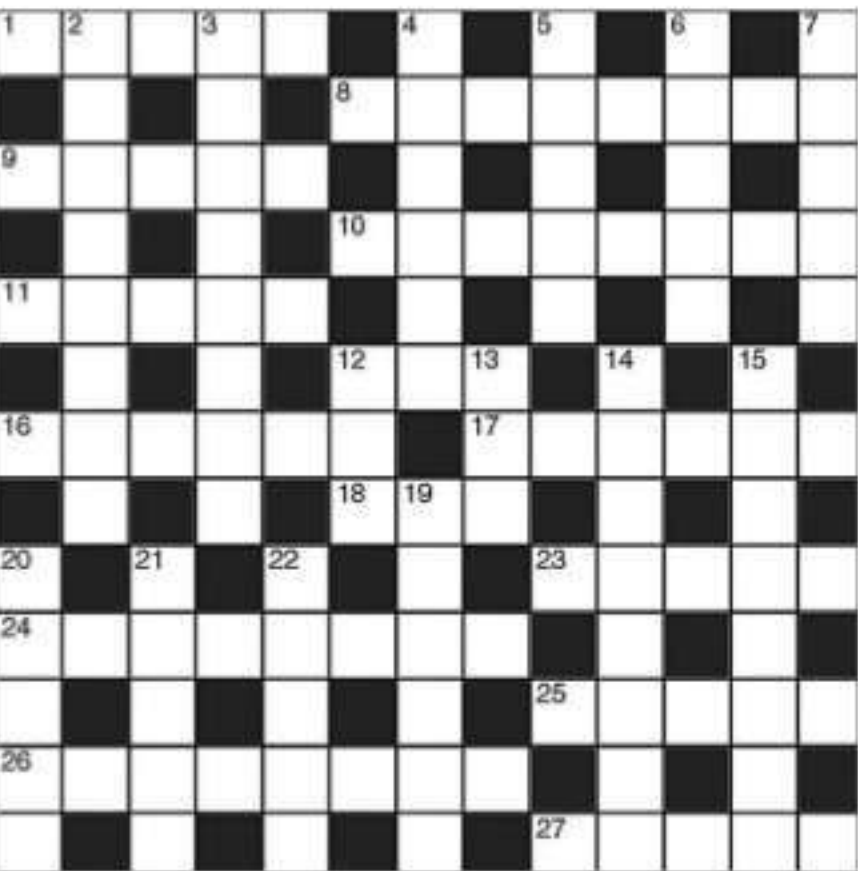
Thiyagarajan said some people were protesting over issues related to train arrangements. "Although special trains had been arranged and two special trains were already stationed there, some anti-social elements reportedly mixed in with the protesters and began pelting stones," he said, adding that peace was restored after police intervention.

Central Range (Patna) Inspector General of Police Jitendra Rana said around 200 to 250 students had gathered and were preventing a train from departing. "When police, along with the RPF, GRP and district police force, tried to persuade them to clear the way, some of them resorted to stone-pelting," Rana said.

He said police then took necessary action to prevent harm to life and property.

East Central Railway (ECR) Chief Public Relations Officer Saraswati Chandra said a large number of candidates appearing for the Bihar Excise Constable examination had assembled at Patliputra station and stopped Train No. 12488 (Seemanchal Express). While many students had boarded the train, a section of "so-called students" allegedly attempted to create disturbances. He said railway authorities had anticipated heavy passenger movement and had arranged a special train for Katihar as early as 2.30 am. The train subsequently departed at 5.47 am.

CROSSWORD



ACROSS

- 1 A firm supporter but a creeper (5)
- 8 Kept from retiring (8)
- 9 Minimum of a quarter allowed to go round (5)
- 10 The kindly feeling of its beneficiaries? (8)
- 11 Hard back (5)
- 12 Used for lighting and heating in Madagascar (3)
- 16 Girl with a new angle (6)
- 17 Trained marine pilots (6)
- 18 Pack animal (3)
- 23 Silent comedy film star (5)
- 24 No ways to go through congested areas (8)
- 25 Powerfully built breed of dog (5)
- 26 To encourage debts is false (8)
- 27 Fading and dingy; thrown out (5)

DOWN

- 2 Subtle implication but a patently obvious one (8)
- 3 Pounds perhaps in liquid assets (8)
- 4 Game and a vegetable with much stuffing (6)
- 5 Hazards of drivers and divers (5)
- 6 Stay clear when hungry prima donna turns up (5)
- 7 More than one figure is old-fashioned (5)
- 12 Badger served up as fish (3)
- 13 Not quite the identical person (3)
- 14 Try a ruse to get government money (8)
- 15 Is said to be ordered in advance (8)
- 19 A site for a roadway (6)
- 20 Lower seaman down into rough sea (5)
- 21 It may be smoked out if its den (5)
- 22 Bustling atmosphere around the street (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6014 ACROSS: 1 Speechless, 6 Puss, 10 Roast, 11 Barrister, 12 Bothered, 13 Italy, 15 Tea tray, 19 Sawdust, 19 Open-air, 21 Haricot, 22 Toast, 24 Military, 27 Well-oiled, 28 Koala, 29 Newt, 30 Greyhounds DOWN: 1 Serf, 2 Elaborate, 3 Catch, 4 Liberty, 5 Strides, 7 Ultra, 8 Sorry state, 9 Civil war, 14 Stood to win, 16 Reaction, 18 Uncertain, 20 Rambler, 21 Holiday, 23 Allow, 25 Tokyo, 26 Bays

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

_____ is just another way of keeping a ___ - Pablo Picasso (8,...,5)

MAAIR

●●●●●

AEUDNN

●●●●●

DGIIT

●●●●●

MSUGPY

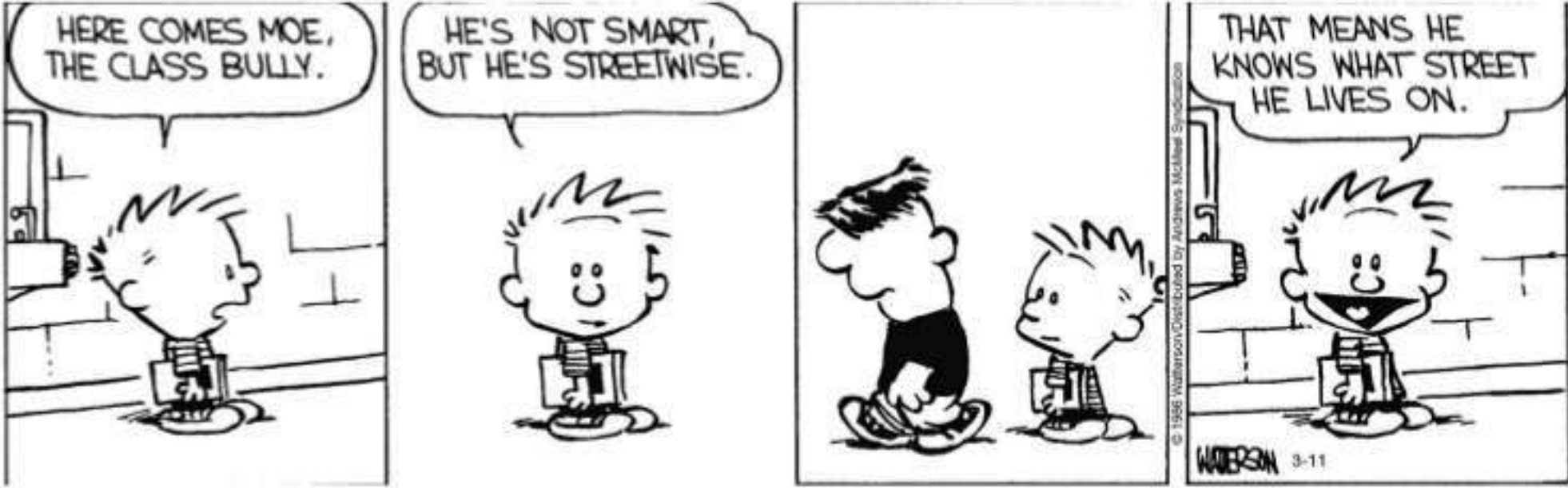
●●●●●

ANSWER: Painting is just another way of keeping a diary - Pablo Picasso

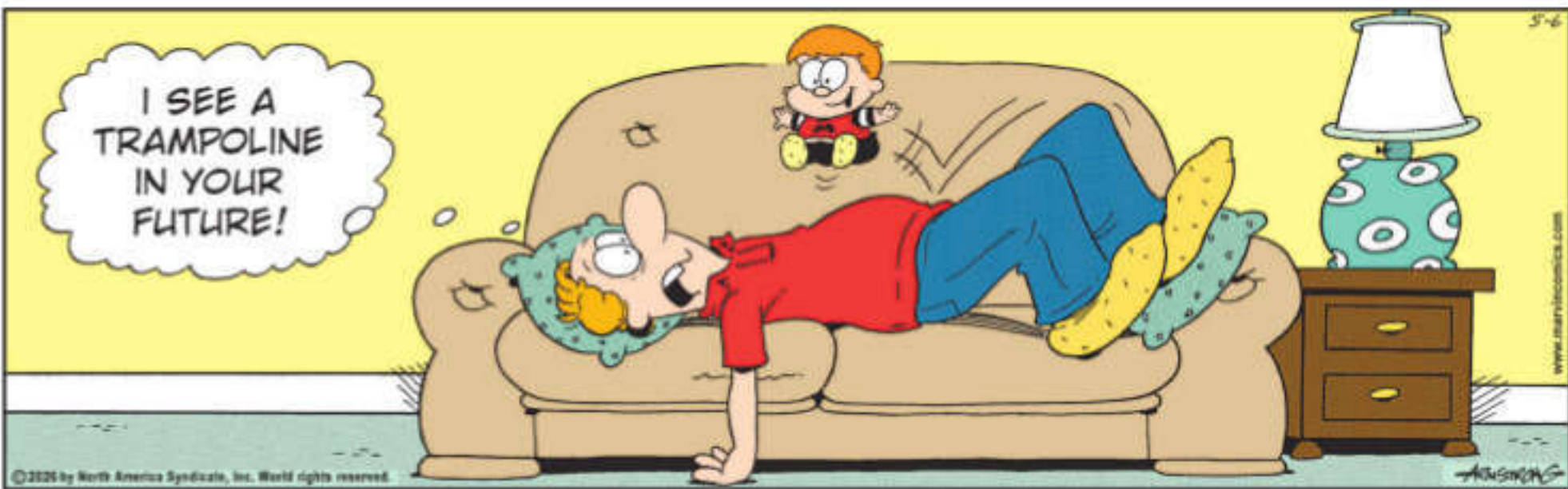
OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

8	4	7		2	
6	5		1		
4		6			
	9		5		
5	6			9	2
	3		2		
		3		9	
	2		8		4
1		9	4		3

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6349

6	1	4	2	9	3	8	5	7
3	7	8	5	1	4	9	2	6
5	2	9	6	7	8	4	3	1
9	6	5	1	8	7	3	4	2
1	3	2	4	5	6	7	9	8
4	8	7	3	2	9	1	6	5
7	9	3	8	6	2	5	1	4
2	4	1	7	3	5	6	8	9
8	5	6	9	4	1	2	7	3

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

BY BILL WATTERSON

BY TOM ARMSTRONG

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

♈

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Stay on your toes today, because surprise invitations to fun occasions, social outings or anything related to sports, the arts and the entertainment world might make your day. Children-related activities might be unpredictable. Tonight: Relax at home.

♉

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Stock the fridge, because your home routine might be interrupted today, hopefully, in a pleasant way. Surprise company might drop by. You might buy something beautiful for your home. A family member might have great news. Tonight: Conversations.

♊

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): It's a romantic day, so don't hesitate to make your move. Something will make you enjoy the beauty of your daily surroundings. Unexpected visits will please you. Tonight: Check your money.

♋

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Financial matters are a bit unpredictable today; nevertheless, a surprise gift, or a favour might benefit you out of the blue. Likewise, you might make some spontaneous purchases. Tonight: You win.

♌

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is a great day to talk with others. Romance is definitely favoured. Someone unusual might pop into your world. Or perhaps someone you already know will do something that surprises you. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

♍

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): With the Sun high in your chart, you look great to everyone! Meanwhile, something behind the scenes might surprise you or catch you off guard — very likely it's pleasant. Tonight: Be friendly.

♎

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): There's excitement in the air today, which could be due to an unexpected encounter with a friend or someone you haven't seen for a while. In either case, surprise romance might be waiting for you. Tonight: You're admired.

♏

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): When dealing with authority figures today, something unexpected but pleasant might happen. This could be a flirtation or the beginning of a new romance. Perhaps someone will recommend you for something. Tonight: Explore.

♐

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Remember that you need more sleep this week. Fortunately, unexpected opportunities to travel might fall in your lap. Meanwhile, discussions about finances, taxes, debt and inheritances will be positive. Tonight: Check your finances.

♑

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Keep your pockets open, because unexpected gifts from others might come your way today. Get ready for romantic promise in all your relationships. Because you're keen to work, you will accomplish a lot today. Tonight: Cooperate.

♒

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Exciting romance might sweep you off your feet today. Co-workers are supportive today. Be patient with family members, because activity and chaos at home might be challenging. Tonight: Work.

♓

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You want to relax and hide at home among familiar surroundings. You also might be more involved with a parent. Nevertheless, romance, social outings and a surprise work-related flirtation might catch you off guard. Tonight: Socialise.

India-flagged dhow sinks off Oman coast; all 14 crew rescued

Press Trust of India
Dubai, New Delhi, June 14

AN INDIA-FLAGGED dhow sank off the Oman coast following a mechanical failure, and all 14 crew members were rescued on Sunday, officials said.

The Indian Embassy in Oman said all 14 crew members rescued are "safe and in good health", adding that they were moved to a vessel which is heading to Mumbai. The Mumbai-bound vessel, MV Jabal Ali, is learnt to be a cargo ship.

"Rescue operation involving Indian Flagged MSV Virat 1 has been successfully completed. All 14 crew members have been rescued and are presently on-board Jabal Ali 9 heading to Mumbai. The crew members are safe and in good health," the mission said in a post on X.

Sources said the vessel sank because of "mechanical failure". Earlier, in a separate post, the Indian Embassy in Muscat said: "It has emerged that the vessel experienced an engine failure, and the crew eventually transferred safely to a life-raft. Rescue operation is presently underway..."

Accused in Khan 'Sir' centre vandalism case found dead in Nepal

Yubaraj Ghimire
& Himanshu Harsh
Kathmandu, Patna, June 14

AN ACCUSED in the case linked to the June 2 attack and vandalism at educator and YouTuber Faisal Khan's coaching institute in Patna has been found dead at a hotel in Nepal on Sunday.

Prince Yadav was the brother of Gyan Bindu Academy director Raushan Anand, who has been jailed in connection with the June 2 incident.

Prince (24) had arrived at the eastern Nepal town of Biratnagar, bordering Bihar's Jogbani, with four others a few days ago and checked into a hotel, local police said. According to the police, he had complained of uneasiness, and on Sunday morning, a local hospital declared him "brought dead".

Police in Nepal said they are investigating various possibilities. They have taken four of his companions into custody for questioning. They were identified as Ankit Yadav (28), Roshan Yadav (27), Latu Yadav (21) and Jayaram Yadav (30), all from Bihar's Saharsa. "We will only be able to come to a definite conclusion after we receive the post-mortem report," an officer said.

Prince's family members have arrived at the spot, Nepal police said, adding that authorities would coordinate with the Bihar Police wherever necessary. The development comes amid an ongoing investigation in Bihar into violence outside Faisal Khan's institute, Khan Global Studies (KGS), in Patna on the night of June 2.

Prince was named in the FIR lodged by KGS manager Kanhaiya Kumar Singh. According to the complaint, around 15 to 20 persons allegedly associated with Gyan Bindu Coaching Institute arrived at the coaching centre around 10.10 pm after

Ladakh agreement hits roadblock over 'key omissions' in fine print

Clause to allow administrative head having a say in posting of bureaucrats omitted from minutes of the meeting

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, June 14

THE AGREEMENT between the Ministry of Home Affairs and civil society leaders of Ladakh on giving the region a "representative administration" appears to have run into rough weather over non-inclusion of certain points in the minutes of the meeting (MoM) held on May 22, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Sources said that while a broad agreement has been reached, the MoM prepared by the MHA did not include many crucial points that had been agreed upon. This has led to the Ladakh leaders not signing the MoM. The MHA has also not yet scheduled another meeting.

According to sources, the point of contention is the non-inclusion of a clause that would allow the elected Ladakh administrative head to write the

Annual Performance Appraisal Report of the Chief Secretary and have a say in transfer and posting of bureaucrats. Another omission, sources said, has been that a solution to Ladakh's demands for Sixth Schedule would be found under a statute modelled on sub-articles A, F and G of Article 371.

"It was the MHA which had come up with a proposal during the last meeting. We had already given our proposal on our demands for Sixth Schedule and statehood. They asked us for flexibility and came up with this Article 371 proposal and self-administration under the UT structure. We accepted it. So we were a bit surprised to not find them mentioned in the MoM," a Ladakh leader said.

An official of the MHA said that not all fine details are written in the MoM, and largely the broad agreements are men-

tioned. "Things are being worked out," the official said.

However, another Ladakh leader said, "The issue of services being under the elected administrative head is of great importance to us. We are anyway not being given statehood, not even a UT with legislature as it is elsewhere. We are being given an elected administrative head with executive, legislative and revenue powers. He is merely being called a Chief Minister. If the CM has no jurisdiction over services, he will become toothless. We know what has happened in other UTs. So we have to have it in writing."

Government sources said this was a minor hiccup and negotiations were on track. Yet, the MHA has not scheduled another meeting with Ladakh leaders. The last meeting with the leaders, held on May 22, was a sub-committee meeting. The meeting of the High-Powered Committee on issues concerning Ladakh — these are held under the leadership of MoS Home Nityanand Rai — is yet to be scheduled.

In a breakthrough after months of protests, negoti-

ations, and political mobilisation in Ladakh, representatives of the Apex Body, Leh (ABL) and Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) had on May 22 claimed that they had reached "in-principle understanding" with the Centre on "restoring democracy in Ladakh" and providing "Constitutional safeguards on the lines of Article 371 A, F, and G", following talks with senior Union Home Ministry officials.

"In this model, the legislative, executive and financial powers will rest with elected representatives through a Union Territory-level legislative body," the ABL and KDA had said in a statement.

"All bureaucrats of the UT, including the Chief Secretary, will come under the executive head of the UT-level elected body (proposed to be Chief Minister)."

Incidentally, the MHA, which was also supposed to issue an official statement on the agreement, never came out with one.

The May 22 developments had marked the most substantive movement yet on Ladakh's political demands since the re-

gion was separated from the erstwhile state of J&K and made a Union Territory without a legislature in 2019. While the move was initially welcomed by many in Leh, concerns steadily grew in both Leh and Kargil over the absence of Constitutional safeguards protecting land, jobs and cultural identity, as well as the concentration of administrative authority in the bureaucracy.

The ABL and KDA — umbrella groupings representing civil society, political and religious organisations from Leh and Kargil, respectively — have since jointly spearheaded an agitation demanding statehood, Sixth Schedule status, constitutional protections, a separate Public Service Commission and enhanced parliamentary representation for Ladakh.

The movement gained national prominence through activist Sonam Wangchuk, who was also present in the May 22 meeting. Wangchuk had led fasts and public campaigns pressing the Centre to fulfil assurances made after the 2019 reorganisation of J&K.

• BRIEFLY



Rescue operations underway in Solapur on Sunday. EXPRESS

MAHARASHTRA

Four children among eight killed as pick-up van falls into well in Solapur

Eight persons, including a six-month-old boy and three other children, were killed after a pick-up van carrying 15 pilgrims plunged into a well in Solapur district on Sunday. Seven people were rescued. According to police, the pilgrims were returning after visiting the Siddhanath temple in Mhaswad, Solapur district, when the pick-up van fell into a well. SP, Solapur rural, Atul Kulkarni, said, "The eight deceased include four children and four adults." Another senior officer said prima facie probe suggests that the driver lost control on the vehicle after which it fell into the well on the roadside. ENS

Kannur: Gold worth Rs 1.88 cr seized at airport

THE CUSTOMS Preventive Commissionerate on Sunday arrested a passenger and seized gold worth Rs 1.88 crore from him at Kannur International Airport, officials said. The arrested person was identified as Abdul Ramsheed. According to officials, Ramsheed had arrived from Sharjah. Acting on suspicion, officers of the Customs Preventive Commissionerate intercepted and questioned him, officials said. Subsequent examination and scanning led to the detection of four capsules containing gold compound concealed in his rectum, officials said. PTI

Karnataka: Three drown in Hassan reservoir

THREE YOUTHS from Bengaluru drowned in the backwaters of the Hemavathi reservoir in Karnataka's Hassan district on Sunday, police said. The deceased were identified as Charan (20), Milan (23) and Manikantha (20). According to police, a group of 10 youths had travelled to Dharmasthala and were returning after offering prayers at the Shri Manjunatha Swamy Temple when they stopped near Shettihalli Church at Gorur, where some of them entered the reservoir backwaters for a swim. Preliminary inquiries revealed the youths did not know how to swim, police said. PTI

Royal family feud, a petrol pump, proposed resort: Behind shooting at fort in MP's Satna

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, June 14

THE PRINCELY state of Nagod in Madhya Pradesh formally disappeared in 1950 when its ruler signed the Instrument of Accession. But while the kingdom vanished from India's political map, the family that once ruled it did not. Stripped of sovereignty but not of land, property or influence, the former royals reinvented themselves as one of the most prominent landed and political families in the Vindhya region of central India.

The forces pulling the family apart are not entirely unfamiliar. As in earlier chapters of the dynasty's history, disputes over property, succession and control of family assets lay at the heart of the conflict, turning private disagreements into a bitter feud, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The dispute spilled into public view on June 11, when Yogita Singh, the estranged wife of Rupendra Kumar Singh, was shot in the abdomen during a confrontation at the family's Parsmania Garhi fort in Satna district. Police have arrested Sunita Singh Parihar, who allegedly fired the .22-bore rifle used in the shooting. Yogita's family alleges that Parihar shared a close personal relationship with Singh, a claim that Singh's representatives reject, describing her instead as a long-time business partner and investor in family ventures.

Behind the criminal investigation lies a dispute that family members say had been building for years. At issue were not only a marriage that had broken down, but also disagreements over the management of a petrol pump, a proposed resort project inside the fort and the future control of assets associated with one of the region's most prominent former royal households.

At the centre of the dispute is



Rupendra Singh is a member of the Nagod royal family; (right) his associate Sunita has been arrested for firing at his estranged wife



Rupendra Singh, popularly known as Baba Raja, a member of the Nagod royal family and a relative of a sitting BJP MLA. The son of Kantidev Singh, Rupendra has long managed the family's affairs at Parsmania Garhi, a sprawling fort estate near Unchehra.

Belonging to a prominent family of Udaipur in Rajasthan, Yogita married Rupendra Singh in 2000, later served as sarpanch of Parsmania panchayat and is the mother of the couple's only son, Prithudev Singh.

Originally from Umri village in Satna district, Parihar first became associated with social work and NGO activities in the Parsmania area before entering Rupendra Singh's business circle. According to a representative of Rupendra Singh, Parihar had been associated with him since 2016 and was involved in several commercial ventures. "She is not only a working partner but also a financial partner in multiple ventures. She has invested money in businesses connected to him, including the petrol pump and the proposed resort project at Parsmania Garhi," the representative told *The Indian Express*.

The petrol pump emerged as one of the central points of conflict. According to the representative, the proprietorship of the outlet remained with Yogita Singh, but disputes arose over its management and operation.

The representative said Parihar had played an active role in the business and had invested in it. He also said operations at the outlet had been suspended for a period before being restored.

The disagreement extended beyond the fuel station. Discussions were also underway regarding the commercial development of Parsmania Garhi itself. Family members and people familiar with the matter say "parts of the fort were being considered for conversion into a hospitality venture". According to Rupendra Singh's representative, Parihar was also an investor in the proposed resort project.

By 2024, the marriage between Rupendra and Yogita Singh had entered a legal phase of separation. "They are not divorced, but Rupendra Singh filed for separation in 2024. For some time before the incident, Yogita was not residing with him... There had been longstanding differences between them and several disputes arising out of the separation," the representative said.

The confrontation on June 11 unfolded against that backdrop.

In an FIR registered on the basis of a complaint lodged by Rupendra Singh, he alleged that his brother-in-law, Nagendra Singh Rathore, and two others assaulted him using broken glass, pieces of a chandelier cover and a steel bottle. He

claimed injuries to multiple parts of his body and alleged that he was threatened before the men left. An FIR based on a complaint from Yogita Singh's side alleges that she was shot at during the confrontation. Parihar was subsequently arrested and sent to judicial custody.

The dispute was also shaped by the position of the couple's son. Several people familiar with the family described him as the next-generation heir to Rupendra Singh's branch of the household. One member of the extended family said that even after relations between Rupendra and Yogita deteriorated, discussions surrounding Prithudev's future remained central to interactions between the two sides.

Said a member from the royal family, "The couple (Rupendra and Yogita) last time met at a family function in Jaipur, where Rupendra Singh said he could not live with her, but allayed all fears that their son would not inherit the property. However, that did not help."

Yogita Singh's family rejects the suggestion that the dispute was confined to business disagreements. Family members allege that Parihar's growing role in the affairs of Parsmania Garhi, her involvement in businesses linked to the estate and her presence at the fort had been a source of tension for several years. They contend that the "conflict gradually widened from a marital dispute into a broader disagreement over influence, access and decision-making within the household".

Police say they are proceeding cautiously. "These are all aspects that will be investigated if such statements come before police. At present, our primary focus is on the shooting incident..." Additional Superintendent of Police Prem Lal Kurwe told *The Indian Express*.



Authorities raze alleged illegal structures belonging to an accused in the killing of a man in Dehradun, on Sunday. PTI

Dehradun: Water row between neighbours turns deadly, sparks communal tension

Aiswarya Raj
Dehradun, June 14

A MAN was killed and his family was attacked on Saturday evening, allegedly by their neighbours, over a dispute on irrigation in their agricultural fields in Dehradun, police said. The incident has led to communal tensions in the area and a large police contingent has been deployed in an effort to prevent further escalation.

According to police, Vinod Kumar and his family had an ongoing dispute with their neighbour, Imtiaz, over water supply in their fields. On Saturday evening, the altercation resulted in violence, leading to the death of Kumar. Three other family members, including the complainant in the matter, Kumar's brother Ashok, are receiving treatment at the hospital.

Dehradun SSP Pramendra Dobhal said four people have been arrested in connection with the case. A part of the property belonging to the accused was demolished.

Following Vinod Kumar's killing, groups and residents from the majority community gathered in the area, chanting anti-minority slogans and demanding the "encounter of the accused and razing of their houses with bulldozers".

A group of people also tried to set fire to the house of the ac-

cused, said police. "They tried to enter the property, and set fire to the fields. However, police managed to contain it and curb further activities. We have deployed platoons of IRB, PAC, and other forces," said SP, Crime, Jitender Chaudhary. SSP Dobhal said, "We are bringing in more forces from different areas."

Sahaspur Circle Officer Anuj Kumar said a communally charged environment has been reported from the area. "We have the videos in which such speeches were made. We will look into those. However, our priority remains maintaining law and order," the CO said.

As per the complaint, Ashok Kumar, the brother of the deceased, said they had an ongoing dispute regarding water with their neighbour, Imtiaz. "Around 6 pm on Saturday, Razak, Imtiaz, Aman, Yunus, Shahbaz, Sharafal Ali, Masoom, Adil, Shamoon, Salman, Javed, Intazar (all booked), along with 30-35 other persons, came to our house. They were armed with sticks, wooden planks, and a hammer... they launched a murderous assault on members of our family," the complaint said. In the attack, his older brother Vinod died, while the other family members sustained serious injuries, he added. The FIR was lodged under sections of murder, attempted murder, rioting, and common intention.

Make way for the 'Queen': Tripura eyes global status for state fruit

Jatin Anand
Agartala, June 14

FOR GENERATIONS, the family of this farmer in Tripura's Killa region has been growing pineapples.

As the state gears up to organise the Tripura Global Pineapple Festival at New Delhi later this month, it has given farmers like him the hope that the GI-tagged fruit of their labour will finally get its global moment under the sun. "We are happy with the government's push for both varieties (the Queen and Kew Pineapple), especially with the supply chain, which was an issue due to limited road connectivity," said the farmer who did not wish to be named.

As the fruit seeks to make its presence officially felt in the national capital, the state govern-

ment says it has already decided on the next big steps in its bid to make 'Tripura Pineapple' a global brand.

The Queen Pineapple was declared the state fruit in 2018, four years after it attained the GI tag for its golden-yellow hue and a distinct aroma besides its flesh laden with vitamins, calcium, magnesium, potassium and iron. The fruit is at the core of the three-year-long 'Mission Queen Pineapple' of Tripura, one such Centrally-funded farm-to-plate programme worth Rs 236 crore launched on May 27. The state is currently witnessing execution of a slew of developmental projects assisted by various Central bodies, including the Jyotiraditya Scindia-led Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region (MDoNER).

Pineapple is cultivated in



The Queen Pineapple was declared the state fruit of Tripura in 2018. EXPRESS

more than half of the state's eight districts and especially by its significant tribal population which constitutes over 30% of Tripura.

Besides the fruit, its ancillary products such as thread derived from its leaves, besides chocolates, jams and jellies will also

make their debut at the three-day festival which will kick off at Major Dhyan Chand National Stadium on June 27 — the International Pineapple Day. According to Tripura government sources, PM Narendra Modi will likely attend the event.

"Our state is emerging as a significant player in North East's agro-marketing and export landscape by producing exported agricultural commodities such as pineapple, jackfruit, banana, scented lemon, organic produce like scented rice, bird's eye chili... and other bamboo products," Tripura Agriculture and Farmers Welfare Minister Ratan Lal Nath said.

"Tripura's unique agro-climatic condition makes it one of India's leading pineapple-producing regions where Queen and Kew varieties are mostly cul-

tivated by tribal growers in four to five of our eight districts. At present, we have about 11,698 hectares of pineapple area with a production of 1.71 lakh MT per annum. Approximately 23,000 MT Pineapple remains as marketable surplus per annum," he added.

The Queen and Kew varieties of pineapple flourish alongside paddy and sugarcane in Tripura's remote hills, especially in Gomati district's Killa region. A key USP of the fruit is the zero to minimal utilisation of chemicals in its cultivation almost year-round. "The only issue we face is the cleaning of the fields for replantation..." said the farmer quoted above.

Minister Nath said the government is working to establish strong market linkages for the produce. "Since 2018-19, we have

exported 33.10 MT Queen and Kew varieties of pineapple to countries like the UAE and Bangladesh. Besides, 74 MT canned pineapple has been exported to Germany and Russia..." Nath added. "It is also creating new job opportunities in processing, packaging and marketing, contributing to the overall economic development of rural areas of the state," he said.

The pineapple festival is expected to facilitate direct linkages of Tripura's farmers with buyers, exporters and food-processing companies to highlight the potential for agri-investment and value chain development in the North East Region, as it seeks to explore markets in Southeast Asia, the Middle East and Europe, said Nath. (The writer was on a four-day visit to the state organised by MDoNER ministry)

Make it clear: Indian sailors are not collateral damage

THE KILLING of three Indian sailors in a US strike on the oil tanker MT *Settebello* in the Gulf of Oman is a tragic incident that adds a further complication to a bilateral relationship going through an uneasy phase. India has, rightly, voiced its objections strongly, summoning the US chargé d'affaires in New Delhi twice to protest this and other attacks that have endangered the lives of Indian mariners. External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said that, in a call with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, he had “reiterated India’s strong protest”. That the US State Department’s account of the call fails to mention the deaths, and claims that “all commercial vessels should immediately comply with orders from US forces”, flies in the face of international conventions and betrays a callous lack of acknowledgement of the incident’s gravity. President Donald Trump’s intervention — blaming Iran for alleged drone strikes against “Indian” ships, which Tehran has denied — is hardly helpful.

This, together with the Trump Administration’s bid to impose higher tariffs on India via US Trade Representative investigations, hurts attempts — such as the reassurances offered by Rubio during his recent visit and the efforts of Ambassador Sergio Gorría — to set the ties back on course. The episode underlines the vulnerability of Indian seafarers — who number around 3.08 lakh, about 12 per cent of the global pool — in the West Asia conflict. Attacks on neutral merchant shipping in war have been a contentious aspect of international law, and the era of open registries, flags of convenience and a globalised workforce has only worsened the ambiguities; a ship may be flagged in Palau, run by a Dubai-based operator and crewed by Indians, as in the present case. The US has sought to justify its strike on the *Settebello* by alleging that the vessel violated its blockade of Iranian ports and the crew ignored warnings, which can be grounds for attack under the established law. The ship’s operator, IOS Marine FZE, has denied the charge.

With lakhs of its citizens potentially in danger, India has critical stakes in ensuring that such attacks do not recur, that mariners have better protections, and that the blockade is lifted. The US must ensure that civilian seafarers do not continue to become collateral damage. Both Trump and the Iranians have signalled that a peace deal may be in the offing. If it happens, the opening of the Strait of Hormuz will be a relief to the whole world, especially to those risking their lives on the high seas. Meanwhile, New Delhi, even as it rolled out the red carpet for Secretary Rubio last month, should keep reminding him of its red lines as well, especially when it comes to the life — and death — of Indian citizens.

Urea price crash opens window for reforms

IN MID-February, 10 days before the United States-Israel strikes on Iran, the state-owned Rashtriya Chemicals and Fertilisers contracted about 1.3 million tonnes (mt) of urea imports at a landed price of \$508-512 per tonne. Two months later, that price nearly doubled to \$935-959 per tonne for a 2.5-mt import tender of Indian Potash Ltd. However, National Fertilisers Ltd’s latest tender for import of 1.7 mt, which opened on June 8, saw bids as low as \$444.9-449.3 per tonne. The price crash — to below pre-War levels — comes amid a partial lifting of export restrictions by China and fading fears of prolonged war-induced supply disruptions. Contrast this with the situation till early this month, when the Centre’s fertiliser subsidy bill for 2026-27 was projected to touch Rs 3,40,000 crore, as against the budgeted Rs 1,70,799 crore.

It’s not clear if the above price drop is a one-off affair, triggered by hopes of a US-Iran deal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, through which roughly a third of the globally traded fertiliser products passed prior to the conflict. The expectation of global supply chain pressures easing has been combined with El Niño conditions developing in the equatorial Pacific Ocean and the US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration predicting it to become a “very strong” event by October. El Niño, to the extent it moderates fertiliser demand in key agricultural regions of the world, will add to the weakening of price pressures from supply-side relief. That matters for India, not the least because much of its fertiliser requirement — whether in finished form or as raw materials and intermediate chemicals — is imported. In 2025-26, the country imported \$27.2 billion worth of fertilisers and inputs. The current fiscal could see that surpass the record \$33.4 billion of 2022-23, post Russia’s invasion of Ukraine. The exchequer outgo on subsidy is over and above.

The Narendra Modi government should view the cooling of global fertiliser prices as a temporary reprieve. It provides the space for carrying out much-needed reforms in India’s farm subsidy architecture. This newspaper has for long argued in favour of shifting from market-distorting product-specific subsidies — be it for inputs (fertilisers, water and electricity) or crops (through minimum support prices disconnected from demand and supply) — to direct farm income support. Farmers should grow what the market wants. And they must do so efficiently, which means paying the scarcity value of water, energy and imported inputs. The goal of reforms is to nudge them in this direction, unlike ad hoc interventions that only kick the can down the road.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



The Editorial Page



PARAMESWARAN IYER, ARUNABHA GHOSH AND NITIN BASSI

WHAT IS common between Narsinghpur in Madhya Pradesh, Ahmedabad in Gujarat, and Barmner in Rajasthan? These cities have reported maximum daytime temperatures north of 40 °C in the first week of May. The high temperatures have led to water scarcity, driven by high evaporation rates and increased demand for domestic water. For many small cities and towns, private tanker water supply has become a norm during summer. Bigger cities such as Delhi are sourcing water from far-off places, often leading to higher costs and dependence on upper riparian regions.

The annual per capita water availability in India is about 1,500 m³, which is likely to fall below 1,200 m³ by 2050, edging us closer to the water scarcity threshold of 1,000 m³. The reduced water availability, coupled with the water scarcity during scorching summers and increasing heatwaves, calls for more proactive water action. The larger question is what can cities do differently?

One intervention with immense (and thus far unrealised) potential is integrating the reuse of treated used water (domestic sewage), especially for non-potable purposes such as irrigating horticultural crops, land-

scaping, construction, public conveniences, textile manufacturing, lake rejuvenation, and wherever there is no direct contact with humans. As per an analysis by the Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW), this can unlock a market and investment opportunity worth over Rs 3 lakh crore and generate 1,00,000 additional jobs by 2047. Also, implementing a circular water economy will help ease water stress. For instance, Thane city can bridge its existing water deficit of 53 million litres per day through scaling up the reuse of treated used water. Four interrelated actions can unlock these benefits.

First, the policy on water reuse must be complemented by city-specific reuse plans. About 14 Indian states now have water reuse policies. Uttarakhand, UP and Odisha are the latest states to realise seasonal water risks and notify reuse policies. While this is a step in the right direction, city-specific reuse plans are needed, which would have clear targets to address existing water deficits and water quality issues, reuse avenues, reuse water quality requirements, revenue generation options, and implementation mechanisms. Each city has a unique reuse requirement. For instance, in Delhi, Varanasi, and Bengaluru, the priority for water reuse is in agriculture in peri-urban areas, whereas in Chennai, it is for rejuvenating water bodies and lakes, and in Thane, for construction, or for industrial use in Surat.

Second, enable private financing for reuse projects. Urban areas have less than 50 per cent of networked sewage treatment capacity, and less than one-third was actually treated in 2021. There are many reasons for this, including the absence of infrastructure to

Institutional reforms are needed to enable urban local bodies to set up special-purpose instruments to manage reuse projects and convert them into a business opportunity

Focus on knowledge, not on whose system it is



ROHAN MANOJ

DO YOU have a niggling suspicion of “Western” medicine? It’s understandable. As many Indians will tell you, such foreign concoctions are drastic measures. For routine ailments, indigenous remedies will suffice. Quite apart from whether this advice works in specific cases, it does something else: It dethrones “Western” medicine from its position of privilege — as doctors often emphasise, there’s no such thing as “Western” medicine, only modern medicine — and casts it into a swamp of relativism. It calls into question the primacy of modern science, the foundation on which modern medicine is built. This makes it an epistemic matter — relating to knowledge itself.

As a debate on Indian Knowledge Systems unfolds in these pages, it’s important to emphasise that this is also a bid to build an epistemic paradigm. If it were simply about understanding the intellectual traditions of the past as part of the study of history, it would be called Indian Intellectual History. If it were simply about documenting living oral and folk traditions, that would be an entirely different field. Drawing on traditional practices to create sustainable architecture is a third, separate area. All these are laudable and uncontroversial aims, and the research ought to be strongly supported. The Brahmanical nature of many Sanskrit texts is no reason not to study them; rather, anti-caste scholars should study the *Dharmashastras* precisely because they provided the jurisprudential scaffolding of caste.

However, bringing these and other fields together, under the rubric of “knowledge systems”, makes them part of the fashionable “civilisational” agenda, which seeks to recover an authentic Indian paradigm of knowledge. The question is, to what end? Would exploring, say, pre-modern Indian science or mathematics through anything other than a historical lens serve any purpose? Would this advance the global understanding of science or mathematics?

Such a project implicitly relativises modern science, handing it over to the “West” and forfeiting any Indian claim to

it. This depends on, and props up, the hackneyed notion that there are such things as discrete, insular “civilisations”. In this telling, “Western Civilisation” traces an unbroken arc from Ancient Greece and Rome to present-day Europe and America. It chooses to forget that this is a story Europeans started telling themselves a few centuries ago, replacing the older framework of “Christendom”. It also forgets the multifarious influences that went into the formation of both the “West” and of modern science. For instance, consider *Hortus Malabaricus*, the 17th-century botanical treatise compiled by the governor of Dutch Malabar, drawing to a great extent on the Ayurvedic knowledge of Itty Achudan, a physician from Kerala. In the 18th century, Carl Linnaeus, who laid the foundations of modern plant and animal taxonomy, used *Hortus Malabaricus* as his main reference for South Asian flora, basing his Latin names on the existing Malayalam ones. Is this Western knowledge?

Pre-modern Indian scholars worked within a living tradition, engaging with each other across time and space and expanding the base of knowledge with each generation; often, they sneaked in original contributions under the guise of commentaries. If Patanjali’s *Mahabhashya* was a commentary on Panini and Katyayana, Bhartrhari’s *Mahabhashyatika* was a commentary on Patanjali, and so on. That world has vanished. Reconstructing it, or rather, constructing something new, building an edifice on pre-modern foundations to address modern problems, would be an inauthentic and ultimately quixotic enterprise.

Let’s turn to our neighbour and fellow “civilisational state”. What often comes up in discussions of China is its astonishing progress in all scholarly fields, be it STEM, the social sciences, or the humanities. Is it all thanks to working within its own paradigm of knowledge? Well, one has heard of communism with Chinese characteristics. But one does not often hear of chemistry with Chinese characteristics.

The writer is senior assistant editor, The Indian Express. rohan.manoj@expressindia.com



VIVEK MISHRA



VIVEK MISHRA



VIVEK MISHRA

Trump administration’s actions, tethered to Washington’s interests, may be undermining the promise of strategic frameworks

clean the much-polluted Ganga was formally launched by Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi in Varanasi. Describing the Ganga as the symbol of India’s unity, civilisation, and prosperity, the Prime Minister called for a people’s movement to clean the Ganga and to take up other such environmental programmes. The Varanasi waterfront, which is one of the most polluted stretches of the river, was chosen as the launching pad for the Ganga action plan.

clean the much-polluted Ganga was formally launched by Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi in Varanasi. Describing the Ganga as the symbol of India’s unity, civilisation, and prosperity, the Prime Minister called for a people’s movement to clean the Ganga and to take up other such environmental programmes. The Varanasi waterfront, which is one of the most polluted stretches of the river, was chosen as the launching pad for the Ganga action plan.

Territory settlement stalled

VARIOUS ALTERNATIVES are being discussed at different political levels to break the deadlock created by the resolution of the Punjab Cabinet on the report of the Venkataramiah Commission. Indications are that the Centre

● WORDLY WISE

Political and legal institutions play a central role in setting the environment that can nurture prosperity and economic growth. — Angus Deaton

up ZLD policies are good examples.

Fourth, create a national circular water mission to shift water management from a linear use-and-dispose approach to a restorative model that maximises its reuse. This will require technological, institutional, financial, and behavioural reforms. Technological reforms should target building more decentralised faecal sludge treatment plants in the growing peri-urban areas. Institutional reforms are needed to enable urban local bodies to set up special-purpose instruments to manage reuse projects and convert them into a business opportunity. Financial instruments must be designed to incentivise those reusing treated used water and reclassify freshwater as an asset class. While the introduction of market-based freshwater pricing for all users should drive efficiency, targeted subsidies must be maintained to protect those at the base of the economic pyramid. Lastly, but importantly, are the behavioural nudges to make used water everyone’s business. By shifting public perception, treated used water and its reuse can be made an essential component of life in a city. The recently published study, ‘Water, Nature, Progress,’ and the Economic Survey of India 2025-26 have laid down the roadmap for a circular water mission in India.

India’s journey to Viksit Bharat by 2047 will depend on how boldly it builds water resilience. A circular water economy can be the lighthouse — it can reduce freshwater stress, improve water quality, and secure water for all. India has the political leadership, will, and proof of concept. What it needs now is action — at scale, at speed, and with urgency.

Iyer is India’s executive director at the World Bank, Ghosh is founder-CEO CEEW, and Bassi is fellow at CEEW. Views are personal

From tariffs to tankers, ties with US face tough tests

THE SECOND Donald Trump administration will likely mark a decisive turn for most countries. There are peculiar strands that distinguish India from others in how New Delhi’s relationship with the US has changed. Existing frameworks may be proving insufficient, indeed redundant in some cases, to guardrail the direction and objectives of the relationship.

Beyond the upheavals over tariff, immigration and the import of Russian oil, the past few weeks alone have witnessed several instances that will be consequential for the bilateral relationship. India has become a target of a new line of tariff of 12.5 per cent which the US Trade Representative has proposed. This acts as a pressure tool amid ongoing trade negotiations.

The US government has also issued an export-control directive to suspend all access to Fable 5 and Mythos 5 by any foreign national, whether inside or outside America. The decision is likely to impact India perhaps more than any other nation, given one of the strongest tech-dependent diasporas and the growing tech-interdependence between the two nations.

But what has drastically added to the strain has been the death of three Indian seafarers in a US strike on a commercial oil tanker. India summoned the US Charge-d’Affaires to launch a protest but the incident itself is likely to ring much louder than just a political démarche. The US has framed its action as enforcement of a naval blockade against Iran. On strict legality, a blockade is a recognised method of warfare under customary international law, including the law of naval warfare. However, the attack has raised questions over trust and strategic coordination that the various frameworks between the two nations promise.

In most cases, the crew, flag and other information of transiting ships is publicly available. It is hard to believe that the US would not have an internal assessment of the presence of another strategic partner’s nationals in large numbers on board ships that it was going to attack. Could India have been intimidated timely — a natural expectation under existing strategic frameworks — if the US Navy and the CENTCOM indeed felt that lack of action would have violated the blockade? For sure, a lawful blockade which requires interception, visit, search, and capture or seizure, would have provided the US Navy with ample time to avert a direct strike. Then, there is the question of proportionality in the decision of disable-by-destruction when civilian seafarers are on-board. India also qualifies as a neutral state in this conflict whose ships and crew retain certain protections under maritime laws.

The Trump administration’s actions, tethered to Washington’s interests, may be undermining the promise of strategic frameworks. For India, internally, it raises political questions for justifying its strategic partnership with the US and could roil sentiments. Externally, the Trump administration seems to be doing nothing right to an already strained bilateral relationship. If Marco Rubio’s visit to Delhi last month was an exercise in papering over differences, the killing of three Indians could very well wipe the gains.

The writer is visiting fellow, ORF America, and deputy director, Strategic Studies Programme, ORF

40 YEARS AGO

June 15, 1986



39 Tamil militants killed

THIRTY-NINE Tamil militants and one government official were killed in the past 24 hours in a series of incidents in Sri Lanka’s strife-torn northern peninsula, military sources said. Military sources claimed that 26 of the 39 guerrillas were killed when a military helicopter strafed three vehicles near Mannar. While informed sources claimed that some of the victims were civilians caught in crossfire, military sources maintained that they were all “terrorists” and that they fired at helicopters on reconnaissance flights.

Launch of clean Ganga mission

THE AMBITIOUS Rs 293 crore action plan to

and the Punjab and Haryana governments are keen that the deadline for the transfer of territories is adhered to. Punjab’s Finance Minister Balwant Singh explained to opposition leaders that it would not be possible for them to give 70,000 acres to Haryana, as the areas suggested have a large Punjabi-speaking population, and it would be against the spirit of the Punjab accord.

UNSC warning to South Africa

CALLING FOR “immediate lifting” of the emergency in South Africa, the United Nations’ Security Council has warned the regime against trying to intimidate anti-apartheid demonstrators on Monday, the 10th anniversary of the Soweto massacre.

Innovation is strategic necessity. Country must incubate technologies world uses



N CHANDRASEKARAN

THE VEDICHymn “*Aanobhadra krtavo yantu vishwatah*” (Let noble thoughts come to us from all directions) has guided India’s civilisational openness to knowledge. Today, it finds urgent expression in innovation.

Technology has become the currency of national sovereignty. A nation’s freedom in trade, security and diplomacy is increasingly determined by its position in critical technology value chains. For India, innovation is a strategic necessity, a bridge between aspiration and execution. It must expand access for citizens, raise competitiveness for enterprises, reduce strategic vulnerability for the nation, and create capabilities the world cannot easily replace. It is central to Viksit Bharat.

One of the most significant shifts of the last decade has been Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s sustained emphasis on making innovation a national mission. Initiatives such as Startup India, IndiaAI Mission, ANRF, iDEX, BIRAC, IN-SPACe, Semicon India, Atal Tinkering Labs and the RDI Fund have built an institutional architecture for innovation, signalling that frontier technology is central to national development. Our higher education institutions, such as the IITs and IISc, supported by the Ministry of Education, are ready playgrounds for deep-tech talent and function as powerful incubators.

India’s first innovation decade built the runway. It widened participation through startups, incubators, digital public infrastructure, research missions, student hackathons and new capital pathways. The next decade must build mastery. We are innovation-dense; we must now become innovation-deep. Progress must be measured by capabilities mastered, critical dependencies reduced, global value chains entered with strength, and lives improved at scale.

India has demonstrated exceptional strength in applying and adapting technol-

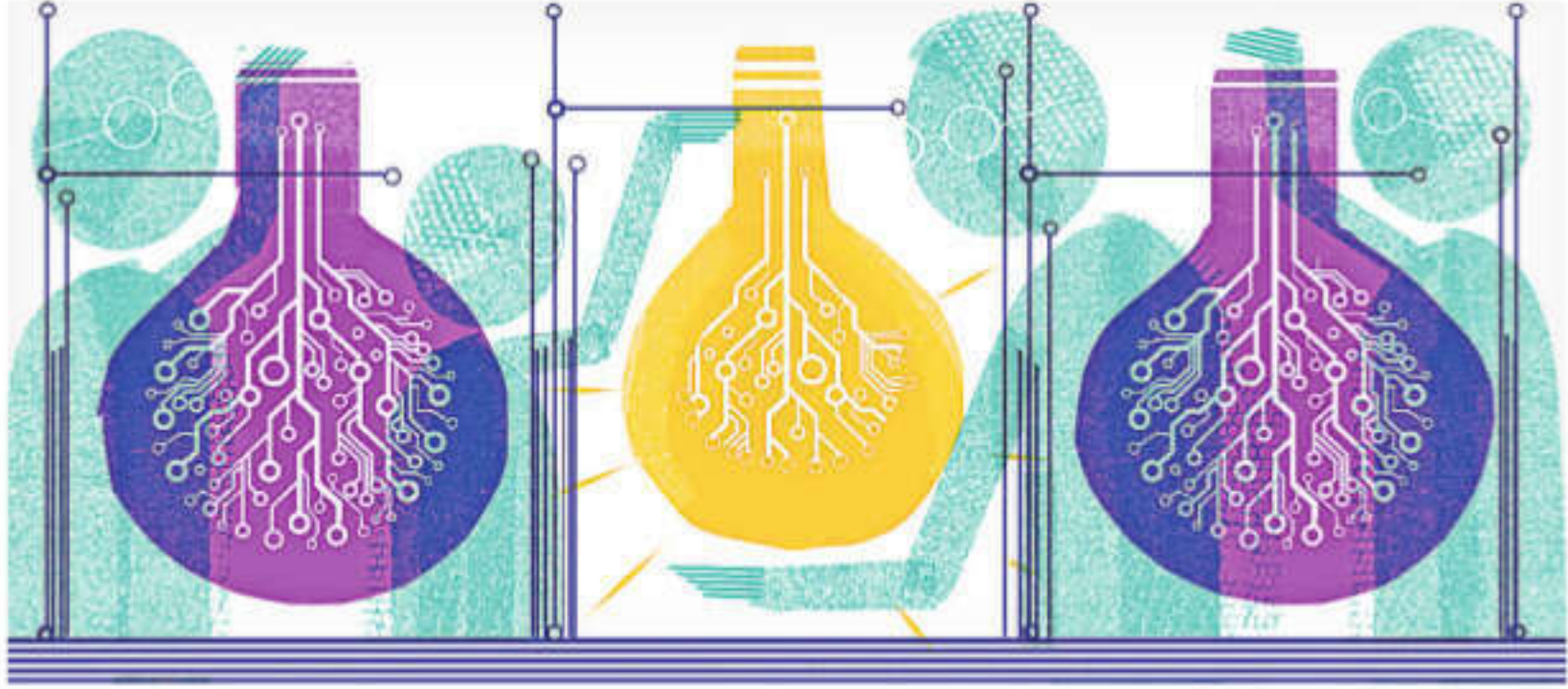


ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

ogy. The next frontier is origination: Owning critical IP, controlling supply-chain choke-points, building component depth, setting standards, and creating platforms that others build upon. India’s industrial R&D intensity is low by international standards. We must move from using the world’s technology well to building technologies the world uses. In every priority sector, we should ask: Do we own the science, the design, the data, the IP, the manufacturing process, the standards and the customer access?

For India’s next phase of innovation, the relationship between policy and market forces must be sequenced and calibrated to sector maturity. In nascent frontier sectors, policy must create anchor demand and absorb certain developmental risks. iDEX proved this: Structured procurement catalysed a defence innovation ecosystem that would not otherwise have existed. As sectors mature, industry must lead, while policy fills the gaps markets leave through long-horizon research, common standards and shared infrastructure that no single player can fund.

As India focuses on technology innovation for strategic sovereignty, we need to keep in mind that it does not mean technological autarky. Given India’s starting point, its national interests are best served through deep partnerships with like-minded nations offering complementary strengths. These are not concessions of ambition. They are a design principle for reaching the frontier faster,

We must also confront technology’s double edge. AI can compress decades of progress in diagnostics and governance. Deployed without careful design, it can also disrupt work, amplify bias and deepen inequality

squarely in India’s enlightened self-interest. Strategic sovereignty means collaborating from confidence, not dependence. The India-France Year of Innovation is a template: Build mastery openly, selectively, based on mutual strength.

India’s large enterprises have a significant role to play in driving innovation beyond being first customers of the startup ecosystem. It is much more comprehensive: Investing in R&D, co-innovating with startups, integrating startups and MSMEs structurally into supply chains, making strategic investments in startups, and deploying engineering rigour, quality systems and global market access in service of the broader ecosystem.

At Tata Group, as we deepen our footprint in semiconductors, artificial intelligence, defence, clean energy and digital infrastructure, we are making the startup and MSME ecosystem integral to our growth. In every complex domain, the unit of innovation is not a product; it is an ecosystem. A semiconductor strategy needs design, materials, packaging and customers moving in concert. An electric vehicle needs a battery, charging network, software and financing to move together. Large companies that build with this understanding pull an entire ecosystem forward.

India cannot build mastery everywhere. The discipline is this: Apply rigorous criteria. What are the core socio-economic problems that need to be addressed — access to quality healthcare and educa-

tion, sustainability, energy and food security? Which domains have irreducible domestic demand, providing a captive proving ground? Where do India’s talent and cost structure create advantages that others cannot replicate? Where does import dependence create genuine strategic exposure, becoming a lever an adversary could use in a crisis? Where is a technology young enough for near-parity competition? India’s goal: To identify the domains where the world cannot easily operate without us. For this, we need to concentrate innovation energy.

We must also confront technology’s double edge. AI can compress decades of progress in diagnostics and governance. However, deployed without careful design, it can also disrupt work, amplify bias and deepen inequality. India’s model must be net positive by design, augmenting capability, creating new jobs, and ensuring that the transition does not burden the weakest sections. The transition must be planned and managed with empathy through structured reskilling and redeployment, while ensuring that India does not lag in competitiveness.

Bharat Innovates 2026, organised by the Ministry of Education in France, is a declaration that India’s most ambitious innovators are ready for the world’s most demanding stage. More importantly, it is a collaboration bridge connecting Indian startups and research institutions with global investors, corporates, universities, research institutions and markets. Its promise is not only that the world will see what India is building, but that global partners will ask: What can we build with India?

To young innovators, researchers and entrepreneurs, the conditions have never been better. India is the world’s most concentrated laboratory for consequential innovation, where the hardest problems of human development and technological self-reliance must be solved together at a billion-person scale. The innovator who solves for India’s problems solves for much of the world. That is not a burden. It is the most powerful innovation brief on earth.

India’s innovation story will be written by a generation that chose mastery over mere participation, depth over dispersion, and purpose over convenience. That generation is ready. The moment is now.

The writer is chairman, Tata Sons

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Safety non-negotiable

ACCORDING TO Washington, vessels suspected of facilitating Iranian oil exports are warned, intercepted, and, if they fail to comply, disabled through precision strikes intended to minimise casualties. Yet the deaths aboard the *Settebello* expose the limits of that argument. Precision is not the same as safety (‘As Modi, Trump head to G7, face off over death of sailors,’ *IE*, June 14). Their deaths signal that the world’s sea lanes are being transformed into battle spaces where civilian crews are expected to absorb the risks of strategic rivalry.

S Paul, Nadia

Beyond punishment

THE EPISODE raises a larger question about how far personal opinions, once aired publicly, should affect one’s professional standing. (‘MBBS student sent on forced leave,’ *IE*, June 14) While medical students are rightly held to high standards of sensitivity, the punishment must be proportionate and rehabilitative rather than purely punitive. Institutions would do well to introduce structured sessions on social media conduct and professional ethics early in the course, so that young students learn these boundaries before, not after, such incidents.

A Myilsami, Coimbatore

Lessons not learnt

THE FIRST anniversary of the Air India flight AI 171 tragedy is a somber reminder of institutional opacity (‘One year after AI 171 crash, questions persist,’ *IE*, June 13). The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau’s failure to stick to the 12-month timeline for its final report undermines public trust. When structural delays compromise accountability, and serious safety anomalies are left unanswered, administrative silence ceases to be perfunctory. It becomes an active public-safety hazard.

Krishan Kumar Chugh, New Delhi



BIJAYALAXMI NANDA, NUPUR RAY AND SHAMBHAVI MANI

THREE HUNDRED million enumerators will knock on doors all over the country for the first time in 16 years to conduct the world’s largest head count. The sheer amount of change that the Census will document is going to be phenomenal, particularly for socio-economic and demographic indicators. While we wait for this, let’s examine the trends that have already been captured by other surveys.

India’s maternal mortality ratio (MMR) stood at 93 as per SRS 2021, a decline of 86 per cent compared to the global reduction of 48 per cent over the past 33 years (PIB, May 10, 2025). It has further come down to 88 (Special Bulletin on MMR in India 2021-23, RGI). Various policy interventions have been credited for this achievement. However, while states like Gujarat, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu have already met the UN-SDG MMR target of less than 70 per 1,00,000 live births, others like Madhya Pradesh, Assam, and Uttar Pradesh are still struggling. Census 2027, cross-referenced with health system data, will enable district-level maternal mortality mapping. This will allow policies to be targeted more precisely.

The demographic transition process reveals that socio-economic development positively impacts mortality, and the statistics for infant and child mortality rate

It is the first time in independent India that caste-based data will be collected. It is expected to be a detailed catalogue of declared castes, cross-referenced with socio-economic indicators

After 16 years, Census could tell several new stories

also confirm it — it declined from 39 in 2014 to 27 in 2021. The neonatal mortality rate has declined from 26 in 2014 to 19 in 2021. The under-five mortality rate has declined from 45 in 2014 to 31 in 2021. This highlights improvements in health infrastructure and policy interventions. Although the Census 2027 is likely to confirm continued improvements in aggregate, it is the state-by-state and district-level pictures which will matter.

The 2011 Census recorded child sex ratio: 919 females per 1,000 live births, a decline from 927. This was attributed to intense son preference and misuse of NRTs (New Reproductive Technologies). To curb this, the state had a dual response of the PC-PNDT Act on the supply side, and conditional cash transfer schemes incentivising the birth and survival of girl children on the demand side.

The NFHS 5 data shows a glimmer of hope where the sex ratio at birth for children born in the preceding five years was 929 females per 1,000 males, and the sex ratio of the population was estimated at 1020. Interventions like Beti Bachao Beti Padhao showed measurable improvements in some areas. However, the Census 2027 will provide an authoritative picture.

India has witnessed concerted efforts in achieving higher enrolments at all levels of education. With policies such as Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan and Beti Bachao Beti Pad-

hao, there has been emphasis on girls’ education. Yet, Census 2027 is expected to reveal an adult literacy gap, since as per available data, 14.4 per cent overall literacy gap between men and women persists, concentrated in rural pockets. Another issue will be digital literacy. The gender digital divide is emerging as the next frontier of inequality.

Although female labour force participation has seen major improvements, the gender gap remains. Although the Census will not replace the PLFS as the primary source of labour force data, it will provide an updated population denominator with its questions on occupation, offering a comprehensive picture of India’s labour market.

It is the first time in independent India that caste-based data will be collected. It is expected to be a detailed catalogue of declared castes, cross-referenced with socio-economic indicators. This will allow for a much more nuanced picture of where disadvantages are concentrated, enabling targeted policies and reservation frameworks. The Census will indicate the transformative progress in human development indices. For policymakers, researchers, and citizens, it is a mirror that India has been waiting for.

Nanda is professor of Political Science and principal of Miranda House, University of Delhi. Ray and Mani teach political science at Kamala Nehru College and Vivekananda College, University of Delhi, respectively

In Bharathiraja’s cinema, the landscape was the story



ARI GAUTIER

M Y ATTHAI was less than thrilled after watching *16 Vayathinile*. The film brought back memories of her hometown, Murungapakkam, six km south of Puducherry. She had come to the cinema for glamour and adventure, not to be returned to the red earth and palm trees she had spent years forgetting.

I didn’t know what I was thirsty for until it arrived with Bharathiraja. Understanding what Bharathiraja did for Tamil cinema is to understand what the Impressionists did for painting. Before Claude Monet, Camille Pissarro, and Pierre-Auguste Renoir brought their easels outside, European painting was a studio affair: Controlled light, controlled compositions, subjects deemed worthy by the Academy. The Impressionists shattered that. They painted haystacks, train stations, women hanging laundry, driven by an obsessive need to capture fleeting natural light, insisting that the world outside the studio was not inferior but inexhaustible.

Bharathiraja did the same thing structurally. Tamil cinema in the 1970s had its own Academy: The Kodambakkam studios, the star system, the grammar of mythologicals and social dramas. He took his camera outside, into the fields of the Kongu and Madurai belts, under the white Tamil Nadu sun with its long shadows. He cast untrained faces and let the landscape speak for itself. A farmer’s daughter at the well, a young man’s longing in a village square — as dramatic and beautiful, he insisted, as any mythological tale.

And like the Impressionists, he was met with scepticism from those who should have known better. Atthai, who had grown up in a village and paid good money to escape it for three hours, was not prepared to see her native red earth elevated to art. It took time. It always does.

This new way of seeing had a name: PS Nivas. Trained at the Institute of Film Technology in Chennai, Nivas brought a visual vocabulary shaped by the shadow-conscious Malayalam black-and-white tradition. Nivas used backlighting to let figures emerge from light rather than be lit from the front — understanding, as

Monet understood, that a slight softness, an unexpected shadow, a face caught between two expressions were not imperfections. They were the film itself.

From 1890 to 1891, Monet submitted himself to gentle madness: Painting the same haystack again and again, at dawn, at noon, under snow, under the copper light of autumn. It was not the hay that held him. It was what light did to it — how it consumed it, lifted it, rendered it almost im-

material at certain hours. The haystack was the place where light came to confess.

Bharathiraja understood the same thing, with the red soil of Tamil Nadu beneath his feet. His sugarcane fields are not backdrops. His whitewashed walls, crossed by that thick afternoon light that only the South knows, are not props. They are the story. He returned to them film after film, season after season, with the patience of someone who knows that the world, looked at with enough care and love, never runs dry.

Jean-Francois Millet knew something the French Academy refused to admit: That three women bent over a harvested field (*The Gleaners*, 1857) contained as much grandeur as any mythological subject. Bharathiraja worked from the same conviction. His women were never ornamental. In *Muthal Mariyathai*, the desire between an ageing landlord and a young married woman is neither condemned nor softened — it exists, whole and present, the way Millet’s gleaners exist. In *Alaigal Oivathillai*, he follows his characters through labour, festival, desire, loss, and refuses to force an arc onto material that already has its own breath. Like Pissarro returning season after season to the fields of Pontoise, he believed that if you looked honestly enough, something true would rise to the surface on its own, the way salt rises through the earth after rain.

He was right. I am not sure my *atthai* ever fully reconciled with Bharathiraja. For her, cinema was always a way of forgetting — the red soil, the toil, the constrained life she had worked so hard to leave behind. Bharathiraja insisted on remembering. He held that what she had left behind deserved to be looked at until it became luminous.

In that insistence lay both his genius and his provocation. The villages he filmed, the faces he restored to dignity, the untidy stories he chose to tell — they will endure. So, too, will Murungapakkam, six km south of Puducherry. Bharathiraja would have known exactly how to film it.

Gautier is a writer and poet brought up in Puducherry

‘Good’ women can be messy as well

prefer Nirma to “wash your clothes”.

Suresh Triveni’s *Maa Behen*, now streaming on Netflix, borrows those four names — Rekha, Jaya, Sushma (Hema takes her own sweet time to appear) — and asks a gleefully subversive question: What if these women were messy, selfish, sharp-tongued, and absolutely done with being good?

Let’s start with the title itself. *Maa Behen*. In large parts of the Subcontinent, these two words are rarely said together as a compliment. As a phrase, it has long existed in the shadows of abuse and moral policing. Women are granted respect only when they fit into a sanctified role. Triveni takes these words that have long been used to threaten or insult men and to remind women of their purpose and turns them on their head. The women here are selfish, reckless, frustrated, and contrarian. They are human.

Pay attention to where the film is set: Adarsh Colony. Adarsh means ideal, model, exemplary — the kind of name Indian housing societies love. It carries a promise of respectability, of people living correctly. And who is the family’s most vocal critic in this model colony? A man named Charitra Singh. Charitra means character, specifically moral character. In India, when someone says a woman’s *charitra* is bad, it is never neutral.

Self-appointed moral guardians are often fascinated by the very women they condemn. The supposedly wayward woman becomes essential to the performance of virtue

It is a verdict. Their home itself is named Kripa Bhavan — *kripa* meaning grace, something the colony has never once shown these women. The idea of “good” and “bad” women has always been policed by people like Charitra Singh, who appoints himself as a moral guardian of women who never asked for their opinion. These self-appointed men are often fascinated by the very women they condemn. The supposedly wayward woman becomes essential to the performance of virtue. Outrage is also curiosity, obsession, and voyeurism disguised as concern.

This is why the casting works so well. As one of Hindi cinema’s most beloved stars, when Madhuri Dixit plays a character who is free-spirited, it is almost liberating. Jaya, on the other hand, shows us the cost of “goodness” that women have to pay. Despite having lived her life abiding by the laws of so-

ciety, she ends up failing to be “the perfect daughter-in-law and wife” in a marriage she never wanted. The TV anchor from the crime show *Khalbali* narrates Rekha’s imagined life with breathless scandal. We recognise his voice immediately. We have heard it on news channels, in WhatsApp groups, at family dinners, on evening walks in the colony park. The voice that holds women against an impossible standard and then enjoys telling them they have failed.

Maa Behen is not a perfect film. But its essential argument is airtight. Triveni borrows names from the Nirma jingle and asks us, very politely, to let go. Hema, Rekha, Jaya, Sushma are back. But now, instead of washing things clean, they embrace the mess.

The writer is correspondent, The Indian Express. anusree.kc@expressindia.com

IRAN-U.S. 'DRAFT MoU'

A senior Iranian official told Reuters a final draft of the MoU with the US covered a range of issues, from Tehran's nuclear work to reopening the Strait & US waivers on oil sanctions. The official claimed the draft memorandum included the following:

STRAIT OF HORMUZ

- Iran immediately reopens the Strait of Hormuz to all commercial vessels, while the US lifts its naval blockade on Iranian ports.
- The lifting of the US blockade would begin immediately after the memorandum is signed and be completed within 30 days.



FINANCIAL

- The US agrees not to impose any new sanctions on Iran until a final deal is reached.
- Following a final agreement, all US and UN sanctions on Iran would be lifted according to an agreed timetable.
- Washington, in coordination with its regional allies, would prepare a reconstruction and development plan for Iran, to be negotiated and agreed with Tehran within 60 days.

- The US will waive oil sanctions on Iran for a specified period, allowing Tehran to sell oil and receive revenue.
- The US agrees to release \$25 billion of Iran's frozen assets, including via direct cash transfers.



NUCLEAR

- Tehran agrees that it will neither produce nor acquire nuclear weapons.
- Pending a final agreement, Iran would maintain the current status of its nuclear programme, refraining from further uranium enrichment.
- The US agrees to allow Iran to dilute its stockpile of highly enriched uranium on Iranian soil under a future comprehensive agreement.

- Iran's nuclear programme, uranium enrichment activities and mechanisms for handling its stockpile of highly enriched uranium would be negotiated within 60 days of the memorandum and addressed in a final agreement.

REUTERS



BRIEFLY

HUNGARY

Orban re-elected as Fidesz party leader despite election loss



Leader of Hungary's opposition Fidesz party, Viktor Orban. FILE

HUNGARY'S MAIN opposition Fidesz party re-elected former Prime Minister Viktor Orban as its leader on Saturday for another year despite the party's loss of power in an April 12 election to the centre-right Tisza party. Nationalist Orban 62, provided inspiration for right-wing conservatives across Europe and the US as the mastermind of what he called an "illiberal" model of democracy. Some 729 delegates out of 737 voted to re-elect Orban at Fidesz's party congress, state news agency MTI reported. REUTERS

UNITED STATES

12 people killed in Missouri plane crash

TWELVE PEOPLE died in a plane crash on Sunday in Butler, Missouri, the state highway patrol posted on social media. The Missouri State Highway Patrol said the crash occurred near the Butler Memorial Airport. "Reports indicate all occupants have perished," the agency posted on X. Butler is about 60 miles off Kansas City, Missouri. REUTERS

HAITI

Top defence official abducted in Port-au-Prince

ARMED MEN in Haiti have kidnapped a senior government and police official in Port-au-Prince, the highest-ranking abduction in recent years in a country gripped by gang violence, according to media reports on Saturday. James Boyard, cabinet director at the Defence Ministry and inspector general of Haiti's national police, was seized on Thursday. REUTERS

NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

NEPAL

2 Indians held for suspected drug trafficking

TWO INDIAN nationals were among three people arrested in Nepal for allegedly possessing a huge quantity of narcotic drugs, police said. The Nepal police arrested the Indian nationals identified as Ahmad Ladn, 32, and Mo-hamad Saddam, 33, hailing from Bihar, on Saturday. PTI

PAKISTAN

Australian girl, 9, shot dead in police mix-up

A NINE-year-old Australian girl of Pakistan origin was killed and her father and brother were critically injured when police personnel opened indiscriminate fire on their car suspecting them to be robbers in Punjab province of Pakistan, police said on Sunday. PTI

Trump hosts White House cage fight amid war, political scrutiny

Reuters

Washington, June 14

DONALD TRUMP hosts a card of seven mixed martial arts fights to be held on Sunday inside a specially built arena on the White House's South Lawn on his 80th birthday, a spectacle spotlighting his norm-defying style at a tense moment in his presidency. Seventeen months into his second term in office, Trump has repeatedly pushed the boundaries of the US presidency to command attention and project strength.

His latest stage is the Ultimate Fighting Championship's Octagon, the eight-sided cage erected within eyesight of his White House bedroom for the event titled "UFC Freedom 250." That is a reference to the 250th anniversary of the nation's founding next month.

The event comes as Trump grapples with the four-month-old Iran war that has pushed consumer prices to a three-year high and, as shown in public opinion polls, unnerved many voters. Trump is set to watch 14 mixed martial arts fighters from five countries try to kick, punch and grapple their way to a vic-



Diego Lopes during the ceremonial UFC Freedom 250 weigh-ins on the Ellipse, ahead of Sunday's fights at the White House. AP

tory before an expected audience of 4,000 people inside a 92-foot-tall (28 meters) makeshift venue, nicknamed "The Claw." The main event, scheduled for up to five rounds, features UFC lightweight champion Ilia Topuria against former interim titleholder Justin Gaethje. The fights are set to begin at 8 pm (0000 GMT Monday).

Tickets were not sold publicly. UFC offered some to guests paying more than \$1 million, according to a person familiar with the matter. A quarter of the audience will be military service members, Trump administration said.

Kennedy Centre drops Trump name

Washington: The curtain may have come down for President Donald Trump at the Kennedy Centre but tarp stays up for now. Matt Floca, executive director and chief operating officer of the performing arts venue, told a federal court Saturday that the institution had complied with an order to remove Trump's name from the facade. AP

Swiss reject population cap in referendum, avoiding EU clash

Reuters

Zurich, June 14

SWITZERLAND ON Sunday rejected a proposal to cap its population at 10 million as voters prioritised economic stability and ties with the European Union over worries immigration was stretching public services and pushing up rents.

A preliminary tally of a nationwide referendum showed almost 55% of Swiss voters

came out against the proposal, and 45% in favour. The vote, which was likened to Britain's 2016 Brexit referendum, had put businesses on edge due to concerns it could end the free movement of labour between Switzerland and the EU, the country's main trading partner.

Championed by the right-wing Swiss People's Party, the proposal stipulated that the population must not exceed 10 million before 2050, and that if

it did so for two years, Switzerland should end freedom of movement with the EU.

The government had urged voters to reject the cap. Swiss Justice Minister Beat Jans welcomed the result but pledged to analyse what further steps could be taken to satisfy voter concerns about housing and immigration. "With today's decision, the electorate has sent out a signal of stability, openness, and reliability," Jans told a

Taiwan spy agency opens online 'tip' portal for Chinese nationals

Associated Press

Taipei, June 14

TAIWAN'S INTELLIGENCE agency said on Sunday it is establishing an information-reporting channel for Chinese nationals to offer tips securely, at a time when tensions between Beijing and the self-ruled island remain elevated.

In a statement, Taiwan's National Security Bureau said they are launching a webpage that will act as a secure channel for Chinese nationals to provide intelligence-related information, saying that an increasing

number of people have recently approached relevant agencies in Taiwan wishing to "provide various types of information."

"In recent years, China's economy has faced mounting difficulties, while political control has remained tight," the statement said. "Coupled with a growing range of social and livelihood-related problems, these conditions have fueled public discontent."

Taiwan officials said the move was made in reference to practices adopted by intelligence agencies in the US, the UK and Israel.

Gaza death toll tops 73,000 as Israel strikes despite ceasefire

Associated Press

Gaza Strip, June 14

THE PALESTINIAN death toll from the Israel-Hamas war has surpassed 73,000, Gaza's Health Ministry said Sunday, as Israeli military operations continued despite a stalled and fragile ceasefire in place since October.

Israel says it is targeting Hamas and other militants who pose a threat, and in response to ceasefire violations, including occasional attacks.

Nearly 1,000 people have

been killed in Gaza since the start of the ceasefire, according to the health ministry.

Five Israeli soldiers have been killed since the truce.

The number of deaths since the beginning of the war is now 73,001, according to the health ministry's tally. Over 173,200 people have been wounded since the start of the war on October 7, 2023, following the Hamas-led attack into Israel.

That attack killed some 1,200 people and took 251 others hostage.

a small country to do this," Bieri said.

The Swiss population already stands at 9.1 million and has grown far more quickly than in the surrounding EU. Foreigners make up nearly 28% of the total, which official projections forecast will reach 10 million by the early 2040s.

Polls had forecast a close outcome. In the end, the 'no' camp's victory was clearer than many analysts had expected.

The health ministry, part of the Hamas-led government, is staffed by medical professionals and maintains detailed records viewed as generally reliable by United Nations agencies and independent experts. It does not distinguish between civilians and militants but says women and children make up around half of all fatalities.

Israel says it tries to avoid harming civilians and blames their deaths on Hamas because the militants operate in densely populated areas.

THE ROYAL FAMILY IS NOW MADE UP OF ONLY 16 PEOPLE, 5 MEN AND 11 WOMEN, DOWN ABOUT A QUARTER SINCE 1990; LEGISLATURE IS DRAFTING A PLAN TO ALLOW THE IMPERIAL FAMILY TO ADOPT DISTANT MALE RELATIVES

As male heirs dwindle, a princess waits & Japan debates future of the throne

Javier C Hernández & Hisako Ueno

Tokyo, June 14

JAPAN'S IMPERIAL family, which has long maintained a male-only lineage for emperors, is running out of royals. Now the country has a plan to help revitalize its dwindling ranks: recruit more men.

Japan's legislature, hoping to avoid a succession crisis, moved forward with a proposal this past week to allow the imperial family to adopt scores of distant male relatives. That could give Japan more choices for future emperors — only men are allowed to ascend the Chrysanthemum Throne —

and help ensure the survival of the world's oldest monarchy.

The plan has angered some Japanese officials, commentators and activists, who say there is an easier solution: allowing women to reign as emperor, an idea embraced by a broad swath of the public, according to polls.

"Many citizens want a female emperor now," said Kiyomi Tsujimoto, a female lawmaker with the Constitutional Democratic Party who opposes the plan. "I have people running up to me every day."

But in Japan's patriarchal system, that idea is considered a nonstarter. Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi, a conservative lawmaker, shattered the political

glass ceiling last year when she became the first woman to lead Japan's government. But she and her allies have been among most vocal proponents of preserving the male-only lineage.

She has said that "it is considered appropriate to limit eligibility to male descendants of the imperial lineage."

Japan's demographic decline has touched nearly every aspect of its society, including the monarchy.

The royal family is now made up of only 16 people — five men and 11 women — down about a quarter since 1990. This makes it difficult for the family to carry out its public duties, like overseas visits and



Princess Aiko on a trip to Laos last year. AP

court ceremonies. There are simply not enough royals to take part. Today, there are only three heirs to the throne, com-

pared with six a generation ago.

The reigning emperor, Naruhito, 66, is the 126th in a line that extends back to the

country's founding in 660 B.C. by Emperor Jimmu, who, according to legend, descended from a sun goddess.

In the early 2000s, the pressure to bear a son drove Naruhito's wife, Empress Masako, a Harvard-educated former diplomat, into a deep depression. The couple has a daughter, Princess Aiko, 24, who has taken on a more visible role recently, like leading a visit to Laos, and has been championed by some as a future emperor.

But under the current rules, only Prince Hitachi, Naruhito's 90-year-old uncle; Crown Prince Akishino, the emperor's 60-year-old brother; and Prince Hisahito, the monarch's 19-

year-old nephew, are recognized as heirs to the throne.

In the aftermath of World War II, the United States sought to weaken the power of the Japanese imperial family members, who were regarded by the public as demigods.

Under the nation's 1947 constitution imposed under Gen. Douglas MacArthur, the emperor became "the symbol of the state and of the unity of the people," a figurehead with no political authority.

Under the plan to be advanced in parliament, men from these former royal branches would be brought back into the monarchy. While it is unclear how the men would

be selected or how many would be eligible, they would most likely come from the Kuni, Higashikuni, Kaya and Takeda families. Experts said their offspring might one day be eligible to inherit the throne.

Naruhito said this past week that he hoped the plan would be "understood by the people."

Japan has had female emperors with varying degrees of power, including Go-Sakuramachi, who reigned in the late 1700s. But men have dominated the ranks since then, and Takaichi's Liberal Democratic Party, which has led Japan for much of the past seven decades, has long held that the male line of succession is sacrosanct. NYT

DOMESTIC OPS AT NOIDA AIRPORT START TODAY, INTERNATIONAL FLIGHTS LIKELY BY YEAR-END

‘Confident of India’s long-term aviation growth despite shocks’

THE NOIDA International Airport (NIA) in Uttar Pradesh’s Jewar starts commercial operations today, becoming the National Capital Region’s second major airport. NIA, which is a Greenfield airport designed and built by an arm of Zurich Airport International AG, opens at a time when the aviation sector is grappling with headwinds amid the West Asia crisis. While the NIA management accepts that the crisis is a challenge in the short-term, it is confident of the long-term growth potential in India’s aviation market. The NIA is projected to have 5 million passengers within 10-12 months, with overseas flight operations expected to start by the end of 2026. NIA Vice Chairman **Christoph Schnellmann** and CEO **Nitu Samra** share their views with **Sukalp Sharma** on various facets of the new airport, its positioning vis-à-vis the Delhi airport, and their vision for the road ahead. Edited excerpts:

As the NIA is set to start operations, what are the traffic projections for the coming year?

Samra: We start on June 15 with IndiGo, and Akasa Air starts on the 16th, and we will ramp up over the weeks and months to come. We’re starting with 12 flights a day in June. In July, adding more destinations, we will ramp up to 40-42 daily flights. Then gradually further ramp-up will happen. In terms of projections, it is difficult for me to comment on a longer horizon at this stage. But I think in terms of first 10-12 months, we expect approximately 5 million passengers.

When do you expect the second phase of NIA’s development to be triggered? Any timeline based on your internal projections?

Samra: As per our concession agreement, we would officially kick off the (second) phase

when we reach about 10 million passengers (per year). But in terms of how the infrastructure needs evolve, just to give you an example, we have already started the work on additional parking stands, so there are some things that we could add earlier than the rest of the infrastructure depending on the requirement... The airport (in phase one) is built for 12 million passengers (a year).

Schnellmann: The recent events in West Asia have made sort of intermediate predictions just a little bit more challenging. But as I’ve always said, I’m convinced that by the end of this decade, construction activities for the next phase will be in full swing. We’ll revisit in a couple of years to see how accurate that was.

The airport is starting operations at a difficult time for the aviation sector. Indian carriers have reduced flights due to the West Asia crisis-related headwinds. How big a concern is it for you? What impact do you expect in the short-term?

Schnellmann: We won the bid to design and build this airport at the end of 2019. Three months later, the bottom dropped out of the aviation market across the world. No one was flying anymore (due to the Covid pandemic). I think to our credit, the shareholders and the lenders, everyone stood by and remained committed to this project.

The years since have proven them and us right. We saw traffic in India rebound very quickly, faster than in many parts of the world. That’s the approach we take to the current crisis as well. It’s a challenging time for aviation but if we zoom out and look at where the industry has come from in the past 15-20 years, and what the outlook is, we remain incredibly confident.



CHRISTOPH SCHNELLMANN
VC, NOIDA INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT

NITU SAMRA
CEO, NOIDA INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT

In your talks with airlines on their network development out of NIA, has there been any major rethink that you’ve seen due to the current challenges?

Schnellmann: I think they’re looking at it exactly the same way (as us). Aviation in India remains an absolute growth market, and they’ve committed hundreds of aircrafts each to this market and remain confident in this outlook. One thing we’ve learned, and not just in the past five years, about this industry is that there’s always some surprise, disruption, or crisis. But even through those turbulences, we do see the growth trajectory.

When can we expect the first international flight to take off from NIA? And have the West Asia crisis and closure of Pakistani airspace been speed bumps on that front?

Samra: We expect to start with international operations towards the end of the year. From an international perspective, that (West Asia crisis and Pakistani airspace closure) is not a question right now. But times are uncertain, so it’s difficult to say what will be the situation by the end of the year.

Is it just the India-based international carriers or

overseas carriers also that may start operations as per the timeline that you just gave? Which overseas geographies could see flights from and to the NIA initially?

Schnellmann: We have very specific interest from foreign carriers also. We do see international traffic developing initially in West Asia and Southeast Asia, these are regions for which we are seeing a lot of interest... but ultimately it’s up to the airlines.

The West Asia crisis has made some of it a little bit less predictable, but the interest is there from Indian as well as international airlines. I’m confident that the people in our catchment want direct flights to international destinations.

The issue of high airport tariffs at NIA has been flagged by a few airlines as well as others, who say that the cost benefit to airlines and passengers that the new airport could offer vis-à-vis Delhi airport has been negated.

Samra: We had asked for slightly higher tariffs than what AERA (Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India) has given. Even what we had sought was broadly in line with the other greenfield airports and even a few brownfield airports in India. Considering the whole infrastructure is new, significant capex has been in-

vested. From an airline’s perspective, we know that cost is a consideration. We think we would certainly be operationally cost competitive for an airline. Cost is a mix of various elements like the airport charges, fuel cost, and the operational efficiencies that airport offers, among others. High operational efficiency, like shorter turnarounds between flights, saves costs for airlines, and we think we will be very cost competitive for carriers.

Although it has expressway connectivity, NIA currently lacks multi-modal connectivity, unlike the Delhi airport. How big a concern is it presently, and what does the future look like?

Schnellmann: I’m convinced that the airport is very well connected to its catchment through the Yamuna Expressway. We’ve been working very deliberately to ensure there’s a quick and easy way to reach the airport for every price point, be it buses or coaches, taxis, and even something more luxurious, all that will be available. That really will be the primary access to the airport for a number of years, which is on par with with many other airports. By and large, the vast majority of travellers reach airports by road.

Having said that, I’m excited by the plans that the state government is working on with the central government to develop rail connectivity — RRTS connectivity is planned and high-speed rail connectivity has been mooted along the planned Delhi-Varanasi line. We’re working on plans for both of these railways to have stops directly in front of the terminal. We expect this multimodal connectivity will become increasingly important in the long-term.

FULL INTERVIEW ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Basmati rice exports slip nearly 25% in March, April amid West Asia tensions

Shipments to China went up by 200% in March, reaching a value of nearly \$1 million

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 14

BASMATI RICE, one of the country’s largest export items to West Asia, is taking a severe hit from the regional crisis. According to the data released by the Commerce and Industry Ministry, its exports have slipped nearly 25% due to a sharp decline in shipments to Gulf countries in the backdrop of the crisis.

Dragged by a decline in exports to countries such as Iraq, Iran, Qatar, and Saudi Arabia, India’s total basmati rice exports slipped 27.4% in March and 20.9% in April. Cumulative exports in March and April slipped by 24% to \$838.34 million this year compared to \$1105.36 million last year, official data showed.

Industry executives said India exports nearly 60 lakh tonnes of basmati, out of which nearly 40 lakh tonnes go to the Gulf region.

The five leading basmati import destinations are in West Asia — Saudi Arabia, Iran, Iraq, UAE, and Yemen — and account for about 50% of the country’s total exports.

Data showed that basmati exports to Iraq, Bahrain, Iran, and Qatar were the most affected during March and April, slipping between 50%-90%.

However, shipments to Saudi Arabia and Israel could be improving as there was a less steep decline in April compared to March.

Trade data indicated that basmati exporters may be shipping to various countries via Jordan, as shipments jumped several-fold. According to April figures, Jordan has

• Basmati rice export trends in April

Destinations where exports slipped			
COUNTRY	2025 (\$ MN)	2026 (\$ MN)	EXPORT DECLINE (%)
Iran	98.40	29.60	69.92
Iraq	70.10	6.28	91.00
Saudi Arabia	106.10	79.10	25.47
UAE	45.10	30.60	32.00
Destinations where exports jumped			
COUNTRY	2025 (\$ MN)	2026 (\$ MN)	EXPORT JUMP (%)
Jordan	8.78	67.40	667.46
UK	10.60	19.09	80.13
Oman	7.80	12.90	65.40
Italy	5.50	9.17	66.90

SOURCE: COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY MINISTRY

emerged as India’s second-largest export destination. Its share of 15% in basmati exports is only second to Saudi Arabia, which alone imports nearly 18% of the country’s basmati.

Pivot to new markets; China as an alternative

Exporters have also managed to find buyers elsewhere, particularly in the UK, Italy and Netherlands where shipments in April alone went up by 80%, 67% and 18%, respectively.

Exports to Oman also went up by 65% as Omani ports mostly fall outside the Strait of Hormuz. However, exporters are facing regulatory challenges as they scout for new markets in the backdrop of the West Asia crisis.

Amid the ongoing tensions, Indian exporters are also increasingly exploring China as an alternative, as Beijing has begun stepping up imports of food and raw materials from India since the US imposed steep tariffs.

However, China recently rejected several Indian basmati rice shipments after finding genetically modified organism (GMO) material.

According to an Agricultural & Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (APEDA) notification, exporters are now required to test five specific genetic elements and are required to conduct testing at

a specific APEDA-recognised lab, which can be scoped for GMOs.

This comes as basmati exports to China are going up. Export to China jumped 155% to cross \$1 million in April.

Basmati rice shipments to China had also gone up by 200% in March to nearly \$1 million. Meanwhile, exports to Hong Kong also jumped over 150% in April.

Impact on Punjab, Haryana

A sustained disruption in exports to the West Asia region could have a detrimental impact on Punjab and Haryana, which produce nearly 70% of India’s rice, particularly as the availability of fertilisers has already become a challenge for the region.

The *Indian Express* reported that farmers across five states, including Punjab and Haryana, protested on June 8 against what they claimed were inadequate supplies of urea and diammonium phosphate (DAP) fertilisers, as the paddy sowing season begins.

In Punjab alone, demonstrations were held at 74 locations under the banner of the Kisan Mazdoor Morcha (KMM).

Punjab BJP President Sardar Kewal Singh Dhillon also wrote to JP Nadda, Union Minister for Chemicals and Fertilisers, urging the government to ensure uninterrupted and timely supply.

Behind RBI’s return to ‘terrible’ 2013 idea to lift foreign inflows

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, June 14

SOMETIMES, THE worst ideas are the best.

Speaking in August 2016, just before his term as Governor of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) was to end, Raghuram Rajan said there were multiple ideas the authorities were considering to attract foreign money in August-September 2013 amid the taper tantrums caused by the speculation around tightening of monetary policy by the US Federal Reserve. “However, there was one that I found completely idiotic. I thought this was a terrible, terrible thing to do.”

That idea was the swap scheme for banks’ Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits, or FCNR(B) deposits: banks would get a 3.5% subsidy on the foreign funds they raised through these deposits. This allowed banks to offer attractive interest rates to those abroad and the facility ended up being wildly successful, resulting in an inflow of \$26 billion and helping turn around investor confidence in the rupee and India.

But it was not always clear it would do the job. In fact, not only did Rajan think it was “idiotic” and “terrible”, but a clever suggestion from bankers to get the RBI to pay for the exchange rate risk these deposits entailed. Such were his misgivings that he even asked the outgoing Governor, D Subbarao, to announce the swap scheme before his exit on September 4, 2013.

“The morning that I was going to take over, I went to Dr Subbarao and said ‘would you like to announce it?’ He was gracious enough at that point to say ‘no, you go ahead’. And now I get the credit for that idea which actually I neither invented nor actually believed in,” Rajan said in August 2016.

Now, nearly 13 years later, the FCNR(B) swap scheme is

• FCNR(B) SCHEME

● In the 2013 swap scheme for banks’ Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits, or FCNR(B) deposits, banks got a 3.5% subsidy on foreign funds they raised through these deposits

● This allowed banks to offer attractive interest rates to those abroad and the facility resulted in an inflow of \$26 billion, helping turn around investor confidence in the rupee and India

back. And while the removal of the capital gains tax on Foreign Institutional Investors’ (FIIs) investments in government bonds as well the withholding tax has captured much of the imagination, it is this swap scheme that will do much of the heavy lifting when it comes to bringing in foreign inflows.

“... the same scheme mobilised ~\$26 billion of flows in 2013, and that was 1.4% of GDP in that year (FY14). We believe a similar quantum may be raised this time, and that translates to roughly \$50 billion of flows,” ICICI Securities Primary Dealership economists led by A Prasanna said in a note on June 7, adding that they expect

around \$100 billion of inflows over a period of 12-24 months from all the measures that were announced on June 5 by the government and the RBI. The FCNR(B) swap scheme is even more potent this time around. In 2013, the RBI provided a 3.5% subsidy to banks. Now, it will fully bear the exchange rate risk on new 3-5-year deposits mobilised till September 30.

“Current FCNR (B) Rate is ~3.35% (3 years). Presently cost of hedging, forward premium is ~3.5%. Current Card rate for a 3-year deposit is 6.5%. Banks can thus offer attractive FCNR (B) pricing in the range of 5.5% and upwards (US treasury rates at ~4% of equivalent duration). Taking an annual hedging cost



RBI will bear entire exchange rate risk on new 3-5-year deposits till Sept 30. REUTERS

at ~2.5%, the total outgo comes to ~12.5% for a 5-year tenor, implying \$125 million cost embedded per billion (dollars) raised,” Soumya Kanti Ghosh, Group Chief Economic Adviser at SBI, said on June 5.

It is this estimated \$125 million cost (this time around) that changed Rajan and the RBI’s thinking back in 2013. The cost of hedging for the RBI is high only if a lot of money comes in — but if a lot of money does come in, the rupee would appreciate. And a stronger rupee would not only reduce the hedging cost for the RBI but also reduce India’s import bill.

“Think of having a stronger currency relative to an undervalued rate of about Rs 3-4, multiply it by \$400 billion in imports. That would mean Rs 1.6 trillion in savings (per year) if we only stabilise the currency,” Rajan had remarked.

The savings from a stronger rupee would be much greater now considering India’s import bill in 2025-26 was \$775 billion.

The government and the RBI have blown the steps taken in 2013 out of the water and delivered a ‘Balance of Payments (BoP) package’ that has exceeded market expectations; so much so that economists now expect India to have a surplus or near-zero BoP from earlier expectations of a deficit of around \$60 billion and even higher in some cases.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Bank of Baroda targets \$3 billion via FCNR(B) scheme

Christina Titus
Mumbai, June 14

BANK OF Baroda is targeting to raise \$3 billion through Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank), or FCNR(B), deposits after the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) introduced measures to draw foreign currency inflows and support the rupee, a senior official told *FE*.

“Considering the bank’s market share of around 5% and its strong overseas presence across key NRI corridors, the bank is targeting mobilisation of FCNR(B) deposits in the range of \$3 billion during the scheme period,” the official said.

The expected inflows to the banking industry under the FCNR(B) deposit scheme are estimated to be in the range of \$40-

45 billion, the official added.

On June 5, the RBI announced covering full hedging cost for FCNR deposits, along with a slew of other measures to attract foreign inflows and support the rupee. With enabling leverage, banks now expect higher inflows compared to earlier estimations.

The official further said that given the current market environment, including the narrower interest rate differential and availability of alternative investment opportunities, the scheme is expected to generate a leverage effect of approximately 5-7 times.

According to reports, Punjab National Bank is targeting \$2.5-3 billion in FCNR(B) deposits, while Canara Bank expects to mobilise \$105-210 million through the route. *FE*

DRAFT PAPERS LIKELY NEXT WEEK

NSE IPO set to advance; entire listing to be via OFS

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, June 14

THE LONG-AWAITED initial public offering (IPO) of the National Stock Exchange (NSE) is set to move a step closer, with India’s largest stock exchange expected to file its preliminary papers with SEBI next week, people aware of the matter said.

This comes after NSE’s board approved the proposed IPO on February 6, following receipt of SEBI’s no-objection certificate (NOC).

The public issue will be entirely an offer for sale (OFS), with no fresh issue component. According to people familiar with the development, the draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) is likely to be filed on June 15 or June 16.

The exchange has a broad-

based shareholder base comprising domestic financial institutions, insurance companies, foreign investors and individual shareholders.

Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) is the single largest shareholder in NSE, holding a 10.72% stake. State Bank of India (SBI) and its subsidiary, SBI Capital Markets, together own around a 7.5% stake in the exchange.

Among foreign investors with significant holdings are Aranda Investments, a subsidiary of Temasek, and Canada Pension Plan Investment Board (CPPIB).

The filing will mark a major milestone for NSE, whose listing plans had remained on hold for nearly a decade due to regulatory issues, including the co-location controversy.

FM: Rupee-dollar fluctuations driven by global, domestic factors

Bengaluru: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman Sunday said fluctuations in the rupee against the US dollar are driven by multiple global and domestic factors, including geopolitical uncertainties, foreign capital movements and India’s import dependence on crude oil, fertilisers and gold. Addressing reporters at Devanahalli near Bengaluru during a programme marking 12 years of Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led NDA government, she said exchange rates were influenced by a range of external developments and market conditions. PTI

• CORE PROJECTS

● Upcoming projects include world-class undergraduate university, advanced medical centers and funding research in agri & genomics

● This scale of spending, on a year-on-year basis, has enabled the Trust to provide quality, affordable cancer care to citizens of Assam, Maharashtra, Jharkhand, Andhra Pradesh and UP

This scale of spending, on a year-on-year basis, has enabled the Trust to provide quality, yet affordable cancer care to citizens of Assam, Maharashtra, Jharkhand, Andhra Pradesh and UP, he wrote.

Tata Trusts, headed by Noel Tata, hold 66% stake in Tata Sons, the principal shareholder of various Tata group firms.

• BRIEFLY

Amazon to scale up automation at India centres

New Delhi/London: Amazon will continue to expand the use of automation technologies across operations in India and deploy advanced systems for inventory management at its fulfilment centres in the country, a senior company executive said. In an interview, Amazon Robotics Chief Technologist Tye Brady said it already uses several automation solutions in its Indian fulfilment network and is committed to investing in the market, where it has announced long-term capital commitments. PTI

West Asia, Fed to drive market movement

New Delhi: Market investors would keenly track inflation data, the US Fed interest rate decision, and trends in crude oil prices to determine further movement, analysts said. Besides, the status of the US-Iran deal signing on Sunday, trading activity of foreign investors and movement in global markets will also drive sentiments in domestic equities, experts noted. “On the domestic front, investors will monitor the release of May WPI inflation data,” Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said. PTI



@ieExplained

#ExpressExplained

If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

GLOBAL

Why Trump is bringing UFC event to White House lawns

Kartikeya Bhattacharyya
New Delhi, June 14

THE WHITE House is all set to host its first-ever professional sporting event as part of celebrations marking America's 250th year of independence.

The Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC), the world's largest mixed martial arts (MMA) organisation, is holding the 'UFC Freedom 250' on June 14 (Monday morning India time), which is not only the US Flag Day but also President Donald Trump's 80th birthday.

The White House's South Lawn, which usually hosts diplomatic gatherings, has been transformed into a 4,000-seater makeshift arena with a caged ring at its centre. Another 80,000 people are expected to view the blend of striking and grappling from an adjoining ground called the Ellipse. Critics have questioned whether the event fits the occasion.

Trump's long association

The major driver is Trump's long-standing relationship with the UFC and its president, Dana White.

In 2001, back when MMA was viewed by many as a violent bloodsport and struggled to secure venues, Trump stepped in to host UFC events at the Trump Taj Mahal casino in Atlantic City. An avid fan of combat sports, Trump also launched a short-lived MMA promotion.

White would later become one of Trump's strongest allies. Their relationship deepened during the Covid-19 pandemic, when Republican-controlled Florida allowed the UFC to resume hosting events.

Following the attack on the US Capitol by Trump supporters in January 2021, UFC events increasingly became one of the few major public spaces where Trump continued to receive enthusiastic receptions. White also encouraged Trump's outreach to younger audiences through podcasts and internet personalities.

Trump's appearances at UFC events have since become regular

TIMING CRITICAL

- The event comes as Trump faces scrutiny over his ties with sex offender Jeffrey Epstein and his war against Iran.
- It also coincides with a steep slide in Trump's approval ratings ahead of the midterm elections in November.

spectacles. The White House event comes as Trump faces mounting scrutiny over his ties with convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein and his war against Iran, which has set off an economic crisis. It also coincides with a steep slide in Trump's approval ratings ahead of the mid-term elections in November.

Draped in patriotism

UFC is promoting Freedom 250 as the biggest event it has ever staged. But more than its star-studded line-up, the fight card has attracted attention for its overtly patriotic imagery. Six of the seven bouts feature at least one American fighter. One of the fighters on the card, featherweight Steve Garcia, was a close friend of the assassinated far-right figure Charlie Kirk.

Much of the audience is expected to comprise members of the US military, as tickets have not been put up for public sale. The event follows multiple UFC training sessions conducted for FBI agents this year. On June 11, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and White signed an MoU to use the UFC as a tool of American diplomacy, with fighters and senior executives to serve as cultural ambassadors overseas.

Criticism from fighters

The political nature of Freedom 250 has drawn criticism from within and outside the MMA world. Current UFC middleweight champion Sean Strickland said he would have been willing to fight if fans were allowed to attend, adding that he did not want to participate merely to "go hang out with the Epstein list". Former UFC lightweight title challenger, Gray Maynard, also criticised it.

White, however, has rejected accusations that the event is political, insisting that anyone who loves America would appreciate it. But the flagship event scheduled for June 14 may be exactly the kind of political pageantry the US President needs to secure a major public relations win.

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

'Site of aspiration and exploitation', what India needs to guard in AI growth path



EXPERT EXPLAINS

PETRA MOLNAR

LAWYER AND ANTHROPOLOGIST WHO STUDIES AI AND SURVEILLANCE

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE (AI) is increasingly being framed as a route to economic growth, strategic autonomy, and national power. But what happens when the costs of that ambition are borne by workers, communities and public resources that remain largely invisible?

The "AI Resist List" seeks to answer that question. The project documents global efforts to challenge and reshape the growing influence of AI across areas ranging from

labour and data extraction to surveillance and digital infrastructure.

Petra Molnar, who is part of the project, told **Anagha Jayakumar** why narratives of AI-driven growth can obscure questions of accountability.

Many countries, including India, are embracing AI as a pathway to growth, competitiveness and national power. How did AI adoption become such a widely shared political goal?

The story of AI as a national imperative is, at its core, a story about the seductiveness of technological shortcuts. For governments navigating post-colonial legacies, widening inequality, and the anxieties of geopolitical irrelevance, AI offers a way to skip the messy, slow work of structural transformation and arrive at a future that looks like growth through algorithmic efficiency. The US and China modelled this playbook aggressively, and the pressure to follow has been enormous in the so-called AI Arms Race, with countries jostling for AI supremacy.

What the AI Resist List reveals is that this "AI as development" framing is itself a form of narrative power. It is one of the four pillars we document: Resist, Refuse, Reclaim, and Reimagine. The narrative infrastructure of AI — the stories told about what AI is for, who it serves, and what progress looks like — is as material as the data centres and chip supply chains. Countries like India have absorbed not just the technology but the idea that power in the 21st century requires AI dominance, and that resistance stands in the way of progress.

This framing obscures what drives these decisions: defence procurement interests, surveillance state consolidation, investor capture of public infrastructure, and the very concrete political utility of appearing modern and as an "AI Leader".

The list breaks AI power into

interconnected pillars: labour, infrastructure, surveillance, data, and narrative. India appears in all of them. What does India's position say?

India's appearance across all the pillars is no coincidence. AI power is assembled through extraction at multiple levels, and no country is simply a victim or a beneficiary. India occupies a revealing position: it is simultaneously a site of exploitation and a site of aspiration.

On labour, India supplies much of the invisible workforce that makes AI systems legible. On infrastructure, data centres are being pitched as development anchors while drawing on scarce water and electricity. On surveillance and data, facial recognition systems, networked CCTV, and the vast reserves generated through Digital India raise significant questions about oversight and consent.

Thus, AI power is not assembled in Silico

con Valley and then shipped outward. It is assembled through relationships that are extractive and unequal. AI's global supply chains depend on hierarchies that have structured capital for generations.

AI companies often present data centres and computer infrastructure as engines of development. What questions should communities and policymakers ask?

In my mind, the single most important question is: who bears the costs, and who receives the benefits? For example, data centres consume vast quantities of water for cooling and electricity that, in water-stressed and power-insecure regions, comes directly at the expense of households, farmers, and small businesses. The promised benefits of jobs, tax revenue and a stronger position in the digital economy are unevenly distributed.

Policymakers should ask whether commitments are binding, whether communities can refuse or renegotiate projects,

whether environmental and social impacts have been independently assessed, and whether data governance and technology transfer arrangements benefit locals.

India wants strategic autonomy in AI while remaining dependent on American chips, cloud providers and frontier models. Are genuinely sovereign AI ecosystems possible for countries outside the US and China?

The infrastructure that underpins AI, from frontier models to semiconductor supply chains, is so concentrated that formal sovereignty coexists with profound dependence. A country can localise data and build its own large language model while still relying on foreign cloud infrastructure and Nvidia chips subject to US export controls.

This is not a reason to abandon sovereignty as a goal, but it is a reason to be precise about what sovereignty would actually mean. The most achievable forms of AI sovereignty are about the capacity to regulate, audit, and refuse.

ECONOMY

India's push beyond E20 fuel: Reasons, and pitfalls



ANIL SASI

THE CENTRE last week exempted higher ethanol-petrol blends (22%-30% ethanol) from central excise duty, putting their tax treatment on a par with the 20% ethanol blend (E20) that's the standard at pumps.

The government has also proposed amendments to recognise 85% ethanol-blended fuel and 100% ethanol fuel under the Central Motor Vehicles Rules.

Both measures signal the government's intent to prepare the country's vehicular and fuel ecosystems for the next stage of ethanol adoption. But they have differing implications.

The first measure — the transition from E20 fuel to higher blends — is aimed at most petrol cars.

The second move — the draft amendment to recognise E85 and higher fuel — targets an entirely new category called flex fuel vehicles. Such vehicles are designed to operate on varying blends of petrol and ethanol but are still some way away from being widely introduced to the Indian market.

For now, it is the first proposal that has caused concern among carmakers and motorists — especially considering their experience with the initial transition to the E20 ethanol blend from E10.

The problems for consumers...

Last year, India achieved 20% ethanol blending in petrol, five years before target. E20 fuel, denoting 80 parts petrol to 20 parts of ethanol, is now the standard petrol variant nationwide.

For people with vehicles E10-certified or older, the transition to E20 came in just three years, with little warning of the pitfalls.

There are multiple problems with using a higher ethanol blend in petrol for engines not designed for them.

ENGINE DAMAGE: Ethanol has a higher content of water, which is corrosive. So, E20 or higher ethanol blends could damage the parts of the internal combustion engine (ICE). This is especially true for older engines and the ones used on two-wheelers, where high-grade aluminum or steel casts are not used for the engine block.

MILEAGE: Many customers had flagged a drop in mileage after the E10 to E20 shift. The drop could be between 5-12%, depending on when the car was manufactured. The

HOW A FLEX FUEL CAR IS POWERED

THE ECM: Controls the fuel mixture, ignition timing, and emissions system; detects and troubleshoots problems.

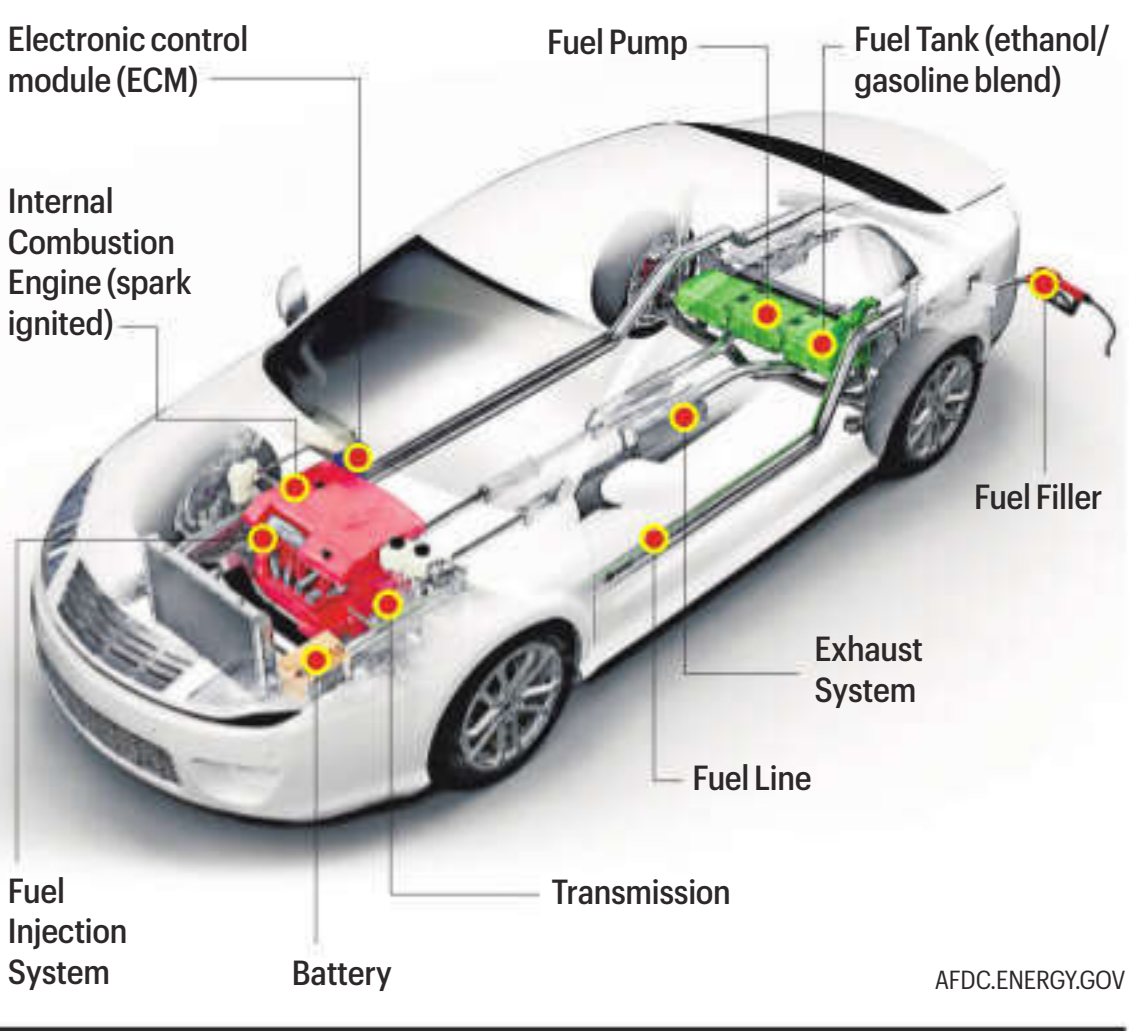
FUEL FILLER: A nozzle from a fuel dispenser attaches to the receptacle on the vehicle to fill the tank.

FUEL INJECTION SYSTEM: Introduces fuel into the engine's combustion chambers for ignition.

FUEL LINE: A metal tube or flexible hose (or a combination of these) transfers fuel from the tank to the engine's fuel injection system.

FUEL PUMP: A pump that transfers fuel from the tank to the engine's fuel injection system via the fuel line.

FUEL TANK (ETHANOL/ GASOLINE BLEND): Stores fuel on board the vehicle to power the engine.



AFDC.ENERGY.GOV

Petroleum Ministry, however, has said that the drop in mileage would be "marginal".

THE ONLY OPTION: Vehicle owners in India currently do not have an option to choose different fuels at the petrol pump, unlike their counterparts in Brazil — a country that has successfully and structurally integrated ethanol with its automobile ecosystem. Brazilian law, unlike India, also provides for a discount for higher ethanol blends.

IGNITION ISSUE: Regular ICE cars running on higher ethanol blends are hard to start on winter mornings because ethanol burns at a higher temperature than petrol.

EXPONENTIALLY WORSE PERFORMANCE: While a fuel with 10% ethanol (E10) makes little difference to a car's performance, anything above is said to cause problems in engines not specifically built for it. And this performance worsens exponentially as the blending levels increase. The Petroleum Ministry has said that these concerns around higher ethanol blends are not backed by "scientific evidence".

A senior technical expert at a major automaker acknowledged that there are no conclusive studies on the long-term impact of blended fuel on non-compliant vehicles. But the expert also said it could definitely have an impact on the engine's life, its various rubber parts, valves and piston heads, among others.

"In case of this new transition too, the

Brazil's way

Brazil's ethanol programme, which kicked-off in the 1970s, was in response to the uncertainties of the oil market.

- At nearly every petrol pump in Brazil now, people have the option to either choose between blended petrol, which typically includes 27-32% ethanol, and E100, which is pure hydrous ethanol. Brazil also got carmakers to usher in flex fuel cars.

consumer will likely end up bearing the brunt of any drop in fuel efficiency. For older vehicles, there is the added question over vehicle damage due to the high ethanol mix. That too is left to the consumer," a representative of an auto manufacturing association said.

...and for automakers

The E25 transition will require additional engineering and validation work around engine calibration, fuel-system durability, corrosion resistance and material compatibility. All this, just months after the E20 transition.

Vehicle costs will increase and likely fall on the consumer.

Carmakers have called for greater policy clarity and alignment before higher ethanol blends can be rolled out at scale.

Beyond that, in private, they're willing to talk about some anomalies in this E20 to E25 transition.

"Some of the concerns have been conveyed, especially through (auto) industry representatives. Indications are that the transition towards a base fuel having a higher blend of ethanol (above E20) is likely to happen, alongside the progressive roll-out of the E85-E100 fuels," a senior auto industry executive told *The Indian Express*.

Oil marketing companies (OMCs) such as Indian Oil and Bharat Petroleum, too, will face challenges. A government source

DEFENCE

AN-32: Soviet-origin transport aircraft, the IAF's workhorse

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 14

FIVE PERSONNEL of the Indian Air Force (IAF) were killed Saturday when a military transport aircraft, the Antonov AN-32, crashed during landing at Jorhat in Assam. One other person on board the aircraft has been rescued and is undergoing treatment.

This is the third major crash of an AN-32 over the past decade. The two other crashes have killed 42 IAF personnel.

What is the AN-32?

Bought in 1984 from the erstwhile Soviet Union, the AN-32s have served as the IAF's critical workhorse. The IAF has employed it as a tactical transport aircraft since its induction into the force.

The AN-32 is a twin-engine turboprop aircraft and can carry a maximum weight of 27 tonnes at a maximum speed of 530 km per hour. It can carry up to 6.7 tonnes of cargo or 50 passengers, making it the pre-

ferred choice for transport of men and cargo across different terrain.

The aircraft can cover small to medium ranges and can operate from far-flung airfields with minimum ground infrastructure, enabling it to play critical roles during a conflict, especially in the mobilisation of men and material and with its limited bombing role.

It has also been used for paratrooping operations. During the Kargil War with Pakistan in 1999 and subsequently in Operation Parakram in 2001-02, it played a critical role in transporting personnel and cargo to border areas through multiple sorties.

Modernisation programme

After an AN-32 crashed in 2009, India signed a \$400-million contract with Ukrainian manufacturer Antonov to upgrade most of the IAF's 105 AN-32s through overhaul of airframes and turboprop engines. The programme also involved fitting the platforms with advanced navigation



The Antonov AN-32. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

and communication equipment.

The programme, however, stalled after Russia formally annexed the Crimea region in 2014. Subsequently, India and Ukraine agreed to resume the upgrades, with Kyiv having developed some alternatives to the Russian-made systems on the aircraft. The upgrade was under way at the IAF's base repair depot (BRD) in Kanpur, with equipment transferred from Ukraine. About half

of the planes had been modernised in Ukraine, and 38 have been at the BRD.

Safety record

The AN-32 is considered among the most reliable transport aircraft in the IAF's inventory. But the crash in Jorhat is the third major one since 2016.

On July 22, 2016, an AN-32 went missing while flying over the Bay of Bengal, from Tambaram Air Force Station, Chennai, to Port Blair, killing 29 people on board. The wreck was traced years later.

Then on June 3, 2019, an AN-32 crashed in the hilly terrain when it was heading to Mechuka in West Siang district of Arunachal Pradesh, near the border with China, killing 13 people on board. The wreck was found over a week after the aircraft went missing.

There was another major crash on June 10, 2009, when an IAF AN-32 crashed at around the same place in Arunachal Pradesh, killing all 13 people on board.

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Supp may hasten Alzheimer's

A WIDELY used supplement marketed for joint pain relief may be linked to faster progression of Alzheimer's disease, according to new research from the University of Florida. The study found that people with mild cognitive impairment, who reported taking glucosamine, were more likely to progress to dementia than those who did not use it. Researchers also uncovered evidence suggesting that glucosamine may interact with biological processes in the brain that are already disrupted in Alzheimer's disease. The finding adds to evidence that metabolic dysfunction plays a role in neurodegenerative diseases.



Collagen's benefits for ageing

A MAJOR review of nearly 8,000 participants at Anglia Ruskin University found that collagen supplements can improve skin health and ease osteoarthritis symptoms, especially when taken consistently over longer periods. Researchers also found modest benefits for muscle and tendon health. But the results challenge claims that collagen enhances sports performance, as it showed little effect on recovery or post-workout soreness. Collagen supplementation was linked to modest improvements in muscle mass, muscle structure, and tendon structure, helping with ageing.



A drug for kidney health

A TRIO of major studies at the George Institute for Global Health found that finerenone may protect the kidneys and heart in far more people than previously thought. The drug significantly slowed kidney disease progression and reduced the risks of kidney failure, heart failure, cardiovascular death and overall mortality. Researchers saw benefits not only in patients with diabetes but also in those with non-diabetic kidney disease, a group with limited treatment options. Finerenone was generally well tolerated. CKD is projected to become the fifth leading cause of premature death globally by 2040.



Eating chips slows you down

A NEW study suggests that eating more ultra-processed foods could make it harder to stay focused and may contribute to factors linked to dementia, even among people who otherwise follow healthy diets. Researchers from Monash University, the University of São Paulo, and Deakin University analysed dietary and cognitive data from more than 2,100 middle-aged and older Australian adults who did not have dementia. Every 10 per cent increase in ultra-processed food (equal to a daily packet of chips) consumed resulted in a distinct and measurable drop in a person's ability to focus.



Fasting can fight gum disease

PEOPLE WHO follow a short-term low-calorie diet may experience lower levels of inflammation associated with gum disease, according to new research from King's College London. The study suggests that lifestyle changes could play an important role alongside plaque removal and good oral hygiene in managing gum disease. Although fasting has previously been linked to reduced inflammation throughout the body, this is the first study to show a connection between fasting and markers of gum disease. The findings add to growing evidence that oral health and overall health are closely connected.





PUBLIC HEALTH
DR VINOD K PAUL
FORMER MEMBER (HEALTH AND NUTRITION), NITI AAYOG

How India cut child deaths faster than the world

Under-five and neonatal mortality fell sharply in a decade

INDIA'S EMERGENCE as a global leader in reducing child mortality is among the most significant public health achievements of the past decade. According to the United Nations Inter-Agency Group for Child Mortality Estimation (UN IGME) 2025 Report, released in March 2026, India recorded a 41 per cent decline in under-five mortality and a 37 per cent decline in neonatal mortality between 2014 and 2024, substantially higher than the global reductions of 18 per cent and 15 per cent respectively.

The UN SDG (Sustainable Development Goal) targets for Under-five Mortality Rate (U5MR) and Neonatal Mortality Rate (NMR) are 25 and 12, per 1000 live births, respectively. With U5MR of 28 and NMR of 18 already in 2024 (as per Sample Registration System), India is poised to attain these targets before the 2030 timeline. Delivering equitable health services across remote tribal belts, difficult terrains, densely populated urban settlements and socio-economically vulnerable communities remains one of the most complex public health challenges globally. Yet India has demonstrated that large-scale improvements in child survival are achievable when services are systematically organised around the needs of mothers and children, supported by strong public systems, digital accountability and frontline health workers. Targeted attention to aspirational districts and blocks has further helped reduce inequities and accelerate progress in historically underserved regions.

At the core of this transformation lies a deliberate shift from episodic interventions to a structured life-cycle approach anchored in the Reproductive, Maternal, Newborn, Child and Adolescent Health plus Nutrition (RMNCAH+N) strategy. Over the past decade, India has operationalised this framework by progressively aligning maternal health, newborn care, immunisation, nutrition and early childhood development into a single continuum of care. The journey begins with maternal health. Healthy pregnancies form the foundation of child survival. India has strengthened antenatal care, maternal nutrition, early risk detection and referral systems to ensure timely and preventive care during pregnancy. As per the National Family Health Survey (NFHS)-6 report released recently, 76.2 per cent of mothers received antenatal care in the first trimester. Institutional deliveries increased from 88.6 per cent in NFHS-5 to 90.6 per cent in NFHS-6, while births attended by skilled health personnel rose from 89.4 per cent to 91.3 per cent during the same period. These improvements reflect strengthened access to skilled care at critical stages of childbirth.

The most vulnerable period for survival begins immediately after birth. More than 1,100 special newborn care units and neonatal intensive care units, supported by 2,868 newborn stabilisation units, now provide specialised care to over 15 lakh sick and small newborns annually. Mother-newborn care units (MNCUs) are enabling zero separation of mothers and infants, strengthening breastfeeding practices, and promoting kangaroo mother care, thereby improving survival among low-birth-weight babies. These care practices, combined with strengthened infection prevention and clinical protocols, have also contributed to a reduction in mortality due to neonatal infections, including sepsis.

Newborn care has become more integrated. The hub-and-spoke model strengthens referral linkages between tertiary hospitals, district facilities and peripheral centres, ensuring timely access to appropriate care. A dedicated facility-based newborn care digital platform now tracks every admitted newborn, enabling structured follow-up and improved accountability. Universal screening for visible birth defects at birth has further strengthened early detection and clinical interventions.

Continuity of care beyond facilities remains central to survival gains. More than ten lakh Accredited Social Health Activists (ASHAs) provide scheduled home visits under home-based newborn care, ensuring post-discharge support for families. As per the NFHS 6 Report, postnatal care coverage within two days of delivery increased from 78.0 per cent in 2019-21 to 85.3 per cent in 2023-24. Full immunisation coverage among children aged 12-23 months increased from 76.6 per cent to 82.6 per cent. The scale-up of rotavirus vaccine coverage from 36.4 per cent to 85.4 per cent of routinely strengthened protection against severe diarrhoeal disease, while the introduction of pneumococcal conjugate vaccine has expanded protection against pneumonia and invasive bacterial infections.

Nutrition remains a critical determinant of child survival and long-term human capital. NFHS-6 shows that stunting among children under five declined from 35.5 per cent in 2019-21 to 29.3 per cent in 2023-24, while severe wasting reduced from 7.7 per cent in 2019-21 to 5.5 per cent in 2023-24. Childhood overweight also declined from 3.4 per cent in 2019-21 to 1.3 per cent in 2023-24. At the community level, the Mother and Child Protection Card has evolved into a comprehensive tool for growth monitoring. India's child survival journey is increasingly a global public health exemplar from which many developing countries can learn.

(Views are personal)

Anonna Dutt

WITH CANCER incidence on the rise — and the cost of newer therapies keeping them out of reach of most — there has been a race to develop CAR-T cell therapies for Indian patients. Among researchers dedicated to lengthening the life span of survivors are those sitting in an unassuming building in the heart of Noida, who have been working tirelessly through the pandemic to develop therapies that are not just cost-effective but also innovative.

CAR T cell therapies — or chimeric antigen receptor T cell therapies — collect a patient's own immune T cells, re-engineer them in the laboratory, multiply them and then infuse them back into the patient. These engineered T cells can then identify the cancer cells, attach themselves to them, ultimately destroying them. The latest innovation is about making them more persistent against a relapse.

Cellogen Therapeutics is set to begin human trials soon for its novel CAR-T therapy at Christian Medical College-Vellore. It can not only fight a patient's current cancer but also create a memory in the body's immune system so that it can keep fighting it off whenever it emerges. The model has an Indian patent and a provisional US patent. This will work much like vaccines, to prevent relapse in cancer patients. Simultaneously, the researchers are also working on developing off-the-shelf CAR-T therapies — therapies that are not specifically designed for each patient.

At present, there are two indigenously developed CAR-T therapies approved for the treatment of blood cancers in India — Immuneel's Qartemi that costs around Rs 40 lakh and ImmunoAct's NexCAR19 that costs around Rs 20 lakh.

The first round of a battle

When he returned from the UK, co-founder of Cellogen Dr Gaurav Kharya understood that India needed to develop its own cell therapies to make them accessible. Cancer treatment was not his first interest, however. As a specialist of blood disorders, he wanted a way to cure sickle cell disease — a condition where the body starts producing red blood cells becoming rigid, sickle-shaped and less capable of carrying oxygen. The shape of the blood cells can also lead to blockages in blood flow, leading to acute episodes of pain, chronic pain, organ damage, anaemia, infections and strokes. He had been treating the children who suffer this pain with bone-marrow transplants.

When he started working with his co-founder and geneticist Dr Tanveer Ahmad on lentivirus — the virus that carries modified cells back to the body — his interest grew using the same to treat cancers as well. "Researchers across the world were already working on this type of therapy," he says.

Despite his busy schedule — he continues to work as a clinician at Indraprastha Apollo Hospital — he reached out to everyone working in the field to gain knowledge. "T cells are the immune system's foot soldiers. Most people don't get cancers because every day these foot soldiers identify thousands of cells that have acquired cancer-

From Noida lab, a next gen therapy that keeps cancer from coming back

Lab plans human trials for a novel CAR-T treatment that mimics vaccine-like immune memory and can make therapy affordable



Researchers at Cellogen analysing data



SCAN THE QR CODE TO READ MORE HEALTH SPECIAL STORIES

CUTTING EDGE

causing mutations and kill them. In some cases, however, some monster cells learn to dodge this identification mechanism and start proliferating," explains Dr Kharya. While T cells are generalists, antibodies are specialised and can attach to specific receptors to defend the body against infections and cancers. In cancer, receptors are proteins on or inside cells that act like docking stations. When specific molecules in the body bind to them, they send signals that tell the cancer cell to grow and multiply. Knowing which receptors a tumour has is crucial for choosing the right treatment.

The chimeric T cells are a combination of both — they are specialised foot-soldiers. They can be trained to attach to specific receptors found on the cancer cells but in large numbers.

Dr Kharya explains why his latest approach is novel. "The first-generation therapies could target the cancer cell only one-on-one, meaning each modified T cell injected into the body could kill only one cancer cell. This is very disproportionate — a patient usually has billions of cancer cells while only two or three million modified T cells are administered. So, the cancer always had the upper hand and would relapse after a few months or years even in patients in whom it worked successfully. There was

also no way to ensure that the body could start generating these cells on its own if and when the cancer relapsed," he says.

What can be a solution?

Second generation therapies are trying to ensure that the modified T cells could start replicating within the body as per the need, increasing their persistence and thereby the time for which a patient remains cancer-free. First is adding more than one target. "Some of the second-generation therapies are bi-specific, meaning they target two receptors. There are only a minuscule number of cancer cells that can escape both the targets, reducing the chances of the therapy failing after some time," says Dr Kharya. Second, ensuring that the immune system learns how to produce the modified T cells on its own.

"This is where our innovation lies. We create a memory in the immune system. We added another co-stimulatory domain to our engineered T cells, which ensures that every time these cells replicate, a number of them go to the central memory. So, even after the cancer has completely been killed, the memory persists. And, if there is a relapse, say after a couple of years, the immune system immediately recognises the cancer cells and starts producing the mod-

ified T cell," he explains.

In layman terms, it would work like a vaccine, which trains the immune system to recognise various pathogens and produce specific antibodies against them.

The phase I clinical trials of the Cellogen CAR-T therapy will start soon, probably within a month. The trial will be conducted on nine patients with acute leukaemia and nine with lymphoma. The phase II trial will be on 27 patients and in more than one trial site. These "living therapies" do not require phase III studies, so it should become available soon after these studies. The therapy is likely to cost around Rs 20 lakh.

Cellogen is, however, working on another innovation that is likely to bring down the cost of the novel therapy further.

Off-the-shelf therapies

What makes CAR-T therapy so costly is the fact that it cannot be mass-produced and needs to be created for each and every patient separately. Researchers are working to create CAR-T therapies that can multiply within the body, eliminating the need for extracting a patient's T cells and modifying them in specialised labs. This novel method can bring down the cost of treatment to around Rs 8 lakh. "For in-vivo CAR-T therapies, instead of delivering the modified T cells using a virus vector, we deliver the genetic instruction for making them. This information reaches the DNA of the cells and then teaches it to make the modified T cells," says Dr Kharya. What this means is the same product can be used by anyone without concern for any reaction.

Dr Kharya adds that there is no risk of the virus, which is used to deliver the genetic instruction, becoming infective. "The real challenge is not knowing whether the genetic information delivered will be used accurately. "With these types of therapies, the biggest fear is that once you insert it, you don't know what will happen — how many on-target and how many off-target activities will take place. Now, we know that they are not that big of a concern and as an abundant precaution, monkey studies are being conducted instead of mice studies."

Cellogen has already received approval for conducting the animal studies and hopes to start the human studies for it by next year. Further, the team is trying to use this method to develop a therapy against a solid-tumour cancer, which is a big challenge for India — triple negative breast cancer. This type of cancer not only affects younger people and is more aggressive, it also lacks all three receptors that are used by commonly used breast cancer therapies, making its treatment difficult.

CAR-T treatment for solid cancers remains elusive — while several CAR-T therapies have been approved for the treatment of blood cancers, none has been approved for the treatment of solid-tumour cancers. This is because they come with their own set of challenges — the markers for solid cancer can be found on other healthy cells of the body as well, the molecular makeup of the cancer can be different within the same patient, and unlike blood cancers, they are not where the T cells are, making elimination difficult. Dr Kharya is now looking to solve this challenge that, if successful, could help women survive aggressive breast cancers.

• DECODING A STUDY

Early menopause before 40 raises heart attack, stroke risk

Study shows 43.6% Indian women, who had early menopause, are at elevated risk of heart attack

Anuradha Mascarenhas

WOMEN WHO go through menopause (end of a reproductive cycle) before the age of 40 are significantly more likely to develop serious cardiovascular conditions such as heart attacks and strokes, according to a new study published in *The Lancet Obstetrics, Gynaecology & Women's Health*.

Using data from more than 111,600 women across 26 countries, researchers found that women with early menopause — defined as menopause between the ages of 40 and 44 — face a 30-40 per cent higher risk of cardiovascular disease compared to women who reach menopause at around age 45. The findings from India were particularly striking. Of the 7,872 Indian women included in the study, 1,445 (18.4 per cent) had experienced premature menopause. The average age of menopause was 44.6 years, while 1,991 women (25.3 per cent) had experienced early menopause.

Overall, 3,436 women (43.6 per cent) had experienced either premature or early

menopause. Dr K. Srinath Reddy, Chancellor of the PHFI Institute of Public Health Sciences, who was not associated with the study, said that women are protected against heart and blood vessel disease before menopause because of the effects of female sex hormones on blood lipids, body fat distribution, inflammatory markers and vascular reactivity. "After menopause, this protection wears off and the risk of heart attack increases to levels seen in men," Dr Reddy told *The Indian Express*.

The findings are based on the Prospective Urban Rural Epidemiologic (PURE) study, a multinational study that assessed 125,073 women aged 35-70 years from 28 countries for an association between age at menopause and cardiovascular events, including heart attack, stroke and heart failure. Researchers collected medical histories on diabetes and hypertension, while cardiovascular risk factors were assessed using the INTERHEART score, which includes smoking, lipid levels, hypertension, diabetes, obesity, diet, physical activity, alcohol con-



GETTY IMAGES

Environmental pollutants, smoking and diabetes are associated with early menopause

sumption and psychosocial factors. The score comprises easily measurable and modifiable risk factors that account for more than 90 per cent of the risk of heart attack globally across regions and ethnic groups.

According to Dr Reddy, premature menopause can result from a range of factors, many of which are increasingly prevalent in low- and middle-income countries. Stress, tobacco use, smoking, unhealthy diets high in refined carbohydrates and low in legumes and fruits, inadequate sleep, and both very low and excessively high levels of

physical activity can all increase the likelihood of early menopause.

He added that environmental pollutants that act as endocrine disruptors, as well as heat exposure linked to global warming, may accelerate ovarian ageing and increase the risk of menopause occurring earlier. Diabetes is associated with a higher likelihood of premature menopause. "Even second-hand smoke from male smokers results in passive smoking that can lead to early menopause," Dr Reddy said. "The neuro-endocrine axis and gut-brain axis, which are sensitive to dietary and environmental exposures, play a role in altering the calendar of menopause."

He noted that many of these adverse exposures are becoming more common in countries such as India, even as cardiometabolic diseases continue to rise. At the same time, gender differences in the risk of coronary heart disease are narrowing. "Many of these exposures are modifiable through health-protective personal behaviours that are encouraged and enabled by supportive public policies. If women do not age prematurely under the assault of socio-environmental stresses, their hearts will be protected against heart attacks. This calls for a broader societal commitment to women's health," Dr Reddy said.

NEWSMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM

WHY KIRAN RIJJU

Kiren Rijju, Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs and Minority Affairs, is seen as one of the most vocal leaders in the BJP-led NDA government which has just completed two years of its third term. He plays a crucial role as the government is keen on passing the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, also known as the Delimitation Bill, 2026, which failed to get the two-third majority in the Lok Sabha in April. The ruling dispensation is trying to muster support for its key reform legislation in the new political landscape that is going through a realignment process after the recent Assembly polls

Liz Mathew: As the NDA marks 12 years in governance, recently the Constitution Amendment Bill was defeated in Parliament. Were you prepared for this?

We were very upset that the Women's Reservation Bill was defeated.

Liz Mathew: The Women's Reservation Bill was not defeated.

Its implementation was. You can name it the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill but basically it was the implementation of women's reservation in the Lok Sabha and the Assemblies. We were upset because the actions of the Opposition parties were unexpected on two accounts. Number one, the same bill, the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam in 2023, supported by all the Opposition parties, was passed unanimously. And it was mentioned that the Bill will be implemented on the basis of the population census conducted after 2026. Since the caste-based census is going to take a long time, we have to refer to the 2011 census, so that requires amendment. Without that, we can't incorporate the necessary things to be included in the implementation of the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam Bill. Secondly, it is not that we brought the Bill suddenly, we had consultations with all the stakeholders, especially the bigger political parties. Except for the Congress, Trinamool and AAP, the other parties have joined, they have agreed.

Liz Mathew: The main contention of the Opposition parties was that you had not called an all-party meeting. Then you brought the Bill two days ahead of the session and that you did not mention about what you had promised to other parties which is the 50 per cent increase, you only mentioned the number of seats in the Lok Sabha. The Congress had said that they were ready if you delinked it from the women's reservation. What do you have to say?

While the first part of the Parliament session was on, we had started the consultation process. The demand for all party meetings was much later. Mallikarjun Kharge wrote three letters to me. The first demanding the all-party meeting be kept for later, when I already completed the consultation with most of the political parties, with DMK, Samajwadi Party, Shiv Sena, with all other parties. What is the point of calling for all-party meeting when we have finished the consultation process? We met 70 per cent of the Opposition parties. The Congress then out of blue asked for an all-party meeting, that was basically a ploy.

Liz Mathew: What is the way forward?

I can't commit anything right now because unless it's placed in the Cabinet and a decision is taken.

Liz Mathew: With the CBSE evaluation and the NEET paper leak, many students have been affected. Has the government failed in this?

You cannot say that the government has failed. But we should concentrate on how to get the students justice. There are so many steps taken from re-evaluation to re-assessment. Now, portals have being created. Many students have registered and have sent in their queries. Despite cyber attacks, the government has taken necessary steps to fix them. The primary objective is to make the system transparent so that in future such frauds are prevented. If we all sit together and ensure that reforms take place, the careers of students will be better.

Liz Mathew: Don't you think that somebody from the government has to be held accountable for this?

First of all, at any level, if a person has made a deliberate attempt to hijack the system, action should be taken. To build the confidence of the students, the CBSE chairman and the secretary have been shifted. New proposals to change the system are in place. The education minister has already said that he takes moral responsibility. He is not running away from the error, whoever has committed it, he has rather taken it up as a challenge to fix the problem. The demand for the resignation of the education minister is an effort to drive political mileage out of the problems faced by the students.

Manoj CG: Had the BJP been in the Opposition, would you not have demanded the resignation of the education minister?

There is a difference. If the fraud is committed by the minister or minister's staff, then the minister is responsible. But if a problem happens within an autonomous body, then they are answerable. The CBSE is an autonomous body. Then there is NTA, these are not directly monitored by the minister daily.

When we were in Opposition, every month there were scams against ministers. In the last 12 years, there is no direct charge against any minister for taking bribes or commission or manipulation of the system... So, bifurcate the difference between what Congress did and what we have done.

Shyamalal Yadav: Manmohan Singh had launched a 15-point programme in the interest of minorities and in 2014-15 there were 8.71 per cent



ON THE DELIMITATION BILL

When the first part of the Parliament session was on, we had started the consultation process... We met 70 per cent of the Opposition parties. The Congress then out of blue asked for an all-party meeting, that was a ploy



ON ATTACKS ON MINORITIES

If there are incidents against churches, there are incidents against Hindus, in Kashmir, Assam, Bengal, Karnataka... it can happen anywhere. One incident doesn't make it a national one

than MPs. The burden will come to the state exchequer on the payment and other facilities for the elected members. India, as a growing country, will not have difficulties in carrying out this responsibility. Of course, smaller states will have a larger burden but for bigger states it would not be much of a matter because it will cost a few crores in terms of salaries. An MP draws only one lakh as salary. I don't get a salary as a minister so there's not much of a burden.

As for the total representation and why it is necessary, in places like Uttar Pradesh, an MLA represents nearly four lakh people which is equivalent to 20 MPs in Europe. If the elected representative is unable to cover the entire area or meet people, it is a deficiency which must be taken care of.

In fact, if you are concerned about democracy then you should be questioning why only 850.

Tista Roy Chowdhury: What are your thoughts on the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) and the protests they have been organising?

Anybody can create a political party. But don't undermine and ridicule Indian democracy. The CJP only poses a challenge to the Congress party. They need to worry.

Vandita Mishra: The Congress has three state governments in the country and the Left has none. So why does it pose such a formidable challenge for the BJP in the 12th year of its power?

The Congress and Left should understand that the people of India do not buy their argument or their leadership. Despite that they say that Modi is a failure and the BJP is a failure. They should stop running this campaign that the government has failed. People have accepted the government... They are powerful in paper and on social media but we are countering them.

Liz Mathew: But does Opposition have a space in democracy?

If they are rejected by the people, how are we to be blamed for that?

Damini Nath: In the last many years, we've seen that though productivity is high during Parliament, the number of bills that go to committees and that are passed in a short duration is increasing. Is this a cause of concern and how would you address this?

You are right in certain aspects. The numbers of bills passed in the last few years, of course, the numbers are not less but the amount of time given for discussion is less because from the beginning (of the session) the Congress party jumps into the Well of the House and starts shouting 'Your prime minister is a thief', they keep shouting slogans.

The bills are, therefore, becoming the victims of this. How are the bills to be referred to if discussions are not allowed? First of all, you have to allow debates and discussions. During that time, if necessary, you send or refer the bills to the Parliamentary standing committee or JPC. That has to be decided by the House. But the moment the House resumes it is adjourned again because MPs come with placards.

Shalini Langer: You've said that they hold placards in front of the prime minister but the PM is rarely there in the House.

For any important debate or discussion, the Prime Minister is always there. But he cannot sit in the House throughout. He has to run the affairs of the government. Even ministers have got a roster. I decide which minister should be present on which date in which House and at what time. These are all decided by the parliamentary affairs minister.

Liz Mathew: The NDA government is entering its 13th year. When it comes to governance, what are your real concerns?

Right now, it's the West Asia crisis. It is a reality that 80 per cent of our oil and gas comes through the Strait of Hormuz. The prime minister has already stated in the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha that we have diversified our energy sources. We are taking all possible steps towards a transition to green and clean energy.

Because of the West Asia crisis, the government has had to bear a significant burden. The reduction of Rs 10 in excise duty has cost us more than Rs 1 lakh crore. India is among the few countries where the increase has been only around five per cent. Despite that, Opposition parties continue to raise an outcry. In a crisis like this, everyone should support the government. It has always been the tradition that when there is an external or internal crisis, people stand with the government.

Liz Mathew: What about youth aspirations? We are seeing increasing disenchantment among young people. Doesn't that concern you?

Youth aspirations have certainly gone up. Young people in India are more aware of their needs and rights. But alongside their that, they also should be aware of their obligations and duties towards the country. Young people are the country's greatest asset and their participation is essential for India's growth.

Kiren Rijju, Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs and Minority Affairs, on the need for the Constitution Amendment Bill, attacks on minorities, why most Bills do not get passed in Parliament and the major crisis facing the government. The session was moderated by Liz Mathew, Deputy Editor



Kiren Rijju, Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs and Minority Affairs (right), in conversation with Liz Mathew, Deputy Editor, *The Indian Express* RENUKA PURI

minorities appointed in all Central government jobs. What percentage of minorities has been appointed in the Central government after 2014-15 until now?

I will not look at appointments in a few organisations. See it in totality. Minorities are better in India, 12 years after Modi ji has become the prime minister. It's the Congress and the Left ecosystem that keep hammering these slogans of minorities not being safe. *Sabka saath, sabka vikas* means every scheme is for everybody. Can anyone name a person who has left India because of religious persecution? You are maligning the character of the nation by saying that Muslims are not safe in India. Hindus and Sikhs from Afghanistan have come to India, from Pakistan, too.

When problems started in 1959 in Tibet, why did they (Tibetans) come to India? It shows that India is inclusive. It's not only because of BJP, the character of the Indian society is such. But we have made it very clear that we will not accept illegal migrants. We will not accept anybody who is creating trouble in our country.

As for appointments, deserving people wherever they are, will be appointed. We don't believe in appeasement of anybody. Our philosophy is simple, justice to all, appeasement to none. There is no deliberate attempt to bar anybody from getting appointment in any of the bodies.

Aaron Pereira: In February, the Catholic Bishops Conference of India (CBCI) wrote to the prime minister about attacks on Christians, especially during mass but nothing happened. Also, what is your response to Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) given that over 20,000 institutes have lost their licences, so far.

Aakash Joshi: And if we look at what happened after the massive win in

Bengal, Suwendu Adhikari, who became chief minister, said: 'Muslims did not vote for me, I will work for Hindus'. What do you make of such political statements?

First of all, I have a responsibility towards looking after the welfare of the minority communities, but law and order is not the subject of the minority affairs ministry. To give an example, though, just before the 2015 Delhi elections, there was news that churches were attacked in Delhi. I called the Delhi Police Commissioner who gave me the statistics: there were four incidents. I asked for incidents across three months. There were more than 300 incidents related to temples, around 150 related to *gurdwaras* and some 100 incidents related to mosques. But the news was only about churches being attacked. And then right after the Delhi election was over, there was no news. Can you



afford to run this kind of campaign in a secular country? If there are incidents against churches, there are incidents against Hindus also, like in Kashmir, in Assam, in Bengal and in Karnataka... it can happen anywhere. One incident doesn't make the incident a national one. As for FCRA, someone said it cost the BJP more than five per cent votes in Kerala. We are not doing anything for the sake of votes. A major amendment of the FCRA was done in 2010 by the UPA government. It was already in existence.

Liz Mathew: But, you are doing it seven days ahead of the election.

No. Implementation has continued. More than 20,000 FCRA were cancelled in the last 12 years... There were many cancellations but platforms are being provided. If the cancellation seems arbitrary or they have not been given enough

ON THE WEST ASIA CRISIS

The government has had to bear a significant burden because of the crisis. The reduction of Rs 10 in excise duty has cost us more than one lakh crore. India is among the few countries where the increase has been around five per cent

time to be heard, then that will violate the necessary course of justice. That will be looked into. But it is not targeted at anybody. This is not a law which is meant for any religious group. It is a law for everybody. The only thing is if a complaint is coming from the Christian community we will definitely address it, but the thing being said that the campaign is made only to target missionaries is wrong.

Srirupa Goswami: Manipur is still burning. Why is it so difficult for the government to tackle this violence that has been going on for almost three years now?

Unfortunately, Manipur has witnessed violent incidents numerous times in the past as well. The conflict between Nagas and Kukis has taken thousands of lives in the past. Any violence is unfortunate. In Manipur, they are used to being in a bunk hole for months. When BJP came to power, peace prevailed for six-seven years and the valley and hills were well connected. There was a dialogue, there was normal development taking place. Then unfortunately, violence erupted due to various reasons, largely because of mistrust between Meitei, Kukis and Nagas. As a country, we have to collectively come together, give up violence and come and sit and negotiate and learn to live with each other.

Harikishan Sharma: The government proposed to increase seats of Lok Sabha from 543 to 816, roughly an increase of 272 seats. Can you give us an idea of the financial burden it will have on the government and the people? Secondly, if the government genuinely feels that women should be given reservation, what is stopping you from giving them reservation with the present number of seats?

In almost 80 per cent of the states and union territories, MLAs have higher salary

● RESULTS
GROUP B
Qatar 1-1 Switzerland
San Francisco Stadium
GROUP C
Brazil 1-1 Morocco
New Jersey Stadium
GROUP C
Haiti 0-1 Scotland
Boston Stadium
GROUP D
Australia 2-0 Turkey
BC Place Vancouver

● MATCH SCHEDULE
GROUP H
Spain vs Cape Verde
Atlanta, 2130 hrs
GROUP G
Belgium vs Egypt
Seattle, 0030 hrs (Tuesday)
GROUP H
Saudi Arabia vs Uruguay
Miami, 0330 hrs (Tuesday)
GROUP G
Iran vs New Zealand
Los Angeles, 0630 hrs (Tuesday)
ZEE5 OTT & UNITE8 CHANNELS

Scotland marks 28-year absence with win vs Haiti

COACH STEVE Clarke made it clear he didn't enjoy his first two experiences leading Scotland during lackluster showings in the European Championship. So far the sport's biggest stage has brought him - and the Scots - a lot more luck. John McGinn deflected a shot off an opposing defender and past goalkeeper Johnny Placide in the 28th minute, and Scotland defeated Haiti 1-0 in Group C of the World Cup on Saturday. Haiti, whose only other World Cup appearance was in West Germany in 1974, is still in search of its first World Cup point. REUTERS



Nestory Irankunda celebrates after scoring for Australia. AP

Australia spoil Turkey's return to World Cup

NESTORY IRANKUNDA and Connor Metcalfe scored and Australia spoiled Turkey's return to the World Cup for the first time in 24 years with a 2-0 victory on Saturday night. Goalkeeper Patrick Beach made eight saves for the Socceroos in their group opener as FIFA President Gianni Infantino looked on. Australia was playing in its sixth straight World Cup and seventh overall. Irankunda broke through for the Socceroos in the 27th minute with a low shot while pursued by three defenders. It came less than a minute after the first-half hydration break. He celebrated by punching the corner flag in a tribute to Australian soccer legend Tim Cahill. REUTERS

De Bruyne vs Salah: 'Nice to compete like old times'

Associated Press
Renton, June 14

KEVIN DE Bruyne has accomplished plenty in his decorated career. Yet, the star Belgian midfielder does not plan to take his fourth World Cup appearance for granted. Two days ahead of Belgium's World Cup opener against Egypt, the 35-year-old De Bruyne stressed much has changed since his days as a Premier League sensation for Manchester City. Nearly two decades removed from representing his home country for the first time and 119 appearances later, the two-time Premier League player of the season considers himself grateful to do so. "It's an honour for me to still

IN HOSTILE TERRITORY

Coming up, Iran on US soil: Tension, security — and divided fans



Sandip G
New Jersey, June 14

LOS ANGELES has another name. Iranians call it Tehran-geles, home to the largest concentration of Iranians outside Iran itself. On Monday evening, it stages a football match unlike any in World Cup history: involving a country engaged in a military conflict with the host nation. Iran face New Zealand. The Iranians will cross over into the US from Tijuana the day before their games, play the match, and return to Mexico the same night. These are the logistics of war, in a tournament built

for peace. "I've been to three World Cups and they always say, once you get off the plane and enter the host country, there's just a unique atmosphere of friendliness and globalness," Mehdi Taremi, who will play in his third World Cup, said last week. "Unfortunately, I'm not feeling it right now. There's a lot of tension. You feel it in the atmosphere."

Three days ago, at this same stadium, Iran's flag was met with sustained boos from the American crowd during the opening ceremony. Players were issued visas at the eleventh hour. The team moved its camp from Arizona to Tijuana, citing unfair treatment on US soil. Fifteen federation officials were denied entry, Iran's ticket allocation was revoked, and fans who had bought seats found them cancelled. The security operation



Iranian players train in Tijuana, Mexico. They will travel to Los Angeles for their first World Cup match against New Zealand. REUTERS

around a single group-stage fixture already resembled something other than football.

The tensions had been building since December, when Iran threatened to boycott the World Cup draw after senior federation officials were denied visas. They reversed course days later, sending coach Amir Ghalenoei with

a skeleton delegation, insisting pointedly that attendance did not mean withdrawal of protest.

Outside the stadium last week, people waved pre-revolutionary Iranian flags, the lion-and-sun emblem of opposition to the Islamic Republic. FIFA banned them inside venues, a move challenged in court on

First Amendment grounds.

"For the majority of Iranians, the distinction between Iran and the Islamic Republic is very important and that's what this flag represents," Nicole Sadighi of the Institute for Voices of Liberty has been quoted as saying in media reports. "They are not supporting the regime. They're using this World Cup to express their resentment towards it."

The question of who the diaspora is cheering for has no clear answer. In 2022, after the death of Mahsa Amini, a young woman, in police custody that sparked nationwide protests, Iranians cheered their own team conceding goals in a 6-2 defeat to England. When Iran were knocked out by the United States days later, people danced in the streets of Tehran, Mashhad, Isfahan and Karaj. Raha, a 28-year-old sociologi-

cal researcher, traces the disillusionment to the players' conduct during the Woman, Life, Freedom protests.

"People were fighting in the streets, and right before the World Cup, the players were laughing, joking, taking photos looking utterly joyous. I will never forget those pictures," she told *The New Arab*. She might still watch. But a loss won't upset her, and a victory won't bring joy.

Saman, a professional runner and coach, recently invited friends over to watch the tournament. Two declined. "They said it would just cause arguments. They believe that supporting the current national team is equivalent to supporting the government," he told *The New Arab*. As a child, he says, all they needed were four stones for goalposts and a neighbour's colour TV. What was once sacred is

now contested. For Faramarz, who skipped afternoon classes to watch Iran qualify for the World Cup in 1997, the distance between then and now is not measured in years. Nearly three decades on, he is not sure he will even watch. "It truly breaks my heart," he told *The New Arab*.

The Iranians remember the victory over the United States at France 1998. They have been waiting for a sequel ever since. In Tijuana, superfans Reza Mansoor and Mostafa Pourmand, who between them have attended 11 World Cups, believe this is the best squad Iran has ever sent. "There is a really high chance we're going to advance. Best chance we've ever had."

If they do, it opens a possibility that would have seemed fictional six months ago: Iran against the United States, on American soil.

BRAZIL 1-1 MOROCCO

Vini Jr stunner earns a point, but Brazil far from frontrunners

Rusty and disjointed, the five-time world champions showed little signs of ending their long title drought

Sandip G
Mexico City, June 14

HANDS IN the pocket of his black suit, an odd choice for a sweltering day. Eyebrows raised. Carlo Ancelotti looked grimly at his troops retreating to the bench. Blowing the hair dryer is not his style of operation, after a largely tepid performance for a 1-1 draw. But his still and piercing eyes told the story, he was an unhappy man. A point gained against Brazil's stiffest adversary in the group stage is no consolation for a manager crowned with all the riches of European club football; nor would it have melted the fans' ire.

Brazil could have after all dropped all three points in an incoherent and distracted first quarter, but after equalising and pulling the game back, the five-time champions' staidness in the second half would baffle both the manager and the masses. Not that Brazil didn't strive, but there was little conviction, cutting edge or singular belief. A goal never lurked, Brazil had not the key to the ignition that would blaze Morocco. The North African country shifted between low and mid-blocks to nip any threat from blossoming. Perhaps, it was the first-match rust, but unless they upgrade their performance in the next few games, their wait for the crown could drag longer. Mere individual blitzes could not make them a front-runner.

The second half was an attritional meander to a soft conclusion, an antithesis to a nail-biting first half, sparkled by two sumptuous strikes from either side. Undaunted by the sweltering heat, Morocco waltzed, pressing relentlessly and targeting Brazil's ponderous full-backs. Five shots, but none on target or making Allison sweat,

Number Plate

59.13

● The ball was in play for 59.13 minutes in the Brazil-Morocco group stage match. It is the highest among all matches held at the World Cup till now.

were piled inside the first ten minutes. Brazil were pushed back to their own half, but the centre-back wall of Marquinhos and Gabriel repelled the early intrusions.

Morocco would rue the profigate attempts and the domination of possession that could have been better utilised. As thrilling as they were to behold, their players unflustered by the heritage of the opponents or the grandness of the stage, their midfielders passing the ball in neat triangles, the final product remained elusive. The let-off welcomed panic, with Brazil finding a foothold into the game.

Shortly after the vibrant Vinicius Junior and Igor Thiago nearly conspired a goal, Morocco broke free. Brazil were ill-equipped to deal with the pace and movements that they left far too much space behind for Brahim Diaz to produce a sublime ball to Ismael Saibari. The PSV Eindhoven forward, Saibari, nonchalantly lobbed the ball over a bemused Allison Becker, without any defensive succour from his centre-back lieutenants Gabriel and Marquinhos.

Test of Brazil's steel

The blow was as much a test of Brazil's steeliness as an interrogation of Ancelotti's tactical durability. Vinicius Jr pacified the distraught centre-backs, gestured at the crowd to raise the



Vinicius Junior celebrates after scoring Brazil's equaliser against Morocco in New Jersey. AP

decibels and in a fraction more than ten minutes, he blew his team a kiss of life with the equaliser. It was so Vinicius a moment.

It was not merely a goal, but a statement of his precocious gifts and the readiness to join the legion of great Brazilian forwards. Mid-distance in the Moroccan half, he soaked a pass from Lucas Paqueta and set off, cut in and rolled the ball to Bruno Guimaraes near the box, before he sped away to the edge of the box, receiving it back from Bruno. He turned El Aynaoui out, and unlocked a drive across

the face of the goal into the far corner. It was the kind of goal that could ignite a championship quest, infuse belief. An animated Vinicius raised his arms and blew a kiss skywards.

Inspired, Brazil enjoyed their best spell of the game leading up to half time, where they could have seized the lead but for Morocco's defiant goal-keeper Bono punching Lucas Paqueta's side-footed volley. The first act ended in high hopes of a searing sequel. It was far from absorbing, and continued to expose the failings of both sides.

The Seleccion have to ponder.

As thrilling as Morocco were to behold, their players unflustered by the heritage of the opponents or the grandness of the stage, the final product remained elusive.

The full-backs that started, Douglas Santos and Ibanez, looked rusty and were constantly out-run by Morocco's counterparts. Casemiro looked exhausted; his decision to turn down a contract extension from Manchester United looked logical, as he is beyond the rigid rigours of high-intensity football. His only purpose was to overburden fellow double pivot, Bruno. Both were outwitted and outmusced by the teenaged Ayyoub Bouaddi from Lille.

Discordance upfront would be more worrisome for Ancelotti. The Italian had pledged all his stakes on his extravagantly gifted frontmen. He altered his default 4-2-4 to a sturdier 4-2-3-1, with Igor Thiago slotted as the classical nine. The three imaginative forwards would buzz behind, and when attacking morph into a three-man frontline, Raphinha and Vinicius Junior sliding from the flanks. Perhaps, the combustible first half in the Panama friendly forced the change, against a defiant side that had stung them in Qatar.

But the plan failed gloriously. Thiago barely imposed fear, neither as a goal-scoring threat or a disruptor in the box. His replacement, Matheus Cunha, capable of designing special moments, barely fizzed. Raphinha, Barcelona's best player of the season, was uncharacteristically insipid, barely forcing a save off Bono. Late in the second half, Vinicius squared him up beautifully inside the box, only for a feeble shot that summed up Brazil's forgettable night.

A day spent addressing club vs country credentials

Sandip G
Mexico City, June 14

VINICIUS JUNIOR has heard it all and more. That he loves the club more than his country; that he cares for money rather than the crest; that he is an imposter to the lineage of the greats that have worn the jersey. Vinicius swallowed his pride; he humbly accepted his failing. Nine goals in 49 games is a grim reflection of his prowess. "I have been very bad," he had confessed after the defeat to Uruguay in the qualification campaign.

Maybe, it was the weight of the shirt, an emblem of all things beautiful about the game, a cloth that is a heritage. The number that denoted Garrincha and Jairzinho, the digit that denotes the genius on the wings. Vinicius tried as hard as he could, he devoted endless hours training with the national side; perhaps tried too hard. He would tell his skeptics: "I am sure one day I would become the player I want to be for my country, which I love more than anything else."

Brazil's source of belief

It arrived on a sweltering New York evening. His team in disarray, praying and hoping for a flush of belief, he became both a goal-scorer and talisman. The goal was beautiful; a fusion of Brazilian artistry and European ruthlessness. From his initial pass to Lucas Paqueta, to the run without the ball, to his positioning on the byline, to the pounce and snap, it was synchronised ballet. From the stands, Ronaldo winked in approval. He once famously said: "They tried to erase you, my friend. And you rocked. The best player in the world is black and Brazilian." The racism he suffered at Madrid generated strong sympathy in Brazil.

The celebrations had an understated grace. He didn't stride into rehearsed dance steps, for which he was heavily criticised in Spain, for its perceived vulgarity; he didn't leap and punch the air in angst, or put an index finger on the mouth to shush his critics. He stood and soaked the enormity of the moment.



Vinicius Junior battling it out against Achraf Hakimi. AP

ment, in how game-defining and career-altering it could be. The 25-year-old was Brazil's beating heart, the lone source of belief. The stands erupted in anticipation when he had the ball on his feet, they leapt when he swayed and shuffled past the markers. Neil El Aynaoui would remember the day he was turned over by an irresistible force, an apparition in yellow rather, where he could have done nothing else but sit and wonder.

A slice of the credit goes to Carlo Ancelotti. The Italian knew him well from their Madrid days, and he knew how and where to harness the best out of him. The bewildering changing of coaches did not help—Ancelotti is his fifth coach in four years. Systems, roles and tactics kept shifting, leaving him confused. Often, he was slotted as the centre forward; sometimes he was deputised in a free-roaming role where he was devoid of service. Ancelotti reinstated him on the left wing, granting him the freedom to cut in on his stronger foot, and use the width of the flanks. He told the press pack: "He's an extraordinary footballer, a worker and a fighter. If he hasn't produced his best for Brazil in the past, he will now."

Vinicius would know that one goal won't change perceptions. In Brazilian football, you are either a World Cup winning hero or not a hero at all. The Morocco game could be his ascent to the footballer he as well as his nation wants him to be. And now he heard what he wanted to hear too. A hero.

{ MORE ARRIVALS }

De la Fuente's continuity project arrives as favourites at World Cup

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, June 14

LUIS DE la Fuente bears little resemblance, in temperament, to Jose Mourinho. Spain's head coach possesses none of the Portuguese's rodomontade. Such is his commitment to humility that when Deportivo Alaves sacked him three months into the job, midfielder Carlos Indiano suggested it was partly because de la Fuente was too nice.

He has had one exception. When the RFEF appointed him as Luis Enrique's successor after Spain's Round of 16 exit at the 2022 World Cup, the reaction was sceptical. Enrique had arrived with a Champions League title. Julen Lopetegui had lifted the Europa League. De la Fuente had youth team trophies and an unassuming manner. Questions

at his presentation revolved around inexperience. He allowed himself, briefly, to shed the garb of modesty: "With all my humility and honesty, if there is someone who knows what the future of Spanish football is, it is me."

Nearly four years on, those words read less like bravado and more like prophecy. Spain have lost only twice in 42 games under de la Fuente, their last competitive defeat over three years ago. His win percentage is 73.81. He has won the Euros and the Nations League. The verdict is difficult to dispute.

Process has become a sacred word in Spanish coaching circles. When de la Fuente guided Spain to the 2019 Under-21 European Championship, he was more relieved at a three-year project bearing fruit than over-

whelmed by the trophy. At the heart of his process lies one principle: continuity.

Unai Simon is the clearest example. No player has made more appearances for Spain under de la Fuente than Simon, who was part of the 2015 Under-19 Euros-winning squad under the same manager. Neither David Raya's successive Premier League Golden Gloves nor Joan Garcia's Zamora Trophy have seriously threatened his place. Simon is one piece of a much larger puzzle. Rodri and Mikel Merino were his teammates in that Under-19 squad. Fabian Ruiz, Dani Olmo, Pedri and Mikel Oyarzabal played in the Under-21 Euros side.

Sixteen of the 25 players Spain have brought to America have been playing for de la Fuente since their youth days. A



Luis de la Fuente during Spain's training session. REUTERS

further six received their senior debuts under him. Had it not been working, critics would be within their rights to allege fa-

vouritism. Continuity has proven to be the foundation.

Goal machines

They have scored 125 goals under de la Fuente, averaging almost three per game. Much of that productivity comes from an unusual trio: Lamine Yamal, Mikel Oyarzabal and Nico Williams. Yamal, the youngest player to win the Euros, will be the first name any neutral reaches for.

When they look further, they find Williams, who would be the headline act in most other teams. Between two flamboyant wingers sits the industrious Oyarzabal, who rarely courts attention. His record speaks for him: 25 goals in 53 appearances.

Spain is not solely about goals. They have kept 19 clean sheets under de la Fuente, nearly

one every other game. Shielding the defence are Rodri, Spain's first Ballon d'Or winner since 1960, and Fabian Ruiz. During qualification, Spain scored 21 goals and conceded only two.

Finding flaws in this Spanish team is the needle-and-haystack exercise of world football.

History, though, offers a note of caution that deserves more than a footnote.

Of the 16 occasions where a World Cup has followed a European Championship by two years, only two nations have managed to win both tournaments. Spain would be the third. No team in the modern era has sustained this kind of dominance across back-to-back major tournaments without something — an injury, an upset, a moment of complacency — intervening.

